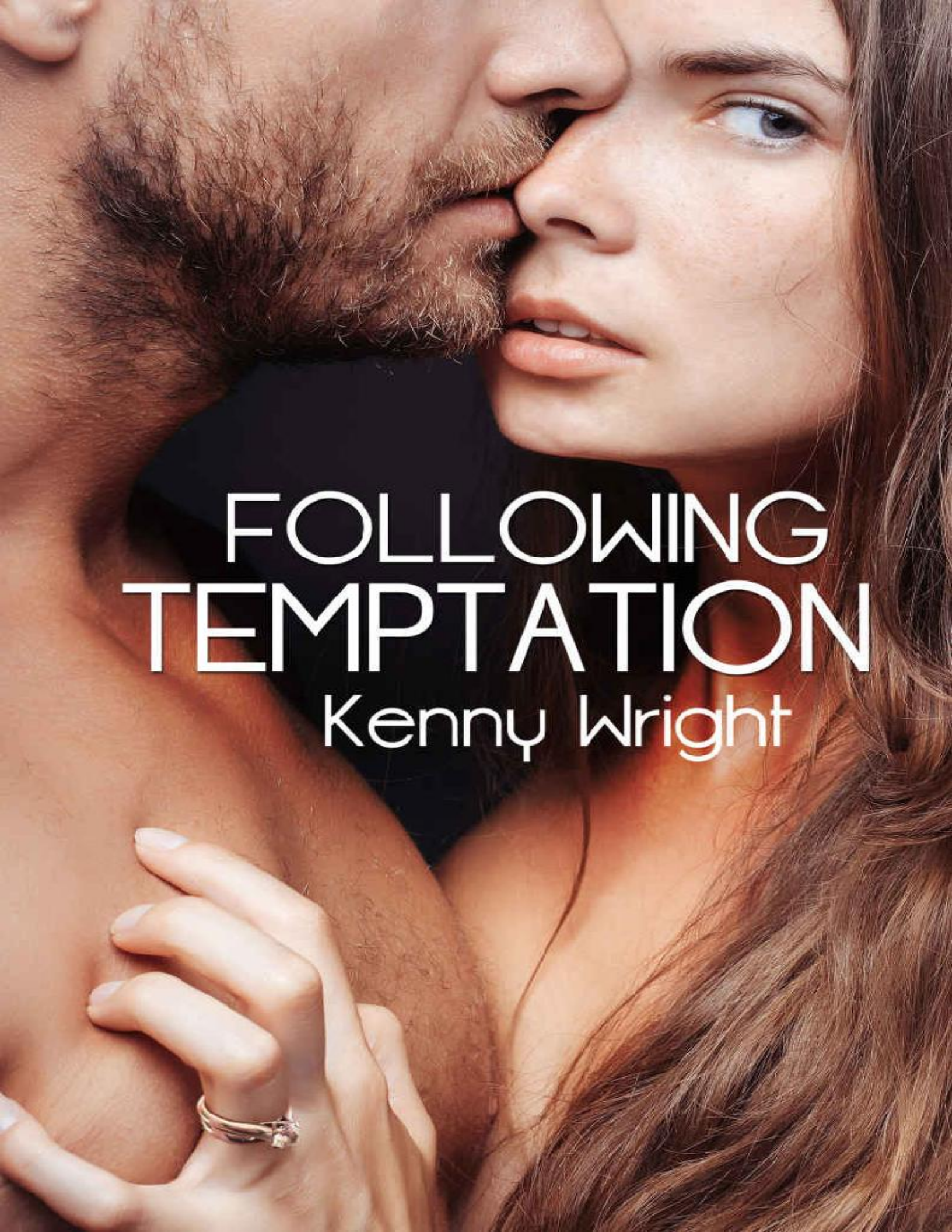




FOLLOWING TEMPTATION

Kenny Wright

Following Temptation

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Foreword

Rather than talk about the inspiration for this book (real life, although not so sexy) or how much I enjoyed writing it (I really, really did), I want to talk about shared universes. For those of you who are comic book fans (or pretenders, like me, who watch the movies and shows and read Wikipedia articles about the actual comics), you know that Marvel has done a great job with this. For those of you who don't, the gist is that movies (and shows) share characters between them. The *Iron Man* movie preceded the *Captain America* movie and the *Thor* movie, but they all teamed up in the *Avengers*.

I've done a lot of writing with Kirsten McCurran over the years. I admire the characters she creates and the books she writes. She's a sounding board like no other, and at some point, we decided to start borrowing each other's characters and burying them like easter eggs in our stories. AJ, from *Nothing Forbidden* and the *Training to Love It* books, for example, was also mentioned in Kirsten's *Hot Dates* series. It was a fun dip into a shared universe, so we decided to take it further and create a town together. And thus, Kingston was borne.

You'll read plenty about Kingston in *Following Temptation*, so I won't go into great detail about what it's like other than to say it's a generic town set just outside an unnamed city somewhere on the East Coast. It's got parks, it's got a Main Street, it's got a farmer's market and food and wine festivals, and apparently, it's got a lot of married people doing some very naughty things.

Other stories set here (all written by Kirsten, who's just too prolific) are *Bound by Two*, *Halloween Swing*, *A Swinging New Year*, and *Brooke's Revenge*. I've got others in the works, and even Max Sebastian may be getting in on the hot Kingston action. The overlaps aren't blatant, and it's not critical to read all the works to appreciate this book (or any of the above), but it should be fun for fans looking for a little extra something. So that's Kingston!

I do want to express my heartfelt gratitude to a number of people who helped me bring you the book you have in your hands (or on your Kindle or whatever). Kirsten McCurran and Ben Boswell were not only great to bounce ideas off of when I got stuck, but amazing beta readers. I only had

to completely re-write a few chapters! I have to thank my wife for taking the time to edit despite our crazy, busy lives and all that she's got going on now, and to Gary for giving it one last pass.

And, of course, all of you readers and fans and critics out there. I'm sorry that my writing has slowed down. It's not for lack of motivation, I promise, and especially not a lack of ideas. Time's just getting away from me. So thanks for being patient, and thanks for your continued support.

Now stop reading this ramble and go read what you came here to read!

Chapter 1

“I think I’m going to walk this morning,” I told my wife, Laura, as I stepped outside.

She met me at the front door, crossing her arms beneath her breasts, a bemused smile fixed across her pretty face. “Look at you. That Fitbit really *was* a good purchase.”

“Got to get my steps,” I said. I flicked my wrist, and the black fitness band lit up, showing my current step count: 403, just this morning.

“Nothing like a gadget to actually get you exercising.” Laura laughed. “Now I need to find something to gamify putting your clothes in the hamper.”

It was a joke reserved for sitcoms and couples married for fifteen years. We were the latter, and had the fourteen-year-old teenage boy to prove it.

“Har, har.” I jogged back up the stoop and kissed Laura goodbye. Unlike me, she needed no excuse or gimmick to keep up her exercise regimen. Thanks to her, we lived a healthy lifestyle. I probably would have weighed fifty pounds more if not for her healthy cooking. “Have a good day, Laura.”

“Bye, Michael.”

With an extra spring in my step, I descended the stairs, walked down our driveway, and began the half-hour walk through our suburban landscape to the train station.

I wasn’t in terrible shape, although I’ll admit that the first few days of walking like this had my knees aching more than they should. I was a 45-year-old man who worked behind a desk. I didn’t have the most active lifestyle, so time had begun to take its toll. But like I said, things could have been worse, and there was no way Laura was going to let it get there anyway.

I was smart enough to understand that her gift of the Fitbit was a not-so-subtle hint that I needed to get my act together. I used to run more. I used to love hiking. Now, I got most of my exercise watching our son run up and down the soccer field.

Our neighborhood was settled and on the upper-end of middle class, with tree-lined streets that zig-zagged seemingly haphazardly. We loved this because it meant no traffic, but it also meant there was no direct route to the train. At least not along the sidewalks. Luckily, there were plenty of paths and cut-throughs, and after a week of getting lost, I'd finally figured out the most efficient way.

I wasn't the only one to walk to the station, and I certainly wasn't the only one out on a nice morning like this. People walked their dogs, fit moms jogged in tight, eye-catching spandex, kids ambled by on their way to school. This was my life, and it was good.

Until I spotted Dane Armstrong. I hung back, slowing my pace until there was a healthy distance between the two of us. It wasn't that Dane Armstrong was a bad guy. If anything, he was the opposite. He coordinated the community jazz festival. He was the troop leader of my son's Boy Scout Troup. He had the largest vegetable garden I'd ever seen that wasn't on a farm, and he shared its output generously.

He was just too nice, if that was possible. Everyone loved Dane, but he just came off as phony or something. A guy like that couldn't be all sunshine.

And he was divorced.

Okay, so that wasn't fair, and I knew it. It wasn't the kind of thing I'd admit to anyone—not even Laura—but I guess it got me wondering. He was in his early forties, but in much better shape than me. Tall, with broad shoulders and sandy blond hair that he kept short along the sides and combed and styled in a structured wave on top—the kind of guy a “Dane” would be. The only thing missing was the Scandinavian accent. So why was such a perfect husband, and now such an eligible bachelor, alone?

Dane turned down Belvedere Street—the street I took, too, because of the cut-through over to Harris. It was curious, though, because as far as I was aware, Dane worked exclusively from home. He had no reason to catch the train. In his black shorts and Under Armor shirt, he was also dressed more for working out than working, although he wasn't carrying a gym bag or a tennis racket. In fact, he wasn't carrying anything at all.

I turned down Belvedere and pulled out my phone, pretending to read something in case he looked back and wanted to strike up a conversation. He didn't, and we continued down the rolling street with its well-kept front

lawns. The birds chirped. The breeze felt good, still carrying the freshness of spring.

Dane passed right by the small path that I used, heading further down the street. As far as I knew, there were no other cut-throughs, just a collection of cul-de-sacs and even larger homes.

I watched him, intrigued. I knew a few people who lived back here, but most of the guys would have left for work already, and as far as I knew, had nothing to do with Dane.

“Where are you going?” I mumbled to myself, following him like a balloon on a long tether.

So focused was I on Dane that I actually walked right by the entrance to my wooded path. I considered skipping it to continue tailing him. Maybe Dane knew a better way through the neighborhood, some other trail I’d missed.

Or maybe he’d turn around and wonder why in the hell I was following him and hadn’t said hello.

It was that potential confrontation, and the forced conversation that was sure to follow, that had me retracing my steps to the cut-through. Just before I took it, though, I looked back. The quiet street and its sidewalks were empty. Was there another path?

Then I saw him, up on the front porch of one of the homes—the Early’s. He knocked, the door opened, and Jessica Early appeared from inside. I paused, just a few steps down the path, and watched as Jessica smiled and said something that I couldn’t hear. She actually looked up and down the street—although not well enough to see me—before reaching out, taking Dane by the hand, and pulling him into the house with a laugh. The door shut quickly behind them.

Stunned, I stood on the trail, puzzling this one out. Why would a divorced man be visiting a married woman’s house?

Jessica Early was attractive in a June Cleaver, perfect-housewife kind of way. I’d be lying if I said that I hadn’t fantasized about her from time to time. With her pale skin and near black hair—seemingly always held in check with a headband that matched her dresses—her hourglass figure, and the way she could manage to wear bright red lipstick without looking trashy, she was the epitome of a Kingston MILF.

And she’d just pulled Dane Armstrong into her home. By the hand. And judging by the absence of Mr. Early’s Audi in the driveway, they were

now alone.

My heart started to race as I considered the scandal here. I knew Jared Early. His son played soccer with mine, so we saw one another at the games. A former Marine, now working for a defense contractor, he wasn't exactly the kind of guy who would be all that cool with his wife hanging out with a handsome, single man like Dane. More, Jessica would have known this.

I wondered what I should do here. I didn't know the Earlys all that well, and as much as I didn't care for Dane, I didn't love the idea of Jared going after him with a golf club. If this got out, I could get dragged into it as well.

So I did the only thing I really could. I shrugged, looked one last time at the house, and turned down the path toward my train. Best to just pretend that I'd seen nothing. After all, what had I really seen, right? A smile. The touching of a hand. A laugh. And that's it. It wasn't like they were slobbering all over each other in plain sight.

That should have been it. It really, really should have.

The walkway that I'd found was an old one, more than half the flagstones either buried or removed at some point. Mud and weeds covered it. It snaked in between two of the larger, more wooded properties, before dumping out along a dry creek, filled with brambles.

A squirrel darted across my path. Light filtered down through the thick foliage above, dappling the overgrown landscape. The trail turned and followed the creek, running parallel to the street I'd just left, and set far enough away from the backyards of those houses that it didn't feel like I was an intruder.

Normally, I barely looked at them. Normally, I had my head down, listening to a podcast or just letting my mind wander as I made this walk. A long bridge crossed the creek a few more houses down, and the path eventually led out to Harris and eventually the train station.

This morning, though, I couldn't help searching the backs of the houses for the Early's. I knew I shouldn't, but I couldn't not, and as I did, my heart started to race and my gut started to warm. I told myself that I was just looking to confirm that it was all innocent, that this was for my own peace of mind.

Jared and Jessica Early's property was separated from the woods by a six-foot privacy fence that hid all but the very edge of their pool. Beyond it

rose their large home, a white-painted latticework skirting the base of their screened-in porch. I'd been there exactly once, when Laura and I attended a swanky dinner party, and remembered it being as nice on the inside as on the outside.

Right now, though, I didn't care about any of that. I searched the wide windows for movement, my pulse throbbing in my ears. I didn't realize I'd crept into the foliage until a blackberry bramble slashed across my shin through my trousers.

"Ow," I hissed, reaching down to pull the vine away. This was stupid, and if anyone came along the path, the situation would just get worse.

Up close, their privacy fence didn't look as pristine. It was gray and weathered, and some of the slats were warped. One, just to the right of the wooden gate, was loose enough that I was able to look right through it.

Which was a terrible idea.

So, of course, I looked.

The green and perfectly kept lawn stretched up the gentle slope to a pool that glistened with clear water in the morning light. A mug of coffee and a newspaper sat on the patio table on the opposite side of the pool, like someone had just got up. I wondered if Jessica and Dane would be coming out here to do the perfectly innocent thing I was sure they were about to do.

I needed to leave, though, because this was bad. Also, my heart was beating so fast I worried about heart failure. I didn't need to check the Fitbit to know that it was well above resting pace.

I almost left. Almost got out of there, blissfully innocent. I glanced one last time up at the large house and nearly missed it. Nearly. But I didn't.

Jessica stepped into view in the second story window, and even in profile, I could see the mischief in her smile. With her attention fixated on something I couldn't see, she casually reached between her breasts and began unbuttoning her dress.

I stared in total disbelief. She said something, laughed, and pulled open her dress.

My breath caught. My pants grew tight. This was so very, very wrong, and yet I couldn't move.

Beneath, Jessica wore a black satin bra that lifted a pair of breasts even larger than I'd suspected, her plunging cleavage as creamy as the rest of her complexion. I could just see that she wore a matching pair of bikini panties

that complemented her wide hips and narrow waist. She was the definition of buxom.

She tipped her head, her black hair spilling over her shoulder as she nodded at something. Then, as casually as she'd shed her dress, she reached between her shoulders and unclasped her bra.

Her heavy breasts fell into view, ripe and indisputably natural. At the same time, Dane appeared at the edge of the window. He reached out, filling his hand with her left swell. Jessica sighed. He stepped closer, his other hand moving up to her neck and into her hair, pulling her into a deep kiss.

I had my evidence—a burden that I didn't even want. My curiosity was more than satisfied. Time to go. Only, I couldn't seem to will myself away. *Just a couple more seconds*, I kept telling myself. *Just a little more*. I huddled closer to the fence, to that loose slat, like it would hide me.

Dane pulled back from the kiss, stared down into Jessica's eyes, then said something. She took a sharp breath, nodded, and sank down to her knees. As she did so, she grasped the band of Dane's shorts and tugged.

Even from where I stood, at the far side of the backyard staring up through a window that was partially obscured by the glaring sun, I could tell that Dane had one hell of a cock. It curved down from between his legs, thick and not fully erect, like a ripe banana, and when Jessica reached out and wrapped both hands around it, her hands looked tiny.

Now, I'm not a self-conscious man when it comes to my own dick, and I don't make it a habit of looking at what other men pack, but outside of porn, this guy appeared to have the largest cock I'd ever seen, and it appeared to have Jessica Early enthralled.

She stroked it with both hands, mesmerized as it lifted and thickened in her grip. Dane lowered his hand into her black hair and spoke. She looked up at him, running her tongue across her plump, upper lip in a way that made my own dick throb. I'd never be able to attend a dinner party and look at her lips in the same way again.

Dane smiled, ran his thumb down her cheek and pushed it into her mouth. She closed her eyes and sucked on it in earnest. Dane encouraged her, nodding, his upper body—still clothed in his workout shirt—rose and fell with anticipation.

With a final word, he pulled his thumb back, drawing it across her cheek hard enough to smear a trail of red lipstick. Any tenderness was gone.

He pushed her head down, and focused her once again on his cock. She took it into her mouth without hesitation, pumping his base with her hands as he guided her head along his length.

I ran my hand across my own erection before pulling it away. I'd already crossed the line of decency. I wasn't going any further. Still, it was hard to resist, especially watching the intensity with which Jessica blew him. I couldn't even remember the last time Laura had gone down on me, and I don't think she'd ever done it so enthusiastically.

Dane's hand tightened into a fist in Jessica's hair. He leaned forward, taking control of her boobs. Forcing his cock deeper and deeper into her mouth. At some point, he must have passed into her throat. His cock was just too big for it not to have, but Jessica didn't try to pull free. As far as I could tell, she didn't gag.

She curled her hands around his ass, holding on as he began to thrust into her, fucking her mouth more than receiving a blow job. It was so aggressive, so hedonistic, so wrong. But that it was wrong made it so much hotter. She looked up at Dane, her face smeared with lipstick, her normally perfect hair disheveled, her nostrils flaring.

I was so focused on what I was seeing, so frozen in place, that I didn't see it approach until I heard the crack of a branch behind me. I started, understanding, possibly for the first time ever, the phrase: jump out of your skin.

I wheeled around, so fast that I nearly lost my balance. There, standing about ten feet from me—and just as startled by my presence—was a buck, proud and tall, crowned with antlers that added to his majesty.

For a moment, we just stared at one another, each wondering what the hell the other was doing there. Beneath that glassy stare, I felt judged, as silly as it was. He gave a quick shake of his head, glared at me for one final second, and bounded off.

The snare was broken. I didn't even look back up at the house. I just stepped back onto the path, shoved my hands into my pockets, and made my way off toward the train station. Sweat covered the skin beneath my clothes, and I didn't stop shaking until I was on board the train, headed into the city. I couldn't think about anything but Jessica on her knees, staring up at Dane as she serviced his enormous cock.

With a little bit of distance from it, I could fully appreciate just how fucked up the situation was. What I'd just witnessed wasn't just some

random, heat-of-the-moment fling. It didn't look like that was the first time that Jessica had kissed Dane, had held Dane's cock, had sucked him.

I pulled out my phone. I needed to tell Laura. She'd never believe this. Before I could call her, though, I realized just how little I could actually tell her as I traveled on this crowded train. So instead, I shot a quick text off.

[Me]: Remind me to tell you about something I saw on the walk.

The text didn't send immediately, caught between towers. When it did, her response came just as I was getting into the city.

[Laura]: You get your steps in?

I just shook my head. It had been some morning.

Chapter 2

Believe it or not, I actually did manage to forget about what I'd seen. As soon as I walked into the office, I was caught up in the maelstrom of meetings and reports. We had to redo our entire presentation from scratch, and we were working on the PowerPoint right up to quitting time.

It was only as I started my walk home that the memory of what I'd seen returned. As I passed behind the Early's house, I glanced at the loose slat in their fence and my heart leaped.

When I made my way back into Belvedere, I couldn't help but look back. Jessica was in the front, dressed in a t-shirt, black leggings, and a floppy hat, working in the flower beds. I looked away before she looked down the street. Everything was normal.

Only it wasn't normal. I couldn't help but see her kneeling over the flower bed, picking weeds out of the mulch, and interpose the memory of what I'd seen that morning. It didn't end at the Early's house, either.

It was like the curtains had been pulled back, and now I was seeing a sexualized, lascivious world. If Jessica was capable of carrying on an affair, almost literally in my backyard, then anyone was. As I walked down my street and Clarissa Williams in 412 jogged past me in her sporty top and clinging jogging shorts, I couldn't help but wonder if she was coming home from a quickie. As I said, "Hi," I noted that her skin was sweaty and that her blond ponytail was just a little out of sorts. Had she been to Dane's? Had he pulled that ponytail as he rode her?

Get a grip, man.

Not even Laura escaped my sudden, suspicious scrutiny. As a writer, she spent most of her day working at home. Just like Jessica. As I entered the house and she came out to greet me, I wondered if she'd been wearing that blouse and those tight jeans when I'd left. Surely I would have recognized how sexy she looked, right? I would have noticed how her green blouse clung to her chest, outlining her pert breasts and athletic frame. Or how the dark jeans complemented the swell of her hips and her tapering thighs? Or how, at 41, I swear she was more beautiful than ever.

"What?" she asked. She looked behind her, realized that I was actually looking at *her*, and had the modesty to blush. Even that little action seemed

laced with sexuality.

“Um, sorry, you’re just...” What? Why was my heart pounding like a teenager working up the nerve to ask a girl out?

Laura caught on, her eyes narrowing ever-so-slightly. “Buttering me up, mister? You didn’t make an impulse purchase, did you?”

“Uh...”

She put a hand on her hip. “I thought we talked about this, and we decided to hold off on a new sofa.”

“No, it’s not that.” I laughed, releasing some of the tension I was feeling. “Um, is Bobby home?”

“He’s got soccer practice. Went with Nick. Why?”

I want to drag you up to the bedroom and ravage you, I almost said. Then laughed some more at myself. She’d really think I was out of my mind. I took a breath, gave her a friendly peck on the mouth, and went into the kitchen to retrieve a beer. Over my shoulder, I said, “You’ll never guess what I saw this morning.”

Laura turned, leaning on the door jamb of the kitchen. She’d put her dirty blond hair up in a messy bun that made me think of sex, and for one painfully uncomfortable moment, I imagined my wife in Jessica’s position. It sent a wave of nausea through me.

“Stop being dramatic, Michael. What did you see?”

I cracked the beer and took a long sip before composing myself. “Dane Armstrong and...Jessica Early.”

Laura looked at me blankly for a moment, not catching on. “As in...” Then her brows went up. Then the light bulb went on. “Oh,” she said, elongating the vowel. “You...saw them?”

She wasn’t accusing me of anything. The question was one of curiosity, but I couldn’t help feeling defensive. After all, I *had* stayed and watched longer than even remotely reasonable. “I mean, I saw him go into her house.” Then, because I felt like even that needed explanation, added, “He was walking ahead of me when I was headed to the station.”

Laura seemed to relax. Her eyebrows went back down and she released a chuckle. “You saw him go into her house, and you immediately jumped to *that* conclusion? Oh, Michael, I never took you for a speculative gossip like that.”

She started to go back to whatever chore she’d been working on. She didn’t believe me. I grabbed her by the arm, stopping her. She turned back

to me, surprised, her eyes flicking from where my hand was grasping her to what must have been my slightly crazed expression.

“It wasn’t just that,” I said. *I stood behind her home and watched through her fence as she sucked his cock.* “I saw them kiss. Just before going into the house.” It was a little white lie, but one much easier to explain. “I wouldn’t have thought anything of it if not for that. You know me, Laura.”

“You saw them kiss?”

I nodded, eager for her to believe me.

“Jessica Early,” Laura said, still sounding skeptical.

I nodded. “And Dane Armstrong.”

Laura took a deep breath, in and out. “Wow. That’s...” She shook her head. “Wow.”

“Crazy, right?”

Laura agreed. “Insane.” I could see her mind whirring through all the repercussions. I’d been there earlier. “You’re sure they kissed? Like...”

“Like this,” I said, pulling her close and covering my mouth with hers. I intended to just demonstrate what I’d seen—up in the window—only when I pushed my tongue past her lips, all the passion that had bottled up inside of me from this morning was released. Suddenly, it wasn’t just a demonstration of Dane and Jessica’s illicit kiss—it was also the first, real, passionate kiss I’d shared with my wife in a tragically long time.

Laura didn’t seem to know what to make of the kiss at first. I could feel her mouth tighten up into a smile, a laugh tickling her throat, before she gave in. When she did, we were suddenly kissing like newlyweds. Her hands slid up my shoulders and into my hair by the time we separated.

“They kissed like that, huh?” she asked, her face bright and playful.

“Something like that.”

She batted her lashes innocently. “Could have been just the way they greet each other. Dane’s a pretty touchy-feely guy.”

I snorted. “I’ll show you touchy-feely.”

Laura’s features sharpened. “Please do.”

I licked my lips nervously, glancing toward the front door. “When does Bobby get back?”

“An hour.”

“Okay.” I looked over at the counter, considering whether to just take her there in the kitchen. That was something that we hadn’t done since our

early years together, in the house we rented before this one.

“Bedroom?” Laura suggested.

I let reason take over, nodding. She took my hand and led me to the stairs. I slid my hand down to her ass, encased in a pair of skinny jeans that I didn’t recognize.

“Are these new?” I asked.

Laura’s laugh was more amused than anything else, the kind of laugh that went along with the words, *Such a guy*. Instead, she said, “Three years old. You like them?”

Heat gathered under my collar. “I like the way you look in them.”

“Uhhh huh,” she said, rolling her eyes away.

We moved into the bedroom, buzzing with an anticipation that I had almost forgotten about. Once upon a time, I was like this every time this beautiful creature offered sex. How did it ever come to where I took it for granted?

“I love you,” I said, gathering her in my arms. “I’m sorry that I don’t say that more.”

Laura nuzzled against me, brushing her nose along mine. “You know it’s always better to show than tell, right?”

Laura was an author, and mentored through an online, informal writing group.

“All I know is how to craft a PowerPoint. Should I get the computer?”

Laura pushed my chest slightly and looked up at me with her bright blue eyes. With almost total sincerity, she said, “That sounds *so* romantic.”

“Or I could just do this,” I said. I bent down and kissed her. Like before, I felt the smile on her lips, the impulse to laugh and make light. And like before, I felt it melt away to the passion that hummed beneath.

We kissed and stumbled back to the bed. Her knees folded under her and she fell into a sitting position on the edge of the mattress. For a moment, I pictured Dane standing over her like this, his handsome presence looming, sucking the oxygen from my wife’s lungs.

Then the vision was gone, leaving my blood feeling cold and my skin, inexplicably, licked with fire.

I grabbed my tie, loosening it as I crawled onto the bed beside her. Laura turned to kiss me as we struggled to get out of our clothes. Shirtless, I worked my pants off as Laura unbuttoned her shirt just enough that she could pull it over her head. Beneath, she wore a plain, champagne colored

bra that blended with her skin. Her nipples pressed hard bumps through the satin.

She searched my face again like I was a puzzle. “You keep looking at me like that.”

“Like what?”

She shrugged. “Like... I don’t know.”

“Nice job *showing*.”

Laura laughed softly. She reached behind her and released her hair from whatever tie had bound it. It spilled around her face in loose, lazy waves of golden brown, and bit her lower lip. “I like it,” she said. “I’m just feeling kind of...self-conscious.”

“You shouldn’t.” I advanced on her again, kissing her as my hand slid across the smooth skin of her tummy. “You’re sexy as hell, and you know it.” I popped open the top button of her jeans. “But you want me to show you?”

This time, there was no roll of her eyes, no attempt to lighten the mood. Laura breathed in sharply and nodded. When I pulled the short zipper of her jeans down, she helped me wiggle her out of the tight denim.

She wore a cotton thong, white and plain and unmatched to the bra. Laura was the only woman I’d ever met who preferred thongs to other panties, a preference that should never have become unremarkable, yet somehow had.

When I reached for the sides of it, she said, “I’m sorry. I haven’t...you know, tidied things up in a while.”

“I haven’t given you much reason to. Let me change that.” I pulled her panties down, revealing her untamed bush of light brown pubic hair. At the center of it, I could see her pink gash, wet and already blossoming.

As I looked up along her near naked body, her hair tousled, a strand caught in her mouth, I was transported back to that summer when I’d first met her, a girl of twenty-one, just out of college and carefree.

Even back then, I’d felt too stuffy for her, too square. I was going for my MBA. She was talking about a Masters in Fine Arts and spent her weekends smoking pot and attending open mic poetry events. Over the years, we’d met somewhere in the middle.

I brushed my thumb along her slit, circling her clit without touching it. Her smile preceded a quick, sharp gasp. I repeated the path, this time with my tongue, and she squirmed, lifting a leg over my shoulder.

“Stop *teasing* me!” she cried.

I winced at her volume before remembering we were alone. We’d spent so many years keeping quiet with Bobby around, sneaky sex had become a habit...when we had sex at all. When we did, it was late at night, or was the natural end to a night of drinking wine. It was never spontaneous any more. I didn’t come home from work at lunch because I couldn’t stand going the day without her, like in those first few years.

Had that been what happened with Jessica and Jared? They had a kid Bobby’s age. Had they let their marriage fade until Jessica’s only recourse was to have an affair? Or maybe the lack of attention just opened her up to Dane’s seduction—

“Michael!” Laura gasped. “Stop...*teasing*! AH!”

Adrenaline spiked through me—at the demand, at the reminder of what I’d witnessed that morning...at the thought of Laura in Jessica’s place? Whatever it was, red-blooded rage coursed through my veins. I pressed my tongue against her clit as I walked two fingers along her slit, burying them into her pussy.

Laura arched up over me, moaning, her hands going to her tits to tease her nipples. Her eyes were shut. Was she imagining *him*? The chances were slim, but suddenly, uncomfortably, I hoped that she was. I recalled his gigantic dick and added a third finger to her pussy, drilling it deep to simulate our neighbor fucking her.

Laura’s body arched more. She dug her heels into my back and lifted her hips from the bed, twisting away like some impressive sexual yoga pose. She was so graceful, all limbs and smooth skin. She bit her lip, pressing her tits together as she pinched down on her nipples. Her eyes were still closed, and behind them, I imagined she was doing this with another man.

It was too much. I needed to fuck her in a way that, shamefully, I hadn’t felt in years. Extracting myself from her leg, I grabbed her hips, rolled her onto her stomach, and pulled her up to her knees.

Her ass spread out before me, a tight, inverted heart that felt smooth as I ran my hands across it. Laura complained that it was too big. I thought she was crazy, and it made this particular position one of my favorites.

But that’s not why I chose it. No, this time, a twisted side of me wanted her facing away so that she could think about anything—or *anyone*—as I fucked her.

I unbuckled and unzipped myself as quickly as I could, but even still, it took longer than I'd hoped—long enough that she had a chance to look back at me over her shoulder and smile. “This is fun,” she beamed.

Her expression, so clearly directed at me, Michael Robbins, her husband, dispelled my weird fantasy. She wasn't imagining some other guy. She wasn't thinking about Dane's pornstar-sized cock. She was just happy to get a little play at an unexpected time.

It didn't deflate me. How could it, with a beautiful woman like Laura lying naked on the bed, ass up, batting her lashes at me like that? But it did take the edge off, the wild instinct to *fuck* her, to take her so hard she screamed, to reach out and pull her hair. That wasn't me, but was it Dane? And with Dane, is that what she'd want?

Pants off and cock in hand, I edged forward and sank into her pussy. We moaned together, Laura burying her face in the pillow to quiet herself. That was more like the woman she'd become over the years.

I rubbed her ass, filling my palms with those meaty cheeks as she got used to my cock. It had been so long since we'd last done this, and every time felt like a first now.

“Why don't we do this all the time?” she asked, reading my mind. She'd turned her head on the pillow, her blond bangs sweeping across her face. I brushed them away.

“Don't we ask that every time we do this?”

Laura's face went slack for a moment as a wave of pleasure rolled through her. “Yeah,” she said. “Let's do this more often.”

I grinned. “Okay.”

It wasn't the first time we'd made this resolution, and I knew it wouldn't be the last. Despite how amazing sex with Laura was, life just got in the way. Work, Bobby and his extracurricular activities, long days and short nights. At the end of the day, we were usually so exhausted that sex just sounded like more of a chore, and watching the next episode of some television show was just easier.

Looking down at this amazing creature who was my wife, I vowed not to do that again.

Because if I didn't, maybe a guy like Dane Armstrong would.

“Agh!” Laura cried.

“Sorry,” I apologized, realizing how hard I'd thrust, or how my fingers had dug into her buttocks.

“Don’t...apologize,” she said. Biting her lip, she looked slightly embarrassed. “I kind of liked it.”

Rough play was never something we had tried, and never something we had talked about. In fact, on the few occasions when I’d asked her about her fantasies, she always maintained that she didn’t have any.

Armed with the new confession, though, I didn’t hold back. Dane wouldn’t hold back. He didn’t when Jessica had sucked his cock, and I doubted that he’d been gentle when they eventually made it to the bed.

Grabbing Laura’s hips, I pulled her against me with each thrust, and pushed her away as I withdrew. Our skin slapped, mixed with her moans and my throbbing heart. I fucked her, imagining that Dane was fucking *her*—not Jessica—and while I felt shame build in the dark recesses of my conscious mind, I also felt excitement fuel each and every thrust. I gnashed my teeth, fucking her deeper, faster. Her cries spurred me on. The way she grasped the bed sheets on either side of her, desperate to hang on as I rode her pussy like a madman.

Throaty gasps spilled from her. “Oh my...oh my...ohmygod, come, baby!”

It was so unlike her. So dirty. So ripe to fuel my unexpected fantasy that I couldn’t have resisted her plea, no matter how hard I tried.

So I didn’t try at all. I rammed forward, dug my thumbs into the center of each ass cheek until the skin around them turned white, and I exploded deep inside her wet pussy.

I collapsed beside her, heaving in air. Laura, still on her stomach, turned just enough to kiss me on the cheek. She couldn’t seem to open her eyes. “Thanks for doing all the work,” she said.

“Got to get my steps in,” I said.

Laura’s laughter chased away the fading vision of her illicit coupling with Dane. I wasn’t sad to see it go. “I wonder how that thing even handles sex.”

I pulled up my Fitbit and checked my step count, but had no idea what it had been to start. “Not sure, but my heart rate is way up.”

“I’ll bet. You were really...energetic.”

My face grew hot. “Sorry about that. I’m not sure what got into me.” I grew even hotter when I realized that I did. That one, I’d take to my grave.

“Don’t apologize. I liked it. Made me feel...” She trailed off.

“What?”

She snuggled close. “I don’t know.” For a moment, I wasn’t sure she was going to say more. Then, she added, “Like you really wanted me. It’s nice to feel desired.”

“I always want you. That’ll never change.”

“I know that. I’m being silly. But you know what I mean, right? We’ve been together so long—”

“And you’re sexier now than ever before,” I interjected.

“Please. I can’t compete with the twenty-something version of me. I’m fine with that. I’m 41, and am proud of how I’ve...maintained. But—”

“No, seriously, I really do think you’re sexier right now.” I reached out, brushing away her hair. She’d lost the softness of youth, but beneath was a classic beauty that was only now shining through. If I met her now, at this moment in our lives, I don’t think I would have had the guts to approach her. “You’re gorgeous, Laura.”

She cast her eyes away, embarrassed but smiling.

I changed the subject for her. “So Jessica and Dane. Can you believe it?”

“It’s pretty crazy.”

Something about the way she said it wasn’t 100% convincing. Or maybe I was being paranoid. Still, I couldn’t help but probe. “You suspected something?”

“I don’t really know Jessica that well. She always seemed pretty put together, though.”

“Perfect homemaker,” I said.

“God, I hate that term.” She shifted. “But I guess it works for her, sure. But, I mean, no one’s perfect, you know?”

“Apparently not,” I said. “So at your moms’ night outs, she never mentioned...I don’t know...”

“About riding Dane Armstrong’s big dick?” Laura finished with a laugh. “No, the few times that she’s joined us, she kept silent on that subject.”

“Oh, so Dane Armstrong’s big dick comes up often?” It started as a joke, only Dane *did* have a big dick, and how did Laura know that? “What, it does, doesn’t it?”

I immediately looked at her, just in time to see...something slide across her face. Guilt? Fear? Embarrassment? “No, not often.”

“But you *have* talked about it?” *Jesus*.

“It’s not like that. This isn’t *Sex in the City* or something. But sure, it’s come up. Mostly as a joke, though. Back before they got divorced, Lisa used to complain to us about his size, that’s all. So we’d tease her about it. And when she and Dane split up and she moved away...” Laura shrugged. “It’s harmless.”

“Apparently Jessica decided to see if the rumors were true,” I said.

“Apparently.”

My mind was racing a mile-a-minute. “You think any of your other friends have been, I don’t know...curious?” Then, before I could stop myself, I blurted, “Are *you* curious?”

I saw the flicker pass across her face, so quick I could have missed it had I blinked. But I didn’t blink, and my cock betrayed me as it began to twitch and grow.

“No, of course not.” She reached between us, her brows going up when she found that I wasn’t completely soft. “I’ve got everything I need, right here.”

We both had questions. I wanted to ask more about her curiosity, and the only thing stopping me was that I had no idea how I’d answer if she asked me why I was hard again.

Downstairs, the door opened and closed. “Mom! Dad?”

Bobby was home. We reverted to the parents that we were and the life that we lived, hastily throwing on clothes before our son could catch us in the act. I looked at Laura as she pulled her blouse on, sans bra. *To be continued*, I tried to broadcast.

She just smiled, winked, and pulled her jeans on without bothering with underwear.

Chapter 3

I actually didn't end up talking about it, in part because I didn't want to know—in part because I suspected that she wasn't curious at all and I didn't want to be disappointed.

That was the crazy thing. I should have felt reassured that she didn't have any secret desires for another man—and I *would* be reassured, I told myself. But also, there was something exciting about the possibility that maybe she did have some secrets. In this case, ignorance felt safer. I could be excited without feeling jealous or insecure because I could always tell myself it was in my head.

I know, it makes no damn sense. Ravings of a mad man. But all of that was fluff compared to the very real fact that I knew two of the people in my neighborhood were having a very real affair.

We didn't know the Earlys all that well, but their son, Carter, played soccer with Bobby, which meant I ran into Jared from time to time. Dane lived closer, just around the corner. He also had a daughter, Chloe, just a year younger than Carter and Bobby, although Chloe ended up spending more time with her mom on the other side of the city.

As I said before, everyone loved Dane. He even had a dog, Duke, a yellow lab that he liked to walk through the neighborhood because, I suspected, it gave him an excuse to socialize. If you needed some kind of home project, Dane would always lend a hand. If you were going out of town and needed someone to water the plants or feed the pets, Dane was your man. And apparently, if you weren't satisfying your wife in bed, Dane could help in that department, too.

I spent the next couple of weeks on the lookout for Dane, and while I didn't see him with Jessica Early during any of my morning walks, I did see him around, and I noticed an interesting thing. Whenever he was talking with a woman, it was always borderline flirting. Didn't matter her age or appearance, whether she was one of the many attractive mothers in Kingston or one of the older, more matronly women who lived in the neighborhood long before all the families moved in and things got yuppified. He didn't discriminate. I'd see him chatting casually, standing

just a little too close, touching them a little too often as he made his points, and always, *always* making them laugh.

I wondered if the other husbands were as threatened by him as I was. I'd never heard anyone else say a bad thing about him, so began to wonder if maybe there was something wrong with *me*.

I bumped into Jared Early at one of our sons' soccer games. He was sitting in the front row of the bleachers and would bolt to his feet, fists clenched, each time Carter got the ball. I watched him, wondering if he had any idea what was going on in his home. Jared had served a tour with the Marines in Afghanistan. He was the kind of guy whose handshake was always a little too much, and who firmly believed that a woman's place was in the home. There was no way he suspected that his wife was stepping out on him. It almost made me feel sorry for him.

"Hey, Michael," Jared said after the game, grasping my hand with his too-tight grip. Behind him, our sons were chatting about the game, which they'd won handily. "How's it been?"

"Good. Busy. You?"

"Busy, busy."

This was about as awkward and lame a conversation as they came—particularly relative to what the conversation could have been. I said, "Haven't seen you around lately."

"I've been traveling a lot recently. Fuckin' work, you know?"

I thought about Dane and Jessica. I considered telling him. I really did. He was a decent guy, he deserved to know. But...I just couldn't. "Yeah, work's been intense for me, too. Budget cycle and all."

Jared nodded. "You going to the food thing?"

Our neighborhood had an annual food festival every year. The local restaurants along Main Street, as well as some of the adjacent towns, set up booths in Ashley Park. There was live music, a few moon bounces for the younger children, and for the adults, a wine and beer section. It happened every year, late in the spring, and it always snuck up on me.

"That happening again?" I said.

"Next weekend. I actually made sure to get the weekend off so I could go." He looked back at his kid to make sure he was out of earshot. "Jess is always fun when she gets a little wine in her. Wouldn't want to miss that."

I almost winced. Maybe I did. "Definitely not. I'll see you then."

I got out of there before I said something really wrong.

*

I felt bad for the guy. His wife was stepping out on him, he had no idea, and I was burdened with the knowledge. Laura and I had discussed it just enough to agree to stay out of it. It wasn't exactly the most ethical thing, but it was status quo, and Kingston loved its status quo.

Looking over at my son, who looked so much older than the boy I remembered holding, made me think of Carter Early and how devastating a divorce would be. My own parents split around his age and I wrestled with that guilt for years.

"What's up, Dad?" Bobby asked.

"Nothing, just...you played well today, Bobby."

"I didn't score a goal," he said, his shoulders slumped.

"You got a couple assists, and you guys won because of that."

"I guess."

It was pointless arguing with a teenager, so I left it at that.

At home, I meant to bring up the matter of the Earlys with Laura. At the very least, we needed an agreed upon strategy. When I walked into the house, though, all thought of that fled when I heard the cheerful laugh of my wife float from the kitchen, followed by the laugh of one Dane Armstrong.

My stomach fell into my groin as goosebumps rose along my arms. I glanced at Bobby, who was already headed for the basement, where his Xbox was. Normally, I would have told him to shower first, but I seemed to have lost the ability to speak.

My ears, however, felt as open as the front door.

"No, seriously," I heard Dane say. It was definitely him. "The mutt loves you. I think he's got a thing for pretty women in tight clothing."

Laura laughed again, and it felt like a dagger in my back. How could she laugh at that?

"Uh huh," she said. "I think he learned that from his owner, hm?"

"Are you kidding? He's the bad influence on me."

I shut the door behind me maybe a little too hard, rattling the house and making me feel a little better. "Hey, Laura, we're back."

Laura emerged from the kitchen with Dane just behind her, his dog by his side. She was wearing her jogging outfit—black, cropped-pants with a pink strip up the side, and a tight, black t-shirt. I could see her pink sports

bra emerge around her neck. Dane was dressed for running, too, and both of them were still covered in sweat. I blinked, imagining the two of them in one another's arms, hands in each other's hair as they aggressively made out.

When I snapped out of it, I felt sick to my stomach. Dane, looming large and toned over Laura's shoulder, nodded a hello. Laura didn't look bashful or ashamed, even though she was spending time with a man who she knew was fucking another married woman. I wanted to pull her away from him, to get out of this man's face, even as I wrestled with my darker desires.

"Hey, honey. How was the game?"

Laura raised her brows when I didn't answer her question, giving me a look that said: *be cool, dude*.

"Uh, they won. Bobby assisted on a couple goals."

"That's great! This means they're in the tourney?"

"Just edged in, yeah." I glanced at Dane, who hadn't made a move to leave yet. "You guys go for a jog?"

Did they do this often?

Laura answered for them. "Yeah, I ran into Dane while I was on the trail. He was just starting, so we ran together."

"Your wife has some stamina, man," Dane said.

I couldn't *not* read the innuendo in that statement, but pretended not to. "Yeah, she's pretty inspiring."

I expected him to say, *I'll say*, or something equally suggestive, and was grateful when all he did was nod. "I need to get back to feed this guy." He scratched Duke behind the ears. "Tell Bobby congrats on the win."

I swear, there was a swagger in his step as he passed me. It made my stomach swim even more. Even the way his dog looked up at me with those large, sad eyes seemed like pity.

When he was gone, and the door was shut, I whispered through my teeth, "What the hell was that all about?"

At last, Laura looked sheepish. That's the emotion I was expecting, considering the circumstances and everything we knew about Dane.

"Bobby showering?" she asked.

"Basement."

She frowned, crossing over to the basement stairs and leaning out. "Bobby! Take a shower before you start playing video games!"

As she hung off the top of the doorframe, I checked her out. Despite all the years we'd been together and how easy it was to take her for granted, she still had a spectacular body—especially when encased in tight exercise gear. I checked out her ass, molded by the the black pants, and didn't see any pantylines. Did Dane notice that, too? How could he not?

Jealousy burned, insecurity cooled, and that tickle of excitement muddled everything.

Laura led me into the kitchen, where a couple glasses of water sat on the counter. They were close together. Is that how close Dane and Laura had stood, or had she put them there before coming out to say hello to me?

Laura saw where I was looking. "I didn't intend to run with him. He just, kind of, joined. You know how he does that."

Her first words were defensive ones. That didn't sit right with me. "I know who he does, too."

Laura's cheeks turned red, even as she waved it away. "We don't really know that. I mean, you thought you saw them kiss. Maybe they were..." Her eyes strayed away in thought. "I don't know, hugging or something."

"They were definitely not hugging."

"But you were far away, right? You don't know."

I still hadn't told her the full extent of what I saw, mostly because I was embarrassed that I'd acted like a teenaged peeping tom, not a responsible man in my mid-forties.

Sensing momentum in my silence, Laura pressed on. "Anyway, it was harmless, Michael. We just went for a jog, that's all."

"That's all?"

She sighed. "He's our neighbor, honey. We've run together before. It's not a big deal. No reason to get jealous."

"I'm not jealous," I said, too quickly.

She saw the lie for what it was, but let it go. "Besides, this way, I can kind of do some investigation, you know? Maybe I can figure out if something really is going on."

"But I know what's going on."

She looked up at me, cocking a brow. "Do you?"

"Yes. Jessica is cheating on Jared with Dane. And apparently Dane has no problem sleeping with married women." I looked at her pointedly. "To get to the bottom of this mystery, is your plan to sleep with him, too?"

My rhetorical question touched down like a lightning bolt. I felt the burn beneath my scalp.

“No, of course not,” Laura said. “Come on, Michael, you’ve got to have a little more faith.”

“I’m sorry. I know. I trust you. I just...I don’t trust *him*.”

“Good thing you didn’t marry him, then.”

I glanced at the glasses again, so close to one another. “I still don’t like you two running together, or whatever. You need to believe me. I know what I saw, and he’s not innocent.”

“Okay, I believe you. Still doesn’t make sense, though. Jessica never seemed like the type.”

I nodded, although after what I’d seen, I wasn’t sure I could agree anymore. “Guess you never know what secrets people are hiding deep down.”

Laura’s eyes glittered. “Guess not.”

I had the intense desire to look away, and I felt heat begin to climb up my neck. I changed the subject. “So the food and wine festival is next week. We going?”

The charge that hung in the air melted away. Laura picked up her glass and refilled it. “Yeah, definitely.”

“What’s our strategy going to be with Jessica and Jared?”

“Status quo, right?” she said. “We *pretend* we don’t know anything.”

Based on the way she said it, I could tell she still didn’t quite believe it. I let it go this time. “It’s going to be weird.”

“It’ll be fine.”

Chapter 4

We arrived at the Kingston Food and Wine Festival around noon, and it was as bustling as ever. Many had come straight from the Farmers' Market, which had just finished up, to eat lunch and socialize with the rest of town.

One of the nice things about this festival was that people took the time to look nice. It wasn't quite Sunday best, but people also weren't dressed for a trip to the market. Laura, for example, looked like she was just back from the beach in her floral sundress—pink flowers against white, and short enough to show off her legs.

Jessica Early, I was pleased to see, took it further, wearing a long, striped teal dress made of clinging cotton that didn't hide her pronounced curves. I spotted her ahead of me in line for food and drink tickets, and once I did, I couldn't stop looking. This was the first time I'd seen her since she'd been on her knees, and that memory changed the way I looked at her.

Watching her nod and chat with her friend, I thought, *Cheater. Faker. Homewrecker.* And yet, what I *felt* was a lot more complicated, a tangle of excitement and discomfort over the mystery that was now this woman. When she nodded in concern at whatever her friend said, her duplicity rang through me like a discordant, yet not unpleasant, note.

We moved through the line. I bought tickets and found Laura and Bobby. We had lunch together as a family, something Laura insisted despite Bobby's protests.

"Can I go now?" Bobby whined. "Neil and Jackie are going to start a movie and they probably already started."

Laura checked his plate, where he'd polished off all but the crusts of his two pizza slices. "Go on. And you come right home after the movie is over."

"Thanks, Mom," he said, hopping up and running off.

Laura turned to me, holding a knowing smile. "I think our son has his first crush."

"What?" I asked.

Laura chuckled silently, but didn't explain. "We have any more tickets?"

"Two."

She handed me her glass. “Another Malbec please.”

Taking her glass, I crossed the wooded green, back to where the food stands were clustered in the parking lot. The crowd had thinned, although most of that was due to the families with children in tow leaving for naps and afternoon activities. Also, the two previous glasses of wine had settled on me like a warm, fuzzy blanket.

Most of the food stalls had no lines at all. Some were even preparing to call it a day, cleaning and putting away their equipment. The line for the wine, on the other hand, was as long as it had been earlier, if not even longer.

Kingston was a pretty big neighborhood, and had grown rapidly since we moved here almost twenty years ago. The excellent school system had attracted a lot of families who wanted the comforts of the suburbs and yet not get too far from the city. It’s what made events like this so popular to this group. It also meant that I barely recognized anyone anymore. Many of my friends and old neighbors had sold and moved farther out. We’d probably do the same when Bobby was in college, but for now, we were here, watching the neighborhood change around us.

One benefit was that the influx of new people meant house prices went up, and while it was certainly not a rule, more often than not, these young and successful couples were on the more attractive end of the spectrum. Which meant events like this were particularly fun to people watch.

As I stood in line, though, I really only wanted to watch one person—Jessica Early—and at first, I couldn’t find her again. I couldn’t find Jared Early either, for that matter, and hadn’t seen him at all that day. I would have figured he was traveling again if he hadn’t specifically told me that he’d made sure to stay in town for this thing. Maybe plans had changed.

I glanced off at Laura, her long legs stretched out before her as she leaned back on her arms. She saw me looking, gave a little wave and a smile, then cocked her head in the direction opposite her.

I followed her gesture and finally found Jessica Early, reclining on a picnic table with a glass of white wine in her hand. Sitting next to her on that same picnic table wasn’t Jared, however. It was Dane Armstrong.

I quickly looked back at Laura, and despite the distance, I could tell she’d raised her eyebrows meaningfully. I looked back at Jessica and Dane. They weren’t cozied up to one another. He didn’t have his hand on her

knee, or around her shoulder, and anyone else looking would see a totally innocent exchange between two neighbors.

I saw a couple—a dirty, secret, illicit couple. I saw him tower over her, dominating her, corrupting her. Jessica laughed at whatever Dane said—not Laura’s boisterous laugh, but her own quiet version, covering her mouth, her eyes half-moons over her hand.

“What would you like, sir?”

I was at the front of the line. Others behind me shifted impatiently.

“Um, two Malbecs please.” I kept glancing at that picnic table, worried that I’d miss something, although I had no idea what.

“We’re out of Malbec,” the man said, his voice so flat I almost missed the meaning.

I looked back at him, buzzed enough that it was too hard to divide my attention like this. “Okay, so could I have...” What else had Laura been drinking? She’d really liked the Malbec, thought something else was okay, and thought a third wine was undrinkable. “The Merlot.”

“Two?”

“Sure.”

“Two tickets please.”

I groaned at the tedium, handed the tickets over, then got back to my voyeurism. Jessica and Dane were still there, still engaged in their not-flirting. I guess that was the most suspicious part of it. Dane was the kind of guy who didn’t have a problem standing too close, didn’t hesitate to touch another woman’s elbow or shoulder when making a point. With Jessica, though, he seemed to be deliberately avoiding those things.

With my two glasses of Merlot in hand, I crossed back to Laura, watching Dane and Jessica almost the whole way.

“Stop staring,” Laura said once I’d lowered myself to the picnic table.

“I’m not staring.”

“Yes, you are.” She giggled, and lifted her wine to her lips. “You’re also drunk.”

“No.” I sipped. “Well, maybe buzzed.”

Laura smiled, sipped, then made a face. “What is this? This isn’t the Malbec.”

“They were out.” My eyes strayed to the picnic bench before I could stop myself.

“So you got me that disgusting Merlot?”

I winced. “Sorry.”

“Michael, Michael. Look at me.” I did. “Don’t think too hard on this, but is Jessica Early’s hair up or down?”

I started to look toward her, but Laura stopped me. “Don’t cheat.”

“Um... it’s in a ponytail.”

Laura lit up. “That’s good, honey. And is she wearing lipstick?”

“Red.” That I remembered.

“Correct again. And the color of her dress?”

“Teal. With stripes.”

“Teal with stripes. Yes.” She tapped her glass of wine. “You can remember all those things about Jessica, and you couldn’t remember my reaction to the Merlot?”

“I...” I hung my head. “I’m sorry.”

Laura waved it away. She wasn’t the type to ever demand to be the center of attention. Like me, she tended toward introversion at parties, letting others drive things. This was her subtle way of telling me to pay more attention to her.

“I’m sorry,” I repeated. “Want me to get you something else?”

To my surprise, she lifted the glass to her mouth and shook her head. Just before sipping, she said, “And miss this show? Stay. I’ll live.”

After her sip, she forced a smile, as if proving that she was fine. I shrugged and sat down beside her.

She leaned close and said, “Oh, and you’re right. Those two are up to something.”

That surprised me. “I don’t know, they look pretty casual to me,” I said.

“Exactly why it’s suspicious,” she said. So she saw the same thing that I did. “I wouldn’t know to look, though, if you hadn’t put me on to it.”

“I haven’t seen Jared, either.”

Laura frowned. “Yeah. It’s so weird. Jessica’s always been so...so good. PTA mom—but not the annoying kind, Church-goer. Whenever I talked to her...I guess I never thought she was capable of cheating. Even when you told me. She and Jared, they never seemed to have problems, you know?”

“I guess that’s just it, we don’t know. Everyone’s got their demons, even the Earlys. We still don’t tell Jared?”

Laura sighed, wrestling with the question. “I don’t think we do. We still don’t really know.”

I ground my back teeth and swallowed hard. I did know. *I should just tell her*, I thought. My heart began to race as I prepared to confess when Jessica said a final thing to Dane, finished her glass of wine, and sauntered away, her hips swinging. About ten feet away, she glanced back at Dane, who continued to watch her hungrily. She laughed and left the park.

“Yeah, that’s pretty obvious,” Laura said, quiet enough that I wasn’t sure it was meant for me.

Jared had said: *Jess is always fun when she gets a little wine in her*. I noted her empty wine glass beside Dane. Did Dane know that about her, too?

This messed up part of me—driven more by my little head than my big—was turned on by this whole situation. Jared was a good guy. He didn’t deserve this. But this whole situation was like learning that the girl next door did porn. She seemed so sweet, so good, and yet she was a dirty, sexual creature underneath.

One day, he’d find out and it would kill Jared, break up his family. I already found out; maybe I wasn’t the first. Rumors spread like wildfire in this community. Didn’t we owe it to Jared to say something before someone else did?

As if reading my slightly inebriated thoughts, Laura said, “Maybe we should say something.”

“Yeah?”

She sipped her wine, which was surprisingly almost empty. So was mine. She said, “Hypothetically speaking, wouldn’t *you* want to know if I were cheating on you? Even if it was a total stranger telling you?”

My stomach fell, and must have taken my brain with it, too, because almost immediately, I asked, “If this stranger didn’t tell me, would I ever find out?”

Laura stared at me like I’d sprouted a second head. Maybe I had. “What the hell kind of answer is that?”

I knew she’d had one too many. She never swore otherwise.

“What kind of hypothetical question is yours in the first place? You don’t have something to tell me, do you?”

“Of course not,” she said, glaring.

A small and troubling sense of disappointment tickled through me.

“Well, if I’d never find out...” I hesitated, incredulous that I was actually going to say this. The wine gave me the recklessness to finish the statement. “...ignorance is bliss.”

Laura’s eyes went wide. “Wow, really?”

My face went red.

Laura pressed. “You’d rather not know about an affair if there was no way it would ever get back to you?”

Well, that wasn’t exactly right, I realized. I just wasn’t sure how to parse the conflicting emotions that this conversation was evoking. All I really knew was that when she said “affair”, it hit me right in the gut.

I held up my hands. “I don’t know. That sounds crazy.”

“Damn right it does.” Her expression sharpened. “You have something you want to tell me?”

“What? No.” *All this talk of infidelity is turning me on.* “No, nothing. Like what?”

She studied me quietly. I felt like I was sitting under a heat lamp. “Just so you know, I’d want to know, okay?”

“Know?”

She sighed, leaning close. “If you ever even think about...doing what we think our neighbors are doing, I need to know. Okay?” It dawned on me that it wasn’t irritation tightening her face, but concern. “I love you too much to lose you because we didn’t talk through our problem. Even if I’d never know, you would, and that would end *us*. You understand?”

Oh, she thought I was trying to justify some kind of affair? “Laura, no. I’d never... You don’t have to...” I ran my fingers through my hair, surprised that they didn’t come away burned. “You’re the only woman I will ever need.”

“And yet I’ve seen the way you look at Jessica Early.”

Shit. She had me there. “It’s not like that. It’s more like...” I trailed off, trying to synthesize my thoughts around her sudden sexualization, the girl-next-door-turned-pornstar thing, without coming off as completely misogynistic, or without making Laura feel insecure.

Before I could, though, Laura turned her head, following something behind me. “Dane is on the move,” she said.

I started to look when she stopped me. “No, don’t be so obvious.”

“Why not? We’ve spent most of the afternoon watching him.”

Laura leaned in close to me, pushing her hair from her face. “Because he’s being more cautious now, making sure no one is watching him leave.”

“That’s weird.”

She nodded. “It is. So is the fact that he’s not headed toward his house, but in the direction of Jessica Early’s.”

I could have left it at that. We could have kept on sitting there on our picnic blanket, enjoying the quiet idyll of an afternoon at the park with one another. Instead, I finished my wine, stood, and held out my hand.

“What?” Laura said, not making a move to take it.

“Finish the wine and come with me.”

I saw something pass across her face—something I hadn’t seen in years, wild and free and tinted with adventure. She knew what I was offering, even as she asked, “Where?”

“Well, we’re going to follow them, of course.”

Chapter 5

“I don’t think this is a good idea,” Laura said again as we followed Dane. “He’s going to notice us.”

“He won’t,” I said.

We were about two blocks behind him, but it was the middle of the day. It wasn’t like we were the only ones out, and there was another family between us. I also had the advantage of knowing where he was going.

I took Laura’s hand in mine, but she didn’t need much coaxing. Despite her hesitation, her chest rose and fell with excitement and I could see her half-formed smile swim to the surface when she let her guard down.

Ahead of us, Dane turned down a new street. We followed, and when we turned, too, he wasn’t there.

“Well, we lost him,” Laura said. “Guess that’s that.”

“You’re right, guess we should go back home,” I said, although I kept on leading us down the street. “Say, don’t the Earlys live on Belvedere?”

I led us into the long cul-de-sac, and sure enough, Dane was there ahead of us, moving swiftly now that he was alone. We hung back at the corner, but he didn’t look back anymore. He was making a beeline for Jessica Early’s large, white home.

“Still think I’m making this up?” I asked, feeling smug.

“Maybe Jessica forgot something at the park.”

“Forgot her lover, you mean,” I said. “Fine, don’t believe me? Come on.”

I pulled her toward the path that led behind the houses, only realizing what a bad idea this was when Laura looked at me sideways.

“Where are we going?”

“Just making a point,” I said. I didn’t let go of her hand as we entered the quiet of the woods. Now it was my turn to search our surroundings for prying eyes. The yards back here were empty, the windows dark or draped. Crickets and the trickle of the hidden brook were all we could hear.

“How do you know about this path?” Laura asked tentatively.

“I take it to get to the train station. If you follow it all the way through, it crosses the stream about a block down, then empties out onto Harris.” Before she could follow that incriminating line of questioning, though, we

arrived at the back of Jessica Early's house, with its weathered privacy fence and the missing slat.

I moved up to the opening, feeling my wife's eyes boring into the back of my head. I ignored the heat crawling up the back of my neck. She said, "And you know about this because...?"

Through the fence was the rich, green lawn, the crystal clear pool, and the Early's stately home. I searched the windows again, my heart picking up as I passed over the bedroom. All were empty. For now.

"Michael?" Laura whispered, her voice so close I jumped. I began to work out how I knew about this opening when she added, "Do you see them?"

"No," I said, stepping aside and letting her peek.

Our eyes met for one second. Her cheeks were pink, and she looked away, embarrassed, before shuffling forward and looking through the fence.

I heard them first, Jessica's soft laugh and Dane's voice, unintelligible yet patently confident.

"I see them," Laura whispered. "And—oh, wow."

"What? What do you see?"

Laura didn't answer. I'm not sure that she even heard me. She just kept on staring at whatever it was she saw, her eye pressed tight against the privacy fence. I stepped up, moving into the space behind her, and looked for myself.

Dane was standing behind Jessica, who'd changed into a black bikini. And they were kissing—deep, over-the-shoulder kissing. My stomach quivered and my cock began to swell. I blinked, thinking I was seeing things, only to have more details of the scene fill in.

They stood just outside of the French doors that led out onto the patio, on the opposite side of the pool as us. Dane squeezed Jessica's left breast through her bikini and had his other hand buried between her legs, inside the suit. She broke the kiss, tipping her head back as she bit her lip to stifle her moan. Dane whispered something to her, and she nodded and smiled—her eyes closed the whole time.

To Laura, I whispered, "You know, I think you're right. It's totally innocent between the two of them."

That earned me a swift elbow in the ribs, but she didn't pull away from the missing slat. She didn't say anything, just watched. That eased my guilt enough to keep on watching, too.

Jessica turned to face Dane, her back to us now, reaching up to encircle his neck with her arms. She drew him in for another kiss as he reached behind her and untied her bikini top. A moment later, his hands wandered down her hourglass figure and toyed with the loopy bows on her hips.

Laura gasped as he yanked at those bows, stripping the brunette down to nothing other than her tall, corked heels. Dane, on the other hand, still wore all of his clothes—his pressed khakis and his untucked, olive green golf shirt that looked a size too small on his thick upper body.

Laura glanced back at me. “See? Told you it was all completely innocent.”

I almost laughed out loud, despite the sexual energy that crackled around us. Dane grabbed Jessica by the hair, pulling her back roughly. He said something just barely out of earshot, and pushed her to her knees. She didn’t protest. She tossed her hair, looked up at him, and began to silently work open his pants.

I whispered to Laura, “Yeah. *It is* a pretty hot day. All that clothing just needs to go.”

Pressed up against Laura like that, I felt her laugh. I also felt her respond to what we were seeing, feeling her shallow breathing, feeling her stiffness. No doubt, she felt mine, too, but both of us were too riveted by Dane and Jessica that it barely registered.

Only it did. As hot as it was to watch Jessica’s bare, toned musculature shift and move as she reached into his pants and pulled out his cock, hearing my wife’s stifled moan when she saw the other man’s size was so much sexier.

And there was no hiding that size, even from where we were, even with our angle putting Jessica’s head mostly between us and it. When Jessica had the cock free of his pants, the first thing she did was push it against his body, dip down, and slaver all over his balls. The man, at full extension, was impossibly large.

Jessica kissed up the shaft, her dark hair once again obscuring it, and began to bob her head in earnest.

It was our opportunity to slink away. We had all the proof we needed. Staying would be crossing a line into gratuitous voyeurism.

The lust, combined with the lingering buzz of wine, prevented me from thinking rationally at all. I had to assume the same went for Laura. I

glanced behind us, making sure we were properly tucked away in the brush. We were, and no one was coming down the small path anyway.

Satisfied enough to act reckless, I kissed the back of Laura's neck and filled my hands with her breasts. I could feel her hard nipples through the cotton of the sundress, and realized that she wasn't wearing a bra. That emboldened me even more.

Laura seemed to snap out of her trance. She began to pull away, to turn, to say something smart, like, *Let's get out of here*.

I didn't let her. "Shh, keep watching. Try to stay quiet."

She continued to look at me, confused, as I moved behind her and ran my hands up under her dress. When it dawned on her what I was doing, her eyes went wide and she shook her head. I nodded, then glanced past her, at the fence. *Watch*, I mouthed.

She didn't. Not at first. But she didn't stop me from pulling her thong off, either. The gray cotton was damp, encouraging. Stuffing it into my pocket—wouldn't want to leave evidence lying around—I pushed her dress up to her hips and crouched down between her thighs.

Her pussy was swollen and blossoming, her pink spreading open her plump and glistening pussy lips. I buried my face between her thighs, running my tongue along her slippery gash. The fence creaked as she grabbed it for support, but she managed to bite down on her moan.

I teased her with my tongue, reveling in the soft warmth of her, before sliding my fingers into the mix.

"Uh," she gasped, hissing through her clenched teeth.

"What do you see?" I asked between licks.

When she didn't answer immediately, I figured she wasn't watching any longer. Then: "He's got her head in his hands... Oh, Michael..." She sighed tightly. "She's really into it."

There was a fascination in her voice, beyond just her quest to stave off a loud orgasm. Like she was thinking of herself in Jessica's position.

"Oh, god, I think... *hngg*... I think she's got him all the way. All of...*haaa*...all of him."

I pressed two fingers into her, shifting back up so I could look myself.

Dane was still standing large over the kneeling, nude Jessica. His hands were clutching her dark hair, holding her head steady as he rutted his hips forward. I couldn't hear the gags, but I could imagine them.

I kissed Laura's neck as I fingered her in time with Dane's thrusts. My wife's skin burned beneath my lips.

Abruptly, Dane yanked out of Jessica, taking a step back. Reaching down, he grasped his cock and started jerking it off. Jessica cupped her tits, and while I couldn't see it, I could imagine the way she squeezed them together, giving him a target for his sperm.

"Oh my," Laura whispered.

A moment later, Dane exploded all over the kneeling brunette, coating her like some kind of pornstar.

My balls ached to do the same.

Laura bit down on her moan, but was unable to fully restrain the orgasm that tore through her. Her pussy tightened around my fingers as she hung her head between her shoulders and pressed her palms against the fence.

I'd never done to Laura what Dane had just done to Jessica. I'd always just assumed that Laura would think it was disgusting and degrading. Maybe she still would, but there was no denying that something about the display turned her on.

Before she'd even fully recovered, Laura turned and drew me into a deep, sloppy kiss. I was expecting her to come to her senses and urge us to leave. That she didn't made me want to fuck her even more.

When Laura pulled back, she regarded me with brows high with surprise and lips pursed in a contained smile. "You're a naughty one," she whispered. "What if we get caught?"

"Those two don't seem to be concerned with that."

I glanced back through the crack, just in time to see Jessica rise, cocking one hip to the side. Her breathy laugh slid across the yard as she responded to whatever Dane had said. Turning toward us, she scooped a dollop of Dane's come off her breast and sucked it off her finger.

Jessica Early's naked body took my breath away. Her tits swung full and free, ripe fruit off of her womanly, hourglass torso. I could just make out the pearly sheen where Dane had marked her, dripping down her flat stomach.

I followed the flare of her hips as she sauntered over to the pool's edge. She had the kind of body that made me think of figure models and old Playboy Centerfolds. I expected to see a crop of dark hair. Despite

everything I knew she was capable of, it still surprised me to see that she was completely bare.

Dane spoke, Jessica smiled and laughed quietly, and then gracefully dove into the pool.

I wondered what Jared Early would do if he realized that his wife had used their pool to clean off another man's jizz. I almost made a joke of it to Laura before catching myself—a thing like that wasn't a joking matter, and what was wrong with me that I thought it was?

Laura, who'd returned to the fence as well, gasped beneath me. I'd been so fixated on Jessica that I hadn't noticed Dane had begun to strip. Apparently my wife had, and she approved.

Working from home, having a mostly independent child who sometimes lived with the mother, and being single himself, Dane had the time to work out five days a week, and it showed. As he pulled off his shirt to reveal a sculpted upper-body that would have made a male model proud—the abs, the pecs, the arms, even the light crop of chest hair—Laura whispered, “Yes, please.”

I'm not sure she intended for me to hear, like she'd voiced her own inappropriate joke, or had just let her subconscious slip out. Either way, my world tilted because of it. Dane shucked his pants and boxers, leaving him in all his intimidating nakedness. And again, Laura drew a quick breath.

Dane had never gone completely soft, and as he made his way to the patio table, his semi-erect cock swung heavy and large—larger than me at my hardest, I realized, and wondered if Laura was making the same comparison.

He poured two glasses of wine, then finished his swaggering journey to the pool's edge, just as Jessica finished a full lap. He crouched down, handing her the glass of wine. They toasted to something, drank deeply, and kissed again. Jessica reached out and encircled his cock, sliding the skin up and down the growing length until it stood up on its own.

Dane broke the kiss and helped the buxom brunette from the pool.

I knew what came next. I'd known since I first followed Dane, weeks ago. Even still, I felt dizzy with the disbelief and anticipation that this was happening, that this wasn't some porn shoot or sex dream.

This time, I had a partner in crime to help sooth that feeling of shame. And that partner was just as turned on, her heart beating like a motor, her chest rising and falling like she was hyperventilating.

Without taking my eyes off of Jessica and Dane, I moved behind my wife, quietly pushing my pants down around my knees. I didn't even bother scanning our surroundings. I didn't care if someone caught us. All I cared about was getting my cock into Laura before Dane got his into Jessica.

"Michael..." Laura warned as I pushed her dress back up around her hips.

I ignored her, steadying her hips and lining up against her pussy. She was so wet, so slippery, that my first pass glanced off her, brushing up against her clit instead.

She moaned, loud enough that it sounded like a gunshot in my ears. I imagined birds taking flight, Jessica and Dane shooting alarmed looks toward the back of the yard.

They didn't. They were lost in their own world, too, making out with wild abandon as Dane laid her onto her back at the lip of the pool. She was jerking him off again, getting him ready for the ultimate betrayal.

"Hold still," I said, putting my hand over Laura's mouth. "And keep quiet."

She nodded quickly. This time, when I pushed forward, I found my mark and sank into her. She was so wet. I couldn't remember the last time she'd been this wet. That alone nearly put me over the edge.

Jessica pointed Dane's cock at her smooth pussy, and the man didn't hesitate to press into her. Unlike me, he didn't miss his mark. He split her, sank into her, and she arched back onto her shoulders, her chest thrust high, forming a S in their lurid profile.

Laura's pussy squeezed around my cock as we watched Jessica take another man's strange cock. Or maybe it was my own expanding excitement. Or maybe both.

We'd watched porn together—once, a long time ago, when you had to either rent or order it in physical form. It had been a disaster. Rather than getting her in the mood, Laura had spent most of the time laughing at the cheesy music, or being grossed out by the extreme closeups of big dicks going into pussies.

This should have been no different, only it was. Laura was riveted. She held the fence and stared through at those two beautiful people doing something they really shouldn't be doing. I could feel Laura's rapture in her shallow breathing and the way she pushed her ass back into me.

Dane lifted Jessica's leg, holding it high against his chest. Her other dangled into the water, and the new angle, however unintentional, gave us a clear view of Dane's cock sliding in and out of Jessica.

They fucked with hushed, yet vigorous, energy, their need for secrecy as powerful as our own. I matched his pace, watching Jessica's big tits jiggle with each thrust. She reached up and grabbed one of those fleshy mounds with her left hand, squeezing it. The sun reflected off her diamond ring, flashing out a reminder of how wrong this was.

Using Jessica's leg to steady himself, Dane let his free hand wander over his lover and her pale skin. He walked it along her thigh, across her stomach, which rippled with her growing orgasm. Down it plunged, skating across her bald snatch to attack her exposed clit as he fucked her.

I felt something tickle my own shaft, and it took me a moment to realize that Laura was mirroring Dane's wandering hand. She was touching herself, playing with her clit as I took her.

My balls tightened. The world around me went silent and muffled as I wrestled to hold my climax at bay—at least for a couple seconds. I pushed into Laura one final time, my balls nuzzling against her sodden pussy. Her fingers tapped against her clit, urgent and harder than I would have been comfortable with. I could feel it in my balls.

I covered Laura's hand that was still braced on the fence, our fingers lacing together, sweaty and hot. She pushed her hips back, grinding them into mine as she sensed my imminent release. Through the fence and across the pool, Dane and Jessica seemed to fall into the same harmony. Dane pounded his thick dick with the crazed determination of a man at the edge. Jessica crossed it, bowing back, both hands working her pussy as she drove her tongue into her top row of teeth and somehow managed to stifle her cries.

Her pained expression, raw, adulterous, and unadulterated, set me off. Jessica was stunning, with her wet, dark hair plastered to her forehead and those high, pale cheekbones. But it was the idea of my wife, Laura, in Jessica's place, getting pumped by another man, that triggered my final release.

Laura joined me with the first burst of hot come inside of her. She gasped, high and muffled, as her body stiffened. Pressing her ass back into me, she dropped her head between her shoulders again. I squeezed her hand, catching my own grunts before they gave us away.

We slumped into the brush, holding each other as we caught our breath. Sweat dappled Laura's temples and dampened her hair. Her chest rose and fell like she'd just finished a race. I knew I didn't look any better.

"We shouldn't have watched that," she said between huffs.

"You sure about that?"

Her cheeks were pink, but she didn't look away. "Yes. Now we're part of this."

I nodded, handing back her thong. Thing was, we already were, Laura just hadn't realized it. "Come on. Let's get out of here. We'll talk at home."

Laura nodded, already sliding her panties back on.

I said, "Hey, you're amazing, you know that?"

Laura's smile was vibrant. "You're not so bad yourself."

Chapter 6

You're not so bad yourself. It was a throwaway line, I knew, just one of those things said after receiving a compliment, equivalent to a “thanks” or an “I love you, too.”

Thing was, as we hurried home in silence, brushing dirt from our clothes and leaves from our hair, I couldn't help but read into that statement—I wasn't so bad myself, but Dane with his fit body and monster cock was so much better.

I couldn't deny the truth of that thought. I knew I had other qualities that Laura admired, like the fact that I was her husband, or that I was faithful to her. But physically speaking, I couldn't compete with Dane Armstrong. I came to a jittery form of peace with it, mixed, maybe, with some actual excitement. I didn't actually want Laura to do what Jessica did, of course, but it was hot imagining that she could.

Bah, none of it made sense, and it was probably all a part of my muddled and still slightly buzzed brain.

When we got home, Bobby was back, playing video games and wondering where we'd been. We stumbled over our responses before heading off to do responsible, parental things, like shower the sex off and prepare dinner (by ordering pizza).

Hours later, when the house was quiet and we were snuggled in our bed, the stresses of the long day seducing me to sleep, Laura turned to me, her arm propped up beneath her head, and said, “Okay, let's talk.”

“Sure,” I said. “I really think that the food and wine festival has never been as good since Victorio's closed a couple years ago.”

Laura rolled her eyes and laughed. “Goof.”

A cloud of anxiety descended over me. “Okay, let's talk.”

“How did you know about that missing board in the fence?”

My face flushed, and Laura noticed, although she didn't look particularly surprised. She was just confirming a theory she had, and she did so with a thoughtful nod. “So when you said you saw them before, you *saw them* saw them.”

“No,” I blurted.

Laura raised a brow.

“I mean, not like we did today.” I sighed, embarrassed. “I didn’t intend to, but as I was making my way to the station, I saw them in the upstairs windows. They kissed, and she, um... went down on him.”

Red crept up Laura’s cheeks. She flopped onto her back and blew the bangs out of her face. “This feels like a crazy dream,” she said, almost to herself. She turned, looking at me. “You should have told me.”

“I know. I was going to, but it’s kind of embarrassing, you know?”

“A little pervy?” she offered, then snorted. She tore her eyes away from me again and looked at the ceiling. “Like what we did today wasn’t way worse. We had sex while watching them. Through a crack in a fence.”

I rolled onto my side, running my hand up her chest. She felt hot beneath her cotton pajama top, and her nipples were hard. “Don’t tell me that you didn’t enjoy it.”

“Sure, but that doesn’t make it right,” she said.

I tweaked her nipple, drawing a smile from her. “It turned you on,” I said. “You’re as much a voyeur as I am.”

Laura sighed. I could see her gathering her thoughts, to confirm or deny my statement. Or maybe admit that it was something else that got her off—Dane’s body, Dane’s cock, the illicit nature of Dane with Jessica, even? I braced myself for any of those confessions, my heart racing and my blood rapidly fluctuating between hot and cold.

Instead, she said, “That thing you said at the park, about ignorance being bliss. Do you really believe that?”

I lost any sense of mental balance. Did I really believe that if Laura ever cheated on me, I wouldn’t want to know? The answer was a resounding *of course I’d want to know*, but the confusing tumble of excitement was not something I was prepared to confess. I barely understood it myself.

I needed to focus. We were talking about Jared and his life, after all, not my own fucked up issues. “It...depends,” I said carefully.

“We’re talking about cheating here. What other factors even matter?”

“Well, I think motivation matters a lot. If Jessica still loves Jared, and this is just a physical thing, and she has no intention of leaving him...” I trailed off as Laura stared at me in shock.

“We’re talking about an affair, Michael. You saw something a couple weeks ago. We definitely saw something today. That means they weren’t just caught up in the moment—”

“They looked pretty caught up to me,” I interrupted.

Laura blushed, but went on, unfazed. “They planned this encounter. It was premeditated. It’s an affair, Michael. We can’t deny it anymore. We’re a part of this, like I said. We need to tell Jared.”

I groaned. She was right. As much as I wanted to pretend that this was all fun and games, this was real, and there were consequences. “So how do we do this? I barely know the guy.”

“Don’t you do, like, guy things? Go grab a beer with him or something?”

“Laura, I don’t even do that with the few friends I do have.”

“Fair.” She sighed. “Anonymous email message?”

“That’s one way, but it just feels...cowardly.”

“Yeah, I agree.” She sighed. “We’ll think of something. Maybe just play it by ear, and if a situation comes up that makes sense, go for it.”

“It’s going to ruin him,” I said. I believed it, but also, if I put myself in his shoes, I wondered if it really would. And that alone was troubling. “But yeah, okay. Needs to be done.”

“I love you, my peeping Tom,” Laura said.

“I love you, too, peeping...Tammy.”

We burst out laughing together. “Night.”

Too exhausted to make love, we fell asleep.

Chapter 7

“Cheers to your new job,” I said, raising my ice cream cone to Laura’s.

“You definitely know the way to my heart.” She licked her cone. “This is a better way to celebrate than some forgettable glass of wine.”

Laura had landed a gig teaching creative writing at the Kingston Community Center for the Arts, and despite being modest about it, she was brimming with excitement. There was a brilliance in her bright blue eyes and the way she just couldn’t stop smiling that I hadn’t seen for a while.

We hadn’t planned on any kind of celebration, although when Laura texted me that she’d gotten the job on my way home from work, I told her to meet me along Main Street. My plan actually had been wine, but when we walked by the Kingston Creamery, we just exchanged a look, bought our scoops, and settled in at an open sidewalk table.

With her glasses on—plastic-rimmed and slightly too large for her face—her sandy blond hair back in a ponytail, and the ice cream cone in her hand, she looked more like the coed I’d met so long ago than my wife of nearly twenty years.

But that wasn’t quite right. She was also that woman, her beauty made crisp in her maturity. Her face was leaner, her cheeks more pronounced, her beauty more refined. Even without makeup, in a heather blue running shirt and a pair of light jeans, she was more beautiful than ever.

She pushed her glasses up the bridge of her nose and cocked her head. “What?”

“Nothing.” I went back to my ice cream cone. “So where’s Bobby?”

“Out with Neil and Jackie.” Something shifted in the curl of her lips.

“What?”

“I think he’s got a crush on Jackie,” Laura said.

“Jackie Harwell? Eric’s girl?”

“They’ve been hanging out a lot lately. Haven’t you noticed the way he talks about her?”

“No,” I said dumbly.

“Of course you didn’t, dear. That’s okay.”

“Is it serious?”

Laura flourished her ice cream cone. “Just a crush. Pretty sure he hasn’t told her. It’s cute, really.”

“Think *she* knows?”

“Of course, Michael. We always know.”

“You didn’t know that I liked you,” I said.

She looked at me in amusement. “What makes you say that?”

“I seem to recall you talking a lot about guys you went on dates with.”

She nodded, pushing her plastic-framed glasses up the bridge of her nose, and coyly said, “I thought we were just friends then. Didn’t *you* say that?”

“But now you’re telling me you knew I had a crush on you?”

“Oh, yes, definitely.” She gave her ice cream cone a satisfied lick.

“So you were being cruel.”

“I was just challenging you. Besides, I seem to recall mostly talking about how *terrible* those dates were. I liked you, Michael, and I wanted you to ask me out.”

And eventually, she didn’t need to say, her strategy had worked. I don’t know that I would have had the nerve to ask her out cold, but she’d been going on and on about how bad some date had been, and I’d just blurted that she should let me give it a try.

In hindsight, it was all so obvious, and I was being a silly kid, even in my mid-twenties. I wanted to laugh, but then another emotion short-circuited the nostalgia.

One of those dates *hadn’t* gone poorly. I’d been at the house party long enough that I stopped caring about the crush of bodies and the smell of spilled beer and marijuana smoke. All I saw was her, a young Laura, laughing on the other side of the crowded room. I began pushing my way through the crowd, focused on Laura without any real plan other than wanting to be close to her, to share her space, to bask in her laughter.

I was about ten feet away when the crowd shifted and *he* stepped forward. I don’t remember his name, I never found out, but he was her age, virile, handsome, tall. He put his hand behind her neck and pulled her in for a long, deep kiss. The thing that I still remember with painful, teeth-chattering clarity, was her hand on his shoulder, clutching his shirt as though it was all she could do to hang on and weather the kiss.

After that, he whispered something, she nodded, and they left together. It had taken a long time to get over that. I played the friend card stoically. I

still liked her. I still wasn't willing to give up our time together. But it was almost half a year before our first kiss.

Even after all these years, that acute sense of betrayal still rose through me, like all of a sudden my world had been flipped upside down.

For some reason, I thought of Jessica with Dane that very first time, meeting at the front door, coming together in the bedroom window.

"Oh, hey!" Laura said cheerily, snapping me out of the past.

Shit, how long had I zoned out? "I'm sorry," I began, but she wasn't talking to me, but someone behind me.

"Hey, Laura." Jessica's high, breathy voice curled around me like a caress. "Did you contact Bannickers about the landscaping project yet?"

I turned awkwardly in my chair, and there she was, Jessica Early, the denied object of my sexual obsession in the flesh.

It had been a month since the food and wine festival. I'd seen Jared at a few soccer games—nothing that lent itself to me telling him about his cheating wife—but this was the first time I'd laid eyes on her.

Laura said, "It's on my to-do list. Been busy." To me, she said, "I ran into Jessica the other day at the garden store. She offered some advice on what to do about our azalea problem."

I had the sense not to ask, *What azalea problem?* Instead, I looked at Jessica and said, an octave too high, "Hello, Jessica." Then groaned inwardly.

"Good to see you, Michael." As she looked at me beneath her long and curled lashes, I wanted to look away as shame and guilt tumbled through me. Like she knew what I knew. Like I was complicit in her infidelity.

Jared was beside her, his hand on the small of her back. That shame gathered beneath my collar, itchy and hot. "Hey, Jared."

With me sitting and the two of them standing just a couple feet away, I had to twist and look up at them, further adding to the awkwardness of this meeting.

Laura rescued me. "You guys are all dressed up. Special occasion?"

I'd been so distracted it was only now that I took in her black, wrap-dress, and the way its plunging neckline offered up her deep, creamy cleavage. Jared was wearing a suit and too much cologne.

"Not really," Jared said. He turned, meeting Jessica's eyes. When he spoke, it was as if she'd asked the question, not Laura. "Just taking advantage of the nice night and getting a drink at Medici."

Jessica's smile widened as she stared up at Jared. It wouldn't have surprised me if they began making out right there on the sidewalk.

Instead, Jared released her and looked at the two of us. "You guys?"

I found my voice, and at least some of my composure. "Celebrating Laura's new job."

"Oh, that's great," Jessica said, her throaty voice seemingly capable of making everything sound sexual. "I didn't know you were going back to work."

"No, it's not a big deal," Laura said. "Just a part-time thing at the art center. A writing workshop."

"Maybe I should sign up," she said. "Jared's always telling me I need to find more hobbies." She nudged him playfully, and he smiled at her.

I felt ill. If only he knew.

"You should do that," Jared said. Like a puppy dog.

Laura and I shared a look.

Jessica said, "Hey, you two should come and have a drink with us. After you're done with your ice cream."

What had been a fun, cute way to celebrate Laura's job suddenly felt embarrassingly juvenile.

Jessica turned to Jared. "Honey, you don't mind, do you?"

"Of course not," he said, upbeat. "The more, the merrier."

"It'll be on us," Jessica insisted. "To celebrate the new job. Sound good?"

She spoke to Laura, but finished her question on me, her smokey eyes lingering. I was painfully aware of her low neckline, even as I resisted looking.

A thought occurred to me, disturbing and sexy at once. What if she did know that I knew? What if she'd seen me watching—seen us? It's not like we were all that quiet. I was too frazzled and on the spot to follow that thread all the way to its conclusion. Instead, I blurted, "We'd love to join, but I think we're a little underdressed for a wine bar."

A quick glance at Laura confirmed that that was the absolute wrong thing to say, although to anyone but me, she looked completely neutral.

"Oh, please." Jessica dismissed the excuse with a hand wave. "This is Kingston, not the city."

"Well, there's Bobby—" I began, trying to get us out of it.

“We’d love to join you, if you don’t mind,” Laura said over me. “Just give us a few.”

“Great! See you in a bit.” Jessica hooked her arm into Jared’s, and they continued down the sidewalk, pressed as close as newlyweds.

I followed Jessica and her swinging hips. The material of her dress was thin, and I wondered if she was wearing any underwear—

“Hey, Michael. You there?”

I quickly looked back at my wife, totally busted.

Laura had pulled her knee up against her body, resting a flat-soled foot on her chair. She still had her ice cream cone. At least she smiled when she said, “I don’t think Bobby’s the only one who’s got a crush.”

“Laura, no. It’s not like that.” Then, our earlier conversation returned to me and I contradicted myself. “You think she knows?”

“We always know, dear. I told you. And don’t worry, I’m not mad.” I wasn’t so sure about that. “I mean, I get it. She’s gorgeous.”

“It’s not... You’re...” My ice cream melted along my hand. I leaned over and chucked it into the trash in frustration. “It’s not just that.”

Laura held up her hand before I could stammer on. “I get it, Michael.” She leaned in so only I could hear her. “We saw her have sex. We know what she looks like naked. You can never look at someone the same after that. I get it.”

I relaxed. She did get it. “A year ago, Jessica was just another neighborhood mom.”

“A MILF, you mean,” Laura said with a smirk. That smirk was good. It meant we were moving past the awkwardness.

“This is Kingston. I think it’s kind of a prerequisite before you can move here,” I said. It was an old joke between us. “Anyway, sure, she was pretty, but I never thought about her *like that*.”

“You know I don’t believe you, dear.”

I shook my head, but conceded. “No more than I’ve thought about any of the other PTA moms. I mean, she’s pretty, she’s fit, but she’s always had this kind of...”

“Martha Stewart, conservative housewife vibe?” Laura offered.

“Yes! Like she was the authority you went to if you needed to know how to remove a wine stain from a carpet, not, I don’t know...”

“How best to give a blowjob,” Laura whispered, covering her mouth at her own audacity. She looked around, making sure no one else heard.

“I don’t think it’s just what we saw, either.” I thought about her black dress, and the stilettos she was wearing. “There’s something more sexual about her.”

“Well, isn’t that the cliché? With, you know...” She leaned in. “...affairs?”

“Poor Jared,” I said, although strangely, I didn’t really mean it. I mean, I did, and I felt awful for the guy, but he was also getting this bombshell of a wife, and judging from the way they looked at one another, at the way they touched one another, he was reaping at least some of those sexy rewards.

I looked at Laura, sitting across from me, working on the last remnants of her ice cream cone. She was more beautiful than ever, but I’d somehow started to see her as *sexy*. In the way that I had when we were young, when she’d put her hand on that guy’s shoulder at the house party, when I’d watched her kiss another man.

“Michael,” Laura said.

“Yes?”

She looked like she had something to say, something serious or meaningful, then let it go. “Come on, let’s go get my free glass of wine.”

It was strange carrying around this huge secret, but I was happy that I could share it with Laura. As we walked hand-in-hand the two blocks along Main to the wine bar, I could take comfort in the fact that I didn’t need to face this alone.

That didn’t reduce the pressure that started to build, though. We needed to do the right thing and tell Jared, and anything short of that—which definitely included hanging out with the couple like nothing was amiss—was just making us more complicit. When the time came, he’d figure out that we’d known that he was a cuckold even as we saw him at soccer games and drank the wine he bought us. We needed to tell, but each day made it harder.

Or maybe we didn’t need to. They still looked in love—more than most couples who’d been married for a couple of decades. The fire still burned between them, where most couples who’d been together so long had grown cold. Or at least familiar. It may have come at the cost of fidelity, but who were we to judge?

I looked at Laura, lost in her own thoughts. Was that a price that I was willing to pay? The throb started in my heart and ended somewhere

between my legs. I didn't want to think about it, but it was becoming hard not to.

Medici was one of the newer restaurants in Kingston—becoming the fashionable place to eat now that Victorio's had closed. Because of that newness, it was crowded, even on a Thursday night. The crowd was about our age—suburban couples with children old enough to be left at home—and we recognized many.

The Earlys were at the bar, Jessica sitting on a stool with her legs crossed demurely in front of her, as Jared told some story with wild gesticulations to her and the barkeep. As I got closer, I realized that he was recounting last week's soccer tournament, in which their son had scored the winning goal.

It was interesting watching Jessica listen, a tall glass of red wine in her hands, a half-smile on her red, red lips. She was still the suburban mom I knew her as, truly enthralled by her husband's story about their son. Only with a little more makeup than usual, and a tighter dress. It was my perception that had changed. I couldn't help but see her as someone sexual.

"Hey, guys!" Jared said, spotting us. "Michael, Michael, back me up here. Wasn't Carter's kick a thing of beauty, the way it curled into the goal."

Jessica looked at me, and I shared a look with Jessica like the co-conspirators that we were not. She returned...confusion, her brow crumpling as she tried to work through a mystery that she didn't know existed. I blundered forward with a: "It was a great shot. Your kid has a great foot on him."

"I should hope so. Between all the practices, and all the games, I'm glad that it's worth it," Jessica said. "Jared was telling me something about traveling to some tournament in the summer?"

I wanted to look at Laura, but Jessica was staring right at me. "Yeah, Regionals. The boys may qualify this year."

"Road trip, you two. That'll be fun," she said. In that breathy voice, I translated her idea of "fun" into wild, overnight sex on Dane's prick. She dispelled it by saying, "Laura, we should do a girls' night out or something. This is a rare opportunity."

"Very," Laura said cheekily. "I haven't had one of those in forever."

"Speaking of, you two need drinks," Jared said. He grabbed a menu off the bar and handed it to us. "Let's celebrate that new job!"

From the outside, the four of us would have appeared completely normal—just two couples hanging out and enjoying drinks on a Thursday night. Baseball was on the televisions behind the bar, other groups filtered in and out, many we knew, some even stopping by to share a drink. There was nothing unusual about any of it.

Only, I'd seen Jessica naked. I'd watched her deep throat another man's cock. I'd seen her cheat on her husband by the poolside. She could look as doe-eyed and in love at Jared as she wanted, I couldn't unlearn what I'd learned.

Judging from the few exchanges I shared with an ever-tipsier Laura, as well as her quieter behavior, she was also trying to make sense of it.

We talked about Laura's new job, as well as the book of short stories that she'd just published. I was surprised that both Jared and Jessica had read it, but then I was always surprised by my wife's local celebrity. Jared talked to us about less interesting things in the world of defense contracting as he put away light beer after light beer.

I paced myself more responsibly, but at some point, I must have crossed a line because I blurted, "So how are things with you two?"

It was the kind of question you ask early in a conversation, as an ice breaker, not two hours in after enough banter that the answer should have been obvious. I winced, wishing I could have those words back.

Jared didn't even blink. He put his arm around Jessica and stared into her eyes as he answered. "The best ever, man."

For Jessica's part, she returned the intimate look with equal intensity. It was a hungry look, the same kind of look she'd shared with Dane by the pool. "We're doing okay," she said with a laugh.

I looked at Laura, who watched the exchange thoughtfully, the tip of her index finger between her teeth. She didn't see me looking.

Jared whispered something to Jessica that I couldn't hear. She giggled and nodded, glancing at me with large, glittering eyes.

"Excuse me, I need to take a piss," Jared said.

"Very smooth, dear," Jessica said, patting his shoulder. "I'll settle the tab."

"Michael, could you get ours, too?"

"Nonsense," Jared said, already a couple steps toward the restrooms. "I told you, we've got it. This is your celebration."

“Thanks, Jared.” Laura slid off her stool. “I’m going to use the lady’s room, too.”

I was so busy watching them make their way into the back, laughing together and slightly unbalanced, that I didn’t see Jessica sidle right up beside me until she spoke.

“You’re looking good, Michael. Laura have you on an exercise plan?”

She was right there, smoky voice and all, making everything deliciously awkward.

“Thanks. I’m...I got a Fitbit.” I held up my wrist to show off the fitness band.

She ran her fingers along the gadget, brushing my wrist as she did so. Her nails were painted red. “I’ve been thinking of getting one of these. You like it?”

“It’s motivating,” I think I said. It was getting hard to think. “But you don’t really need it.”

I shouldn’t have said it, and I definitely shouldn’t have looked down into her cleavage as I did.

I had seen those tits naked. I could visualize the way they bounced when she fucked. My face flooded with heat. I looked back up at her, and she smiled knowingly.

“Thanks, Michael. I appreciate it. It’s so hard to keep up in this town.”

Did she put extra emphasis on the word “hard,” or was that just my imagination. I needed to change the subject. “So, you and Jared seem good.”

Was that a shadow that passed across her face? Did she pause before smiling? “We are. And you and Laura?”

“Good. You know how it is after all these years.” I’m not sure why I said that. Later on, I’d claim it was for investigation.

Jessica sank her teeth into her full, red, lower lip and nodded. “Oh yes, I do.”

She may as well have wrapped her lips around my cock. I was proud of myself for not moaning right then and there.

“You settle the tab?” Jared asked behind us. I nearly jumped out of my skin. “That’s okay, you two keep flirting away. I’ve got it.”

“Sorry, I...” Behind him, Laura stood, her face unreadable. “Seriously, man, we can split it.”

“Nah, man. Put your money away. I’ll take care of it.”

*

We parted ways at the door, Jessica and Jared heading for the east side, Laura and I going south. Jessica's perfume lingered, like my guilt.

I took Laura's hand as we walked. "That was interesting," I said, for lack of something better to say.

I felt Laura studying me, but didn't dare look. "Very." Her tone was blank.

"You think she's going to sign up for your class?"

She ignored my question, asking one of her own instead. "Did you get the sense that they were going through a rough patch?"

"No."

She nodded, but was quiet again. Most of the houses around us were dark. Reasonable people were in bed by now, and we lived in a reasonable neighborhood. I'd see the flicker of a television now and again, or an upstairs light on, but it was a school night, a work night, and most were asleep.

Only now, my mind was opened to other possibilities. Just because these houses were dark didn't mean nothing was happening inside them. If anything, that darkness just hid more secrets. Jessica and Jared's situation just made me realize that everyone had their secrets.

"It's so weird," Laura said after another block. "So, so weird."

I kept quiet, letting her work through her thoughts.

She said, "On the outside, they're like, so good, you know? It's not just Jared, either. When they left, I got the feeling that they couldn't wait to tear their clothes off." She snuggled into me, and my cock stirred. They weren't the only ones. "But we know that it's all one giant lie. It's like we're in a play or something, and we can see all the stuff that's going on behind the scenes, but we keep trying to pretend we're the audience."

"Why do you think these things are mutually exclusive?"

"We..." She stopped. "What?"

"Oh, nothing. Sorry, keep going."

"No, Michael, what do you mean by that?" There was no bite in the question, only curiosity. Unfortunately, I didn't have a very well thought out answer. So I rambled.

"Well, we know what we know, right? She's got this thing on the side. We also saw her with her husband tonight, and honestly, if I didn't know

better, I would have thought they were newlyweds or something.”

“Yes!” Laura agreed.

“But, I mean...” This was the hard part because it got too close to desires in myself that I didn’t fully understand, and Laura was too smart not to trace them back to me. I wasn’t ready to have *that* conversation. “We figured she was having an affair because she wasn’t getting something from Jared in the bedroom, right?”

“I hadn’t really thought about it, but sure, that’s usually the story,” Laura said. “She’s feeling neglected, along comes Dane who makes her feel sexy, and things just happen.”

Laura’s short synopsis stirred something strange inside of me. She came up with that pretty quickly.

I blundered on before anything could grow from it. “But what if it’s not so cut and dry. What if...I don’t know...” *What if he was fine with the affair*, I wanted to say, but just couldn’t. That would lead to a whole bunch of other questions—questions I didn’t want to answer just yet.

“What if they are swingers?” Laura offered.

Swingers. *Swingers*. Now that was an interesting idea. I pawned it off like I was thinking the same, because it was easier. “Yeah, right. What if they had an understanding like that?”

Laura blew out a lungful of air and looked around. She had this silly, incredulous smile frozen on her face. Covering her mouth, she laughed. “Wow, if that’s true...” Her eyes strayed to mine, full of enormous possibility. It was unnerving. “But it can’t be true. That’s crazy, right?”

We arrived at our home. It was as dark as the others, although we saw the television on in the den. Bobby was still up, most likely playing a video game.

“Yeah, it’s pretty out-there,” I said.

But not so out-there that it didn’t work itself into my psyche as surely as Jessica’s nude body had. By the time Bobby was in bed and we’d rehydrated ourselves and gotten ready ourselves, I couldn’t think of anything else. Were Jared and Jessica swingers? Was it even all that crazy? In a community the size of Kingston, surely *someone* was, right?

It was also easier to swallow than Jessica just being a cheater. It made situations like tonight less oily. If Jared was in on Jessica’s tryst with Dane, then hanging out with the married couple meant that we were all in the know, even if they didn’t know it.

Laura came into bed, dressed in one of my t-shirts—which looked enormous on her—her hair and teeth freshly brushed. “You’re thinking about it, aren’t you?” she said.

She climbed into bed and put her glasses on the nightstand. The lights went out.

“Yeah,” I said.

She rolled onto her side, facing me, and pulled me in for a friendly kiss. “Me too.”

“It’s just a theory.”

I felt her nod. My eyes slowly adjusted to the dark. “A very wild, unlikely theory.”

“Uh huh,” I said, tracing one hand across her cheek. “Do people even do that sort of thing?”

My other hand moved down between her legs, pressing apart her warm thighs. She gasped as my fingers found her pussy; I gasped because she was so wet. A thrill ran through me. Did the idea of Jessica and Jared’s arrangement turn her on?

She gasped as I touched her, ignoring my rhetorical question. I kissed her, surprised at the urgency with which she returned it. She rolled onto her back, taking me with her as I struggled to get my boxers off.

I was hard, and Laura hummed when she wrapped her hand around my cock.

She broke the kiss as she pulled my erection toward her pussy. “You think they were feeling us out tonight?” she asked.

My cock twitched in her hand. I hadn’t considered that possibility, but now that she’d said it, a lot of little details started to fall into place. Jessica’s touch. Jessica’s compliment.

I slid into Laura as my thoughts betrayed me, as I thought about Jessica’s buxom body and how good it would feel to do this to her. Laura moaned, tightening her hand behind my neck and pulling her down against me. Her heavy breathing filled my ears, encouraging me to fuck her.

Behind closed eyes, I saw Jessica on her back, by the pool, her legs splayed open, her body a rolling S of pleasure. I didn’t last long. The image of Dane’s cock rutting into Jessica’s exposed pussy destroyed me. I came without warning, premature and too caught up to be embarrassed.

Laura was right there with me. As soon as she felt my come, she seized up, wrapping her arms around me, and choked on her orgasm.

Satiated and still pretty drunk, I rolled off of her as sleep curled around my consciousness.

“Do you really think they could be swingers?” I asked, not really expecting an answer.

Laura shifted behind me, rolling onto her side, facing away, our asses touching. It was how we normally slept.

“Maybe. I don’t know. It’s a pretty crazy idea though.”

“Yeah.”

Just as I was about to fall asleep, a new thought cut through the haze, sharp and sexy and wrong. I knew why I suspected Jessica of being a swinger, but what about Laura and Jared? Had he said something, done something? Had he made a pass at Laura?

I was too tired to ask, and besides, I could already hear Laura begin to snore.

Chapter 8

“How’s this?” Laura came into the living room wearing yet another outfit—a long, snug fitting blouse with a graphic design splashed across it, a short black jacket, and a tight pair of jeans. Paired with flats and with her hair back in a ponytail, she looked smart, cool, and casual, yet not too casual. Probably the exact look she was trying to pull off for her first day of class.

I started to say as much when she groaned, turned on her heels and started back to the stairs. “No, it’s not right. The jacket is too much, and—”

“Laura, stop.” I chuckled, stood, and pulled her into my arms from behind. “This is it. This is the one.”

“Are you... Maybe I should... I’ve got a cardigan... Or that sweater I wore a couple outfits back—”

I kissed her neck. She smelled like soap and shampoo, and I could feel her pulse racing. “Stop overthinking it. You know these people, and they know you. They’re taking the class to listen to your words, not judge your fashion choices.”

She relaxed against me and sighed. “You’re right. I’m just nervous.”

“You’ll do fine. You’re amazing.”

“Says you, because you have to. I’ve run these things before, but always online. Just seems easier than having to deal with the whole physical thing.”

I tugged her ass against me by her hips. “Funny, but *dealing with the whole physical thing* is my favorite part.”

She scoffed, pretending to be scandalized. “Such a guy thing to say. Perhaps you could give me some real advice?”

“Sure. How about putting yourself into the mindset of one of your characters.”

This was an old joke between us, and she smiled as she responded. “Uh huh. Anyone in mind?”

“Was thinking Scarlett Whirley.”

“I suspect that’s often the case,” she said, wiggling her butt against my hips.

Scarlett Whirley was the female protagonist in her sexiest book to date—a free-spirited, promiscuous femme fatale who ended up getting

embroiled in a murder mystery because she'd slept with the murderer. I've read it a few times, and I still couldn't believe that character had come out of Laura's head.

"You realize that Scarlett would make a terrible teacher, right? She'd be too busy checking out the guys in her class."

My heart leapt as I imagined Laura doing just that. Playing it off with my joking voice, I said, "Maybe that's what I meant." I let the absurd statement hang out there for less than a second before adding, "Seriously, though, just think of her confidence. It's your confidence. You're a rockstar."

She turned to face me, placing her hands on my shoulders. "Thanks," she said, sincerely. "But if this is some ploy to get me to wear high heels, you can keep dreaming."

If that's how she interpreted my suggestion, I let it stand—although I also liked the idea of her wearing high heels. "Hey, I'm just trying to help."

She kissed me. "I know. And I love you for that, even though you're totally driven by this." She brushed her hand across the front of my pants, where I'd begun to harden. Her brows went up, but she didn't probe. She had a class to get to.

*

Laura's workshop ran from 7:30 to about 10:00. Bobby and I had dinner together in front of the television, watching a movie. After a long week, it was a nice way to let my brain shift into autopilot. Beer in hand, dumb action movie in front of me, and my son at my side, I could relax.

It was just wrapping up when Laura should have been home, and instead she sent me a quick text.

[Laura]: Grabbing a drink after class. Will be home a little later.

I didn't think much of it at the time. It was only when Bobby had gone to bed and I was brushing my teeth that it occurred to me to think of this drink as anything but innocent—and it was almost certainly innocent. Still, there was this tiny voice inside of me that wondered, *What if it isn't?* What if some guy in her class had asked her out for a drink, and she'd accepted?

It was preposterous for so many reasons, least of which was that I trusted Laura. The thing about that tiny voice and its effect on me was that it *wasn't* rational. It whispered, *What if* and made me imagine a scene where

Laura stared into the eyes of a strange man over a cocktail table as he ran his thumb up and down her index finger. She'd laugh and blush and look away at whatever he said, and my insides would roil. And my cock would harden.

I tried shutting it out, but as the minutes ticked by, it became harder and harder to do. I scanned Facebook on my phone as I waited for her in bed. 10:30 passed. Then 11. Then 11:15. The scene moved beyond the bar, to his car, where they kissed in the parking lot, hard and feverish, my wife caught up in the newness and the danger and the—

The front door opened and closed softly, snapping me out of my haze. Laura breezed into the room, light on her feet, a silly smile on her face.

"Oh, you're still awake. You didn't wait up for me, did you?"

I stared at her lips, wondering if they looked puffy. She didn't wear lipstick, so there was none to smear, but maybe that's why she'd choose to go without and—

"Just wanted to see how it went," I said. "Was about to turn the lights out."

Laura danced across the room, tossing her jacket onto the chair in the corner on her way to the dresser. She was tipsy, at the very least, and I wondered how many drinks she had. "It went really well. You were right, there was nothing to worry about."

Facing away with me, but with the familiarity that came with years of marriage, she pulled her blouse off and dropped it beside her. Reaching behind her, she unclasped her bra.

"So how big was the class? Recognize anyone?"

"There were ten, plus me." She shimmied out of her jeans and thong, leaving her naked, her heart-shaped ass pointed at me. "And yeah, I recognized almost all of them. That's the way it works in this town when you've been here for so long."

She pulled out a nightie when I said, "You don't have to put that on right away, if you don't want to."

Holding the scrap of cloth against her chest, she turned to me. "Oh yeah? I might get cold."

"I can keep you warm." I felt silly saying it, but said it anyway because I was still in the lingering thrall of that tiny, forbidden voice.

Laura raised her brows, surprised as much as I was, then shrugged. Taking her glasses off and setting them on the dresser, she sauntered toward

the bed, her hips swaying. She discarded her nightgown like a sexy prop, exposing her lean body and her high, perky breasts. To my surprise, her nipples were hard.

“You’re so sexy, Laura.”

She crawled up on the bed and her dark blond hair fell across her face. She tossed her head, clearing it, and said, “Call me Scarlett.”

And then she laughed.

The sauciness dropped away as she snuggled into my arms and kissed me warmly. “I actually did kind of think about Scarlett tonight.”

“Oh yeah?” I licked my lips, knowing I shouldn’t say this next thing. “You spend most of the night checking out all the guys?”

“Well, there were only two guys in the class, but one of them was pretty cute.” Laura’s laughter was musical. “Funny thing, but it turns out most of the people around here who want to spend their Friday nights discussing creative writing are women.”

I only sort of heard her, still caught on the confession that one of them was cute. She may not have been vamping it up like Scarlett Whirley, but this was almost better. Also, she was still naked and right up against me.

“Yeah, that’s pretty funny,” I said, kissing her neck. I ran my hand down her naked back. “So you knew most of them?”

Laura sighed, exposing more of her neck to my gentle kisses. “I...recognized most...of them.”

“Yeah?” I moved her upwards so that I could dip down and run my tongue across her nipple. She gasped, her fingers running through my hair.

“My friend Ellen was there,” she said, fighting to maintain a normal conversation. I traced the crack of her ass down between her thighs, where she was wet and ready.

“That who you had your drink with?”

I yanked my pajama bottoms off and Laura lined me up against her trimmed snatch and sank over me—the practiced dance of our long marriage.

“Yeah, Ellen, me, and...” She moaned softly. She was so wet. Why was she so wet? “And Jessica and Dane.”

I groaned. She’d hung out with Jessica and Dane tonight?

“Turns out Jessica did sign up after all. It was her suggestion that we go out and get a drink after.”

I ran my hands down her body, cupping her ass. “And Dane just happened to be there?”

“Coincidence, huh?”

“Very convenient,” I agreed. We started rutting faster, feeding off the illicit nature of the night. “Did they flirt?”

Laura bit her lip and nodded. “Yes, but...he flirted...with everyone.”

Including you? I wanted to ask. But then, I knew the answer, and I didn’t want her to contradict it out of a sense of marital duty.

“Ellen?” I said instead.

Laura snorted. “Did Dane Armstrong flirt with a cute, skinny blonde? What do you think?”

“Did Jessica seem jealous of that?”

“Sneaky,” Laura said. “You know, I didn’t look, but...I mean, they did a good job hiding the fact that anything was going on there. If I hadn’t known...”

She bit her lip as a wave of excitement rolled through her. I’m not sure what was sexier—knowing about this illicit side of Jessica Early, or my wife’s reaction to it.

I kissed her neck and behind her ear. Her breathing grew heavier. I whispered, “But you did know.”

She nodded. “Uh huh.”

“And?”

Her body stiffened, the hammer of a gun being cocked. “I saw them...”

I squeezed her buttocks. “*Saw* them?”

“Yeah,” she said. She glanced away, embarrassed by what she was about to confess. “I kind of followed them.”

“*You* followed them?”

“Are you going to repeat everything I say?” she said lightly. “Yes, I followed. We all left at about the same time. I’m a little drunk, so I just kind of did it.”

“Where did they go?”

“To Ashley Park.”

“No way,” I said. The park was where the food and wine festival had been, right in the center of town and a block off Main. Closed at dark, doing anything there was risky.

“That’s what I thought, too. They went into the far side, away from Main, you know? Where the picnic benches are?” We’d almost stopped fucking as she confessed, but as she sank into her retelling, her hips began to rock over me again.

“I know the area,” I said. “You followed them?” There was something very sexy imagining my wife being sneaky.

“I did. My heart was beating so fast. At first, I didn’t get close. I kept just far enough away that I could see their shadows. They went to one of those play structures, with the twisty slide and the crazy things to climb up. They were being quiet, but I could still hear Jessica’s giggles and shushes.”

“Could you see what they were doing?”

Laura put her hands on my shoulders and rolled her head to the side, causing her hair to spill over her shoulder. Her eyes were closed. She was back in the moment. “I heard them first. Heard Jessica’s moan cut through the buzzing of the crickets. After that, I had to see.”

“Very naughty, Laura.”

“I was so worried that I’d step on a twig or something that I almost got *too* close. I hid behind a tree, in the dark, and they were right there, Michael. She was bent over the ladder, her dress up around her waist, as he...he...”

“He what, Laura? What was he doing?”

“He was... he was fucking her,” she whispered.

“And what did you do? As you watched?”

“I...I touched myself.”

“Do it now.”

She moved her hand down between us, her breath catching as she tickled her fingers across her clit.

“Did you do it over your jeans?”

“Mmm hmm.” She bit her lip as her fingers circled faster.

“Did you think about opening your jeans?”

“Yes,” she gasped. “But they were too tight.”

That was so hot. I lifted my hips up into her, plunging ball deep. “Next time, wear a dress.”

“I shouldn’t have been there,” Laura said.

I ignored her conscience as it tried to sneak in. “What else did they do, Laura? He had her bent over, fucking her from behind. What else?”

“He...talked to her.” She moaned breathily.

My heart pounded. “What did he say?”

Laura shook her head, her brow furrowing.

“Tell me, honey. What did he say to her?”

She was deep into her world, bouncing up and down on me, her eyes shut tight, her hand a blur between her legs. She opened her mouth, but all that came out was a silent moan. At first. Then, just as I was about to prompt her again, she said, “He asked her if she missed his...his big cock.” Her pussy tightened around me—or maybe that was my cock expanding.

“And what did she say?”

“She said she did.”

“How?”

Laura worked her hips faster, her fingers tapping her button hard enough that it sent tremors across my balls. “She said, ‘I love your big, hard cock. It feels... so... good!’”

As if living the moment, as if Laura herself was loving Dane’s big, hard cock, she arched forward, her hair cascading around us, and came. She was somewhere else, she was imagining *someone* else. I grabbed her hips, yanked her against me, and joined her volcanic orgasm.

It felt like a long time before we recovered. Our sweat had long cooled. Snuggled up under the blankets, I said, “You really saw that?”

I loved that Laura blushed at the question. “Yeah. I know I shouldn’t have, but—”

“I love that you did.”

“Why?”

I chuckled. “Means I’m not the only perv in this relationship.”

Laura laughed with me. “That’s why I was pretty late. I watched, and then I realized I was kind of stuck. I didn’t want to creep away and risk stepping on something.”

“You stayed?”

Laura nodded. “It’s not like they were there for long. When Dane was close, he pulled out and made her swallow him.”

As hot as that image was, it was the way Laura reported it that stuck in my head. *Made her swallow him*, not *finished in her mouth*. She’d noted the dominance, more than the act. Did she even realize that?

“After that, they got dressed and went their separate ways. It was interesting, actually. They kissed, and they were affectionate, but they

didn't seem...I don't know. Emotional? They didn't tell each other, 'I love you,' or anything like that."

"It was all physical," I said.

"That's an understatement," Laura laughed.

"You still think they're swingers? Jared and Jessica?" I asked.

"I don't know. Maybe. But whatever's going on, I don't think Jessica's about to leave him. Not for Dane, anyway."

"Yeah, that's the same impression I got when we were hanging out with the Earlys a few weeks ago." I brushed Laura's hair as my thoughts wandered. "People and their relationships are complicated."

The comment wasn't just about Jared and Jessica Early.

Laura sighed and snuggled into me. "Yes. Yes they are."

Chapter 9

Three weeks ticked by in a blink. The school year ended. We fell into our summer routine. Laura taught her class each Friday night, and while it became an unspoken tradition to grab a drink at Murphy's after class with anyone interested, there weren't any more coincidental meetups with Dane Armstrong.

Bobby's soccer team did qualify for Regionals, as everyone suspected, which meant a road trip with Bobby, Carter, and Jared. Laura was staying back to teach her class.

Laura must have sensed my unease as she watched me pack. "It'll be fine," she said.

"Yeah, I know." I stuffed some socks into the roller bag. "Could get weird though."

Laura snorted. "It could." She pushed off the doorframe, where she'd been leaning. "You could also get some intel."

"The swinger theory?"

"Shh!" Laura said, glancing over her shoulder and down the hall. "Bobby..."

"Sorry."

"But yeah," she said. "That's what I mean."

"You still think that's what's going on?" I went back to packing.

"I don't know. The more I get to know Jessica, the harder it is to believe that she'd cheat on him." Jessica had become one of the regulars of the post-class drinks, and despite my new view of the woman, Laura swore she was "just like everyone else."

"And if she is? If he's clueless?"

Laura sat heavily on the bed, chewing on her fingertips. "Then we have a problem."

"And that's what I'm afraid of."

"Yeah." She patted my leg. "Let's cross that bridge when we get there."

"You going to do that girls night out thing with Jessica?" I tried to play it cool, asking that question. I'd been thinking about Jessica's invitation since hearing it at Medici's over a month ago, although I didn't want to

make a big deal about it. The prospect of Jessica hanging out with Laura—of rubbing *off* on Laura—was a collision of excitement and discomfort.

Judging from the way Laura smirked at me, though, she saw right through me. “Yeah, that’s the plan,” she said with a sly smile. She didn’t press, though, and I let it drop, suddenly focused on my suitcase.

Bobby and I drove off the next afternoon—a Thursday—for the tournament, about two hours away, and for the next couple days, my life was filled with chaperoning teenage boys and soccer.

Bobby’s team did really well, advancing to the finals bracket by the end of Friday, which meant we were there through most of the day Saturday, and drove home late that night. I’d known that these kids were pretty good, but seeing them excel on this level was impressive, even to me. Jared, who’d traveled out here with Carter, was going around thumping his chest like an idiot.

“I’m thinking scholarship here,” I said to Laura over the phone Friday night as she walked to her class. “Should we cash in the college fund now? Or wait?”

Laura’s sing-song laugh was warm on the line. It had only been a day since I’d left, but I missed her. “That’s great that Bobby’s doing well, but let’s not get crazy, honey.”

“Always so reasonable.” My own laugh was forced. I took a big breath. “So a weird thing...”

“Yeah?” She sounded worried.

“Jared kind of invited me down for a drink. Once the chaperones call lights out.”

“Huh,” Laura said. “Doesn’t sound that weird. I mean, you guys are out of town alone. Kids are asleep. I’m sure you two aren’t the only chaperones grabbing a drink.”

“I suppose... I mean, you’re right. It’s probably nothing, but... it could also be something.”

She laughed. It made me feel a little silly, but I clung to it. “Okay, so even it’s it’s not, like, a thing,” I said, piecing together my logic even as the words came out of my mouth. “Two guys drinking, talking about whatever. We know something’s going on with Jessica. What if he lets something slip. What if he tells me that he thinks Jessica’s cheating on him. I’m going to have to play dumb while feeling like a total jackass.” My voice sped up as I began to panic.

Laura heard it. Tried to calm me. “Michael...”

“And okay, so even if this *is* the big confession and he takes me aside to confess that he’s a swinger... well, then that’s not awkward at all.”

“Michael, you’re not hyperventilating over there, are you?”

“This isn’t funny.”

“I’m not laughing.” But she kind of was. “Okay, let’s work through this. How did he seem when he asked you?”

“I don’t know. Normal?” I tried to remember. It was just as we were packing up. He was high-fiving all the other dads. He put his arm around me and I remembered thinking, *He’s not going to nuggie my head with his knuckles, is he?* Then he asked if I wanted to grab a drink. “Okay, maybe I’m overthinking this one.”

Now she did chuckle. “That was abrupt.”

“Yeah, well, if things start getting weird, I’ll pretend to have a stomach bug or something.”

“My courageous husband,” she laughed.

“Aaanyway. So you’re going to class?”

“I am.”

“I bet Jessica doesn’t show up.”

We hadn’t seen much of Dane recently, other than walking his dog around the neighborhood. Certainly hadn’t seen him with Jessica, but we had a running bet between us that with Jared and Carter out of the house, Dane and Jessica would be taking full advantage.

“I still think she comes,” Laura said. This was her argument. “Just to keep up appearances, but then disappears right after.”

“Very cunning, Laura. Should I be worried?”

Laura laughed. “Only if you want to be, dear.”

That stirred something in my loins. “If you end up spying on them again, text me with updates.”

“I’ll be sure to do that.”

*

Jared and I got through a rowdy dinner with the boys, then shepherded them upstairs and into our block of rooms. The team shared a few rooms, each with an adjoining room for the chaperones to sleep in. I was rooming with Elliot Marvel, a decent guy, older than me, quiet until his kid took to

the pitch, when he turned into a screaming lunatic that put Jared to shame. Fortunately, he went to bed early, and when I told him I was going down for a drink, he just waved me away.

I tried not to overthink where this evening could lead, or why Jared wanted to have a drink with me. I told myself that he just wanted to talk about the tournament over a beer, nothing more.

Of course, I knew so much more about Jared and Jessica than I should have, so my mind wandered and worried. Whichever way this went—that he had some secret sex life, or that he was being cheated on—I just didn’t know how to handle it. I wished Laura was here with me. She’d know what to do, and how to navigate the next few hours.

Jared was already in the hotel bar when I arrived, his beer mostly gone. He was alone.

“Hey, man, sorry. Got held up talking with Elliot.”

Jared barked a laugh. “He tell you to ‘just fucking pass the ball’?”

Elliot had gotten into trouble earlier in the day for swearing from the sidelines. I laughed and said, “The guy is like two different people, you know? He’s a sweet teddy bear most of the time.”

Jared nodded, his laughter turning more contemplative. “We’re all like that in some ways, right?” he seemed to say it almost to himself. Then he downed his beer, slapped the empty pint on the bar, and said, “Hey, get us another round. Maybe a shot for you. You need to catch up.”

I didn’t order the shot, but I did order us another round. At first, we just talked about normal guy stuff. We talked about soccer, talked about being a dad in our affluent neighborhood and the pressures of keeping up, talked about whether football was worth giving up a Sunday afternoon to watch—neither of us did.

Three and a half beers in—or was it four and a half?—things turned to our wives. Well, my wife, at first.

“So how are things with you and Laura?” It could have been just a casual, natural turn of the conversation, but felt foreboding.

“They’re okay.” It felt like something was caught in my throat, like a bad case of heartburn. I sipped at my beer, but it did nothing. At least it prevented me from asking the follow-up question: *why do you ask?*

“Just okay?”

I shifted defensively. “No, I mean, they’re good. But you know how it is after a while.” I didn’t mean to say that—I didn’t even believe in a

statement like that, but the booze was making me stupid. Before this could go any further, I shifted the spotlight to Jared. “You and Jessica?”

The corners of Jared’s mouth turned up. “They’re good.” My heart sank. That’s right, I also didn’t want to talk about *this*. Too late. “*Really* good.”

I’m not sure I could have left this alone even if I wanted to. With alcohol flowing through my veins and my curiosity piqued, there was no way I was leaving this alone.

“So, what’s your secret?” I heard myself say. It’s what Laura would have done. Maybe? I blundered on, not liking the implication that things weren’t just as good between me and my wife. “I mean, you two looked like newlyweds when we saw you the other night.”

Jared looked at the bartender, twirling his index finger when he caught the man’s attention “Another round,” he ordered. For the both of us.

I shouldn’t. Four beers was already one beer beyond my limit. Five—or is this the sixth?—would wreck me. That was the thing about alcohol though, right? The more you drank, the easier it was to ignore those consequences and keep drinking.

“The secret,” Jared said, weighing the word and seemingly deciding it wasn’t the right one. “You’ve been married long enough to know there’s no *one* secret with women, with marriage.”

“Sure.” I held my breath, prepared for anything—*we’re swingers, we have an open relationship, whatever*.

Jared’s hazy drunkenness seemed to fall away, and behind it lurked nervousness. He took a deep breath, steeling himself for the conversation he’d been dancing around all night. This was the reason he’d invited me down here. This was the confession. Had to be.

He leaned forward, ever so slightly. “It’s called a Brazilian bikini wax. Ever heard of it?”

I blinked, confused. I was expecting something darker, more risqué. Not...a bikini wax. “Jessica gets—”

“Brazilians. She takes it all off, and man, it’s fucking amazing. Changed our lives.” He leaned back on his stool, so far that he nearly fell out of it before he caught himself. “Whoa, tomorrow’s going to be rough.”

“Tell me about it,” I said, although my mind wasn’t fully with him. It had begun to float away, lost in the significance of what he’d just told me—or more to the point, what he *hadn’t* told me. They weren’t swingers, which

meant he didn't know that Jessica was fucking another man, which meant this man in front of me was a cuckold.

Jared prattled on. "I mean, I know it's not just that. It's the age. I'd heard that women in their forties are just peaking, sexually, but this is insane. I haven't had this much wild sex ever. Not when we first met. Not when we got married." He sipped his beer, then set the pint down hard enough that it sloshed onto the bar. "I'm actually surprised that you and Laura aren't tearing it up. She's a fucking babe."

"Thanks?"

Jared's phone buzzed and he fished it out of his pocket, reading it with a grin. "Looks like our wives are hanging out in our absence."

"What's that?" As I said it, my own phone buzzed.

Jared showed me his phone first.

[Jessica]: operation girls night out is officially a go.

"'Operation Girls Night Out'?" I asked.

"Jess thought that since they're home alone, they could do more than just go grab a drink after the workshop."

More? I caught on the word, unable to get past the thing where Jared's wife really had been cheating all along. I didn't realize how much I'd bought into Laura's rosier explanation of things until now, when I knew they were wrong.

My own phone buzzed. I checked it.

[Laura]: You lose the bet. Jessica showed up. We're going out.

My stomach sank. I wanted to text her back, to tell her to be careful, to tell her that Jared was clueless. I couldn't though. Not with the man sitting right next to me, or the possibility that Jessica was right next to her, reading over her shoulder. So I did the only thing that I could do.

[Me]: Have fun!

[Laura]: That's the plan.

What was the plan, anyway? "Does Jessica go out often?" I tried to say it as casually as I could.

Jared shook his head. "Oh, no. Not in years. But every now and then she talks about it."

"Yeah, same with Laura." That wasn't helpful. "Where do you think they'll go?"

“No clue, man. Let me check.”

“No, you don’t have to—”

But he was already typing. A moment later, we had an answer. “Some club called Ultra Lounge.” He shrugged. “I haven’t been out in almost two decades, so no way I’d have heard of it anyway.”

Ultra Lounge. I’d never heard of it either, but my mind quickly filled in the details of what a place like Ultra Lounge could look like—dim lights filling a small, intimate space where grooving electronic music fueled an undulating dance floor of sexy silhouettes. And somewhere, lost in that shadowy mass, was my wife and a known adulteress.

“I think I need to turn in,” I said.

“But you haven’t finished the beer,” Jared said.

He was right. Most of my beer remained, but I couldn’t imagine drinking another drop. “I should have stopped a couple rounds ago, honestly.”

“Me too,” Jared said, but he reached for my glass and slid it in front of him without moving to leave.

I pulled some bills out and set them on the bar to cover my drinks. “Am I going to see you tomorrow morning?”

Jared waved his hand, like it was no big deal. I had my doubts, but shrugged. I was too caught up in the idea of Laura out with Jessica, being seduced into straying.

Which was an insane thought that only took root because of the five-plus beers I’d consumed. On my way up to the room, I texted her that I was heading to bed and to fill me if “anything interesting happened.” I picked my words about as carefully as a drunk man could.

Elliot was snoring away on the other queen bed when I dizzily slipped into the pitch-black hotel room. He was a reminder of how far away I was from my wife, and how different our nights were shaping up. Hers was just beginning. Mine was ending in a blurry, lonely mess.

In the bathroom, I tried to rein in my thoughts despite everything pulling away from me. I had no reason to worry. Regardless of who she was with, Laura was still Laura. We’d been together for long enough that I had no reason to worry, regardless of who she was with.

But did I want to worry? Did I want to believe that maybe, under the exact right circumstances, my wife *could* slip? My swelling erection suggested an answer that I was ashamed of. I closed my eyes as I brushed

my teeth and my whole world slipped sideways—from the booze, from thoughts of Laura dancing in the arms of some stranger, from the thought of her dropping to her knees and staring up at him with those large, blue eyes of hers as she sucked his cock.

If I hadn't been rooming with Elliot, I probably would have been up all night, checking my phone obsessively as I researched everything about Ultra Lounge. But I *was* rooming with Elliot, and after fumbling with my phone in the dark for about two minutes, I realized I was too bleary eyed and clumsy to do anything like research.

I checked my messages one last time. Nothing. It was close to midnight. I set the phone on my nightstand, rolled over, and passed out.

*

The next thing I knew, morning light was glaring down into my face, and it felt like someone had decided to take a hammer to my temples.

"Didn't want to wake you up like that, Michael, but the buses leave for the tourney in about ten."

"Breakfast?" I croaked.

"Missed it. Don't worry, I told your boy you were taking a business call." Elliot was already tying up the laces of his shoes. "You look like shit, friend."

"Thanks."

"I'd suggest a shower, but..." He tapped his watch, shrugged, and left.

"Fuck." I rolled over, planting my face into my pillow, then immediately wished that I hadn't done that. Vertigo lurked in the darkness behind my closed eyes. Pulling myself to a sitting position, I briefly considered skipping the first game and catching a cab there.

Then I remembered I was supposed to be a responsible adult, and that I was here with my son to demonstrate said responsibility. I brushed my teeth, wet my hair to fake that I'd just had a shower, and dressed as hastily as I could.

I was in such a rush that I almost forgot my phone. Doubling back, I grabbed it, and turned it on, scrolling through my notifications. Baseball scores, people adding photos to Facebook, breaking news that I could care less about, and buried in there, a message from Laura.

I almost missed it. After reading it, I wished I had. It was time-stamped at 3:49 am, and when I loaded up the messages app, it was the only one.

[Laura]: i love you so much

Chapter 10

There were many reasons why my wife would text me that she loved me close to four in the morning. Most of them were completely innocent. The one I kept circling back to, however, was not, and so many of the circumstances surrounding last night made it hard to get away from it.

Out at a club with Jessica, the two attractive suburbanites would make an enticing pair. They'd dance and collect drinks all night from random men until maybe they met the two right guys. Jessica would invite them back to her place when the club shut down—conveniently at around three, but maybe a little later. Laura, drunk and maybe caught up in the exhilaration of the night, would agree without thinking too hard about it. The next thing they all knew, they'd be back at Jessica's stately home, in the living room, paired up as these two young studs reminded the MILFs what it was like to be in their twenties again—

“Hey, Michael, come on!” the coach shouted as I emerged into the harsh morning light.

I held up my hand, shielding my eyes. The bus stood idling, waiting. Flushed red, I ignored my hangover and my tormenting thoughts and hurried aboard. Pulling myself up the bus steps and down the long, narrow aisle was mortifying in a way that I hadn't felt since adolescence. It didn't help that I was surrounded by actual adolescents, one of which was my son, who looked embarrassed for me.

I found a seat next to Jared, who should have been just as haggard as me, but somehow looked fine, if unshaven. He grinned up at me and said, “You look like hell, buddy.”

I fished my sunglasses out of my coat and slid them on. “Someone plied me with too many drinks last night.”

Jared shook his head. “What an irresponsible asshole.”

The bump and jostle of the bus as we rode out to the soccer fields made me nauseous. For a solid ten minutes, I was almost certain that I was going to throw up in front of all of these teenagers—a true role model. Jared, seeing me turn green, even emptied out a plastic bag and discretely handed it to me. I turned it down out of pride, but kept my eye on it when he didn't put it away.

Mercifully, the bus arrived. The fresh morning air and the sweet smell of cut grass helped clear away the cobwebs, replacing that sickening feeling with a throbbing headache. I considered this a win.

The text and all of last night's possibilities returned. I tried to keep the panic down by rationalizing that she was just drunk and missing me, not guilty and next to a sleeping lover. In the light of the early afternoon, the lover explanation seemed more far-fetched than earlier. I was even able to text her.

[Me]: Someone was up late! You have fun?

I tried to sound calm in the text, carefully composing the response to be both inquisitive but not suspicious. Problem was when she didn't immediately respond, my paranoia went right to her with this stranger all over again. I pictured her in bed, the man behind her, his cock buried deep as she read the text, then tossed it back on the nightstand and turned into the man for a wet, over-the-shoulder kiss.

Worst part was that I wasn't completely disgusted by the scene. The more I thought about it, the more my arousal threatened to overtake my horror. It helped that I was pretty sure it was all in my head.

I looked at Jared, cheering on the boys racing down the pitch.

Or was I like that man, clueless as to why his wife had turned into such a vixen? Would I find reasons to justify Laura's strange behavior? Was this just the beginning?

[Laura]: I'll tell you all about it when you're home.

An ominously vague reply. That didn't help me cope with the rest of the day. Still, no sense in probing further.

[Me]: I'll see you tonight.

*

Bobby's team won Regionals, coming home with a cup and a trophy almost too big to fit into the car. Laura met us on the front porch as we pulled up, clapping. "The returning champions."

Dressed in a long, cream-colored yoga t-shirt and a pair of black leggings, it was hard to reconcile this Laura with the one I'd been forming in my head all day. She'd even put up a banner in the living room that read, "Welcome home, champs!" in big, blocky letters.

I'd come up with another possibility of last night, one that didn't involve strange men at all. Dane met up with Jessica and Laura last night at Ultra Lounge—or maybe he was just there, waiting for them after the class. They'd dance, he'd flirt with the two of them. They'd drink, get close, go back to Jessica's empty house and—

“Really? They want you on the regional team?” Laura said, embracing our son.

I shook my head and got myself back into Dad Mode. Ruffling Bobby's hair, I said, “Yeah, apparently there were some scouts there. They want a few of the boys from Bobby's team to try out.” My stomach trembled as I said this next thing. “It'll mean more travel, though, and fewer weekends when we're all together.”

Laura looked at Bobby. “Do you want to do this?”

Bobby did, and he lit up with an enthusiasm that always impressed me. This was Laura's personality in him, always willing to take anything on. “Totally. I mean, if that's okay with you guys.”

Laura looked at me, meeting my eyes. “I think we can manage.”

Did she mean anything by that? Or was I reading into it once again?

Hours later, after dinner, after Bobby and I had narrated almost every play of the final game, Laura and I were in bed, alone at last. My heart pounded like a drum against my hollow chest. Laura changed into a short, cotton nightgown, her face scrubbed, her teeth brushed, ready for bed. I tried to gather my thoughts, but it was like trying to collect smoke in my hands.

Laura crawled onto the bed and kissed me. “So you went out with Jared. Did you learn anything interesting?”

“Well...” Did *I* learn anything interesting?! “I'm not sure if I'd call it ‘interesting,’ although I would say that I learned a thing.”

“Yeah? Tell me.”

I sighed, wishing I could be as forthright as my wife. “We were wrong. He doesn't know about her...affair. He thinks that she's having some mid-life sexual resurgence. At one point, I think he even seemed to suggest that it's all because she got a Brazilian bikini wax, if you could believe that.”

“Did he really?” There was a lightness to her question and the way she circled her fingers up my shoulder.

“It was kind of awkward, you know? Knowing that his wife was doing a lot more than getting waxed, and sitting there not being able to talk about

it.”

“Sounds very awkward,” Laura said, but there was no empathy in her playful smile. “You know I spent most of today hanging out with Jessica, too, right?”

She walked her hand down my torso and slipped it beneath my t-shirt. I tensed, imagining Laura hanging out with such a bad influence.

“Ellen, Jessica, and I had a spa day.” She took hold of the bottom of my t-shirt and tugged. Together, we removed it. “It was a lot of fun. I learned a few things, too.”

My stomach went queasy as my cock stirred. Laura pushed her hand into my pajama pants, finding me more than semi-hard. She smiled at that. “Jessica really opened up.”

I groaned, but still had wits enough to challenge her on her non-reaction to my news. “I just told you that she’s actually cheating on her husband. How can you take that so calmly?”

“Maybe I know something you don’t.” She stroked me gently, feeling me rise as she built up her anticipation.

“What do you know?”

Laura straddled me, her cotton nightie riding up her thighs. “First of all, a Brazilian really can make you horny.”

My eyes went wide as I fought to comprehend what she was saying. She crossed her arms in front of her, grasped the hem of her nightgown, and peeled it up over her head. I drank in her athletic body, from her firm, little breasts to her narrow waist to the juncture between her thighs. Her trimmed bush was almost completely gone, only a narrow landing strip of light brown hair remained.

“You...did that?”

She took my hand and drew it to her landing strip, shuddering as I brushed my fingertips down and across her soft, waxed skin. “Uh, that’s so sensitive,” she sighed. “It hurt like hell, but Jess told me it was worth it.” She bit her lower lip as I stroked my thumb around her exposed clit, her lids drooping. “She’s so right.”

Taking my cock, she scooted up my thighs, lifted up onto her haunches, and teased my shaft between her lips. We groaned together as soft skin met softer skin. She used me like a toy, rubbing the crown of my cockhead along her clitoris and down her buttery petals.

“Uh, that’s good,” she sighed, her eyes shut now.

I couldn't believe she'd done what she'd done, and couldn't formulate the words to say that. I couldn't do much of anything but lay back and stave off a looming climax. Anticipation swelled around us. She had more to say. More to confess. I tried to prompt her.

"So did you go out last night?"

Laura opened her eyes, coming back to the present. Shifting, she positioned my cock against her pussy and sank over it. She was so wet. So easy to enter. "Yes. Just Jessica, Ellen, and me."

"You were out late."

"I was." She placed her hands on my shoulders and began to undulate her hips along my cock.

"Did you dance?"

Laura nodded, her eyes closed. Back in the moment? Reliving last night?

"With who?"

"Jessica and Ellen," she said, then sighed. Her eyes opened and she looked down at me through her lashes. "And a few guys."

I groaned, my cock gaining an inch. Laura's eyes flashed. She must have felt it, too, and I braced for the inevitable next question.

"That excites you, does it?"

I looked away from her, embarrassed, ashamed. She bent down to me, slowing her hips and tipping her head until we were face-to-face. "Hey, I'm not judging. I'm just...curious."

Her brows, which had been shaped into neatly tapering arches, were knitted together as she searched my face.

Disarmed, I nodded. "I don't understand it, but yeah, thinking about you...dancing with another man is weirdly thrilling."

Laura shook her head. "Not weird. We can't choose what turns us on."

God, I loved this woman. "So you danced with some guys last night?"

She raised back up, and I followed her body as she did. "A few."

"Did their hands wander?"

Laura blushed, her turn to avert her eyes. "Maybe one did."

My cock ached. "Tell me."

She forced herself to look down at me. "One guy kept trying to put his hands on my ass. I stopped him...at first. But I'd been drinking, and all the dancing had me—"

She cut herself off, eyes wide.

“Had you what, Laura?”

With my hands on her hips, she began bouncing on me harder. “I was turned on,” she mumbled.

“You were horny?”

“Yes.”

She placed a hand on my chest, her fingers splayed, and used the leverage to ride me harder. I reached between her legs, once again traveling across her smooth mound to tease her hooded button. She moaned, her hips surging.

“So he grabbed your ass?”

“Uhhhh, huh!”

“Did he do more?”

She gasped, losing herself to the inevitability of her climax. Her head lolled back as she bounced, bounced, bounced on my shaft. She tried to bite back her moans—a habit borne out of years of being a parent—but they kept coming, louder and stronger, welling up from somewhere deep.

I whispered, “Did you like feeling his strange hands on your body? Pulling you against him?”

Laura whimpered, shutting her eyes tight. My fingers danced on her sex, barely able to keep up with the flurry of her gyrations.

“Did you feel him against you? Did you feel his cock? Hard? For you?”

“Uh, Michael,” Laura groaned.

“Did that turn you on even more?”

“Fuck me,” she hissed. “Oh, baby, fuck me.”

“Is that what he did to you?” The question was a crazy one, completely fantastical, yet giving it voice gave it a realism that slammed through me like a detonation. My teeth chattered. My ears rang. “Did you go home with him, Laura? Did you fuck him?”

Laura opened her mouth—to answer, to deny. Her breath caught. Her body bowed. For one moment, she was silent, her moans cut short, her breath frozen. Then—

“Uhhh, Michael, fucking come with *meeee!*”

Her pussy rippled and squeezed around my shaft as she ground down into my pelvis, taking all of me as deep as I’d ever pressed. My own breath caught as the scene I was painting for her played out for me. I saw this man

groping her, going in to kiss her, leading her off the floor and out to the waiting cabs outside.

“Fuck, fuck, fuck, Laura!” I saw them making out furiously in the cab. I saw them tear at each other’s clothes as they entered his dark bedroom. “I’m there. I’m there!”

Laura’s orgasm swelled again, her cries no longer contained. Her eyes were shut tight. Was she imagining the same thing? Remembering it?

I exploded inside of her, holding onto the image of another man in my position, enjoying my wife as she enjoyed him. The orgasm came on like a sudden fever, horrible and delirious and overwhelmingly hot. Betrayal slammed through me. *How could she? How could she cheat?* Followed quickly by, *No, she couldn’t have. She didn’t.*

My confused thoughts tumbled through the long cooldown, with Laura draped naked on my body and my heart racing. I found the courage to form a question, although changed it to something softer at the last second: “So what really happened?”

The sweat on our bodies was still warm, and I was just recovering my breath. Laura shifted on me.

“We went out dancing... It felt so late. I had to go home to change after my class, and I really almost bailed. I can’t remember the last time I went out—to, like, a *nightclub*—so late. I mean, it could be twenty years.”

“But you went.”

She nodded. “I went.”

“And?”

Laura sighed happily. “It was so much fun, Michael. It’s hard to explain.”

“Because of the other guys?”

She chuckled softly. “No. Well, not *just* the other guys.” I was down for the count, but my cock stirred despite that. Laura had recessed into memory. “I used to go out dancing all the time, you know? And stepping into Ultra Lounge—so dark, packed with people filtering through the low light—was like going back to those times. There was this energy to it all. It was so carefree.”

She was quiet for a moment, remembering last night, remembering her past. “Do you miss it?”

“It was fun, but no. I don’t miss it. Certainly don’t miss the hangovers. But yeah, it was fun.”

I ran my hand down her spine. “So tell me about this...one guy who got handsy.” My gut churned. I braced for what came next.

Laura shifted, looking up at me. She was back in the present, memories left behind. I saw concern in her face, in her frown, in the way her brows turned down. “You know I was just teasing you, right? Nothing actually happened. I’d never...” She searched my face. “I shouldn’t have said that.”

“No, it was...” I shut my eyes, feeling heat race up my neck. “It was hot.”

She studied me a moment longer, just to make sure I wasn’t lying. “That really does turn you on, doesn’t it?”

I blushed harder. No sense in lying anymore. To her. To myself. “Yeah, it does.” I groaned, wanting to look away. “Just as a fantasy though.”

“Right. And I promise you, the reality was a lot less scandalous than anything you’re imagining. We danced with a few guys. Some bought us drinks. One guy, so, so drunk, kept trying to get his hands all over me, but it was *not* sexy. At all.”

I felt relief—but also some disappointment? I hid that. “Ah, yeah, I bet.”

“But today, at the spa, I did learn some interesting things about Jessica.”

“Yeah?”

“Well...” Laura bit her lip and grinned, like she was trying to hold her secret in for just a few more moments. The anticipation was like a weight on my chest. “You know how you said Jared doesn’t know about Jessica’s fling?”

“Yeah.”

“Maybe he does.” The light in her eyes danced.

Deep down, I knew what she was suggesting, but couldn’t formulate those torrid thoughts into words. I wondered if she could hear my heart beating.

“It’s wild, and a little crazy, but in light of what I learned about you tonight, maybe not so crazy.” She tugged on my flaccid member, feeling it stir sleepily. “Jared gets off on the idea of his wife having sex with other men. In fact, Dane was his idea initially.”

“What?”

“Yeah,” Laura said. The street light that filtered into our bedroom cast soft shadows across Laura’s animated expression. “Apparently they’ve been doing this since he was deployed overseas. She made us swear not to tell anyone because she knows how judgmental people in this neighborhood are.”

“Does she know you know?”

“No. Ellen was with us, remember, but I also don’t think I’m going to tell her how we spied on her through her back fence. As open as she seems, I’m not sure she’d be cool with that.”

“Good point. How did Ellen take it?”

“She was very...curious, I guess you could say. She asked a lot of questions about how it worked. Whether Jared watched. How much Dane knew. That sort of thing. Honestly, I was happy she was asking them so I didn’t have to.”

“And?”

“Well, Jared does watch sometimes, but Dane doesn’t know that Jared knows. As far as Dane is concerned, he’s having an affair with a married woman.”

“What a stand-up guy,” I mumbled. “I can see why the whole neighborhood loves him.”

“I know, right? Makes me wonder if everyone’s got such huge secrets.”

“We don’t,” I pointed out.

She shifted on me, kissing the corner of my jaw. “We do, though. They’re just in here.” She tapped my temple.

“That’s just a fantasy.” But was it? I refocused on the Earlys. “So Jessica tells you that she has an open marriage, then invites you out dancing with her?”

“No, other way around. We went out last night, after my class. This confession came today. Probably prompted by the way she danced with so many guys though.”

“So you don’t think she’s trying to...I don’t know. Corrupt you?”

Laura covered her mouth, hushing her laugh of surprise. “Oh, no. Jessica? No. Just because she’s, um, sexually promiscuous doesn’t mean she’s morally bankrupt.”

“Okay.”

I must not have looked convinced, because Laura's hand fell away and she got serious. "Really, Michael. I never really knew her before this class started—and let's be honest, my impressions of her going in were pretty messed up—but Jessica is Good People. Whatever she's got going on in her personal life doesn't change that. When she came over to pick me up for our spa day this morning, she brought blueberry muffins and a Thermos of coffee. I doubt even you would be so thoughtful." She finished her defense with a finger jab to my chest. How could I *not* smile?

"So she didn't try to use you as a wing woman? Bring home a couple guys?"

"Sorry to disappoint. The three of us left together. Alone."

Right, it wasn't just Jessica and Lauren, but also Ellen. I was disappointed, but also relieved. Ashamed because of it, so I changed the subject.

"In fact, when one guy started getting too close to a pretty drunk Ellen, she shooed him away."

"Ellen?" I tried to think of the cardigan and blouse wearing suburbanite flirting or acting promiscuous at all, and it just didn't work. Then again, Laura did say that the blonde was curious about Jessica's lifestyle. "You said she had some questions about Jessica's arrangement?"

"She did. I think that woman's got a lot more going on inside of her than the logistics of bake sales and strong opinions about garden flowers."

I laughed, remembering how the woman couldn't visit a house without commenting on the flower beds, often times with a judgmental undertone. I'd always found her attractive, in a pulled-together, makeup wearing kind of way, but also got the feeling that she did that because it was expected of her, not to feel sexy. Maybe we were completely wrong about her.

But that's not why I was interested now. I focused on Laura, brushing her bangs across her forehead. "And you were curious?"

Laura didn't answer immediately. She took a moment to gather her thoughts—and as she did, I wondered what kinds of thoughts she was really having. That scared me, but turned me on, too. "I already told you that I was."

I watched her, looking into her eyes and trying everything I could to communicate that this was a safe place.

She took a deep breath. "You want to know if it excited me."

"Did it?"

“Yes.” The one syllable answer slammed through me like a thunderclap. I almost missed the rest of her answer. Saw her lips moving. Refocused. “...not something I need. Or even really want. The reality of it is too messy. Too dangerous. Some things are left to fantasy. Like, you know, how you want a threesome with two women.”

“Who said I wanted that to be left a fantasy?” I couldn’t help myself, and Laura appreciated the levity. “I know what you mean. But...” I rubbed her cheek with my thumb. “But you also shouldn’t repress anything, okay?”

I felt this great weight on my chest, crushing the air from me, as I thought about what I was about to say. Laura nodded. She said something that I didn’t hear. I scooted closer to her—so close that she must have felt the loud and fast hammering beat of my heart—and said, “I trust you, Laura. And if you did ever want to explore it in real life, then I think we could work through it.”

I’d said it, and the weight was off. Now, the repercussions. The judgment. All the reasons I’d been so scared to say it in the first place.

Laura didn’t look disgusted, or confused, or even upset. She studied me quietly, a smile flickering into place. She kissed my nose. “And I told you, I don’t need to.” She sighed—not a sigh of disappointment or disapproval, but more a sigh of endearment. One that said: *I love you, silly man*. “It’s not about trust, or risk, or our ability to work through anything. I don’t *need* anyone else. I’ve got you.”

Simply put. The honest truth. Relief flooded me. “You’re amazing, you know that, Laura?”

She shrugged, giggling. “I do, but you can keep saying it to me. I won’t get upset.”

“The Amazing Laura. A new character, perhaps?”

“I don’t do genre fiction, dear.” She rubbed my nose with hers. “Besides, Jessica’s a far more interesting character to write, don’t you think?”

Chapter 11

The next day was a little embarrassing. Replaying the night before, I realized that I'd offered her a free pass to play with other men, and even though she'd turned down my offer and reassured me that she didn't need it, my face went red every single time I recalled it.

It took a couple days to get back to the playfulness we'd shared pre-confession. Or even to bring Jessica up at all. It didn't hamper our lust for one another, though. Just seeing Laura change out of her clothes at the end of the day, and catch a glimpse of the narrow landing strip, and I was all over her again. It looked sexy, but it was also sexy because it was a reminder of Jessica and her arrangement with Jared. It was a glimpse of my wife, doing what Jessica did. Just not all the way.

"I'm going to have to keep doing this," Laura said after we'd finished making love one night. She rubbed the bare lips beneath the strip—which was also hot to watch. "We haven't been this active in years."

"You won't have complaints from me." I brushed my fingers through her hair. Her golden brown locks were longer than I remembered, long enough to sweep down and cover her breasts. "You should hang out with Jessica all the time. Who knows what else will rub off on you?"

"Uh huh." She laughed. "But actually, I do hang out with her a lot. At the pool even."

"Right. The swim team." I'd forgotten that Carter and Bobby were on that as well. The thought of Jessica at the public pool in the string bikini she'd worn with Dane was a nice image. "Maybe I should take off tomorrow and hit up the pool."

"Oh, did they repair that hole in the fence?" Her laugh told me she was proud of that one. "But actually, there's a practice meet on Saturday if you *really* want to come."

"I feel like I just came back from his regional soccer tournament."

She smiled brightly. "You did."

"Last week?"

"Uh huh."

"You think maybe we've overscheduled him? I remember summers being lazy and long and full of, just, nothing."

“Oh, don’t worry. He does *plenty* of that, too.”

*

I ended up going to the practice meet after all. Since it was the first of the year, with the neighborhood pool having opened just a couple weeks ago, it seemed like everyone was eager to make a big thing of it. The morning was already heating up, high 80s by nine and the promises of a humid day.

The pool was closed to the public that Saturday morning due to the meet, so to my disappointment, none of the adults were wearing suits.

“I feel duped,” I whispered to Laura as we took our seats around the edge of the still water.

Laura nudged me with an elbow. “Oh please. You’d be here for Bobby even if the audience was made up of naked men.”

“I’m not sure that’s true,” I said with a laugh. I did like watching our boy compete, though. Made me proud. And even though the attractive mothers of Kingston weren’t in bikinis, it was still a hot summer day, which meant plenty of skin to try and not stare at.

Jessica Early was there, dressed in a distractingly low-cut, cornflower blue sundress, her full, pale breasts almost spilling free. Her cleavage was distracting enough that it took a couple minutes to realize that Jared wasn’t there.

“Okay, this was a great idea to come,” I said to Laura, who simply shook her head, a smile beneath her mirrored aviators.

The practice meet was pretty boring, honestly, except when Bobby was up. The swim team ranged in age, and since this wasn’t an actual competition, the younger swimmers also took turns doggy paddling up and down the length.

I spent most of my time people watching behind the safety of my own aviators. Kingston had grown a lot in the last few years, and while I recognized some of the parents, most were new to me. Dane was here, watching his daughter, who, despite being a year younger than Bobby and Carter, swam in the same class. *Just like her father*, I thought, *always excelling*.

Ellen was there, too, conspicuously sitting next to Dane as she cheered her younger children on. I nudged Laura, but she’d already noticed. “I see.

Now stop staring.”

I couldn't, though, and was happy for my sunglasses. They weren't obvious about it, looking more like two proud parents who just happened to be sitting next to one another, exchanging a few words now and again. But I saw the way Ellen played with the end of her blond ponytail when he was speaking to her, or the ready laugh she had for whatever he said.

“Wonder where...her husband is,” I said to Laura. “What's his name again?” We'd only met a couple times.

“Trevor. And he never comes to these things,” she said. I could hear the disapproval in her voice. “He's not really into...anything related to the kids.”

“Ah.” I looked across the way just in time to catch Dane looking down at Ellen's chest, her round breasts outlined in her tight-fitting, pink polo shirt. “Well, he better be careful.”

Under other circumstances, it would have been a meaningless line. These weren't normal circumstances, though, and Laura's “Yeah” was slow and thoughtful.

The meet wound on, less interesting than a soccer match, although I couldn't tell if that was more the sport or the fact that this was just a practice. Either way, I spent more time watching the crowd—watching Ellen and Dane most of all. If the man had a list, and I was pretty sure that he did, Ellen was now at the top of it.

After the meet, the pool opened up and someone fired up the grills under the pavilion. Burgers and hotdogs were sold on the cheap, and everyone began to mingle. Many of the parents left. It was our plan until Bobby announced that he wanted to stay and hang out with some friends around the pool. I wasn't surprised to see that one of these friends happened to be Jackie Harwell.

“He ask her out yet?” I asked as we watched our son join the gang of teenagers.

“Not yet. Feels like that's more a father-to-son kind of conversation.”

“I was hoping he'd just kind of figure it out on his own.”

Laura laughed dryly. “I noticed.”

A splash drew my attention to the pool. Riki Ruskin, one of the many attractive MILFs we'd gotten to know over the years, was in the shallow end, the water just above her waist. The tall redhead wore a bikini, and with her full bust, she pulled it off well. “Should I go home and get our suits?”

Laura followed my eyes, her lips twisting up into a smile.

“Just, because, you know. It’s so hot,” I said. “Humid, I mean.”

She fixed me an amused expression that said, *Uh huh*, without actually making a sound. But after a moment of thought, said, “If you don’t mind, sounds fun. It is...humid today.”

This time, it was my turn to follow her eyes...right to Dane Armstrong, who’d stripped his shirt as he manned the grill, flipping burgers. My chest tightened.

“Be back as soon as I can.”

Laura’s eyes lingered on Dane and his broad and muscled upper body. His skin was already glistening beneath the thin coating of chest hair.

“Take your time.” When she looked back at me, she didn’t look guilty. If anything, her I-know-what-you’re-thinking expression made *me* feel the guilt. “I’m a big girl.”

“Yes, you are.” I kissed her forehead and turned away. I needed to get out of there before I got too visibly excited.

“And Michael?” Laura said, catching me before I could get too far. “Please don’t bring me the bikini.”

She knew me too well. “Of course not.”

*

When I got back to the pool with our bag of towels, sunblock, bottles of water, goggles, Laura’s bathing suit, and a change of clothing, I found Laura talking with Dane. Of course she was. I wondered if she was doing it to tease me, or because my offer of a hall pass was tempting her. Either way, my adrenaline spiked to see her standing so close.

He was away from the grill, standing amidst the round tables that made up much of the pool’s grassier area. They weren’t the only ones there, either. Most of the other parents who’d stayed had moved into the picnic area as their kids played in the water. They weren’t even alone, although it’s a testament to how fixated I was on Laura talking with Dane that I didn’t notice Riki was also involved in the conversation.

Dane still hadn’t put a shirt on and his arms were crossed in front of his chest in a way that emphasized the thickness of his arms. It also made it even more intimate when Laura reached out and touched his arm as she

laughed at whatever he'd just said, adding something that made the three of them laugh even more.

My insides squirmed. I did all that I could to keep my erection down as I crossed over to the three of them. "Looks like you guys are having a good time," I said. "Hey, Riki."

"Hey, Michael. Long time. How have you been?"

Riki took a step away from Laura and Dane, and one closer to me, trapping me in small talk. Don't get me wrong, I think Riki's great—smart, witty, easy on the eyes. But right now, she was distracting me from the show I really wanted to watch.

"Looks like your son and Dane's daughter are getting close," Riki said, clueing me in on what they were all talking about. She glanced across the pool without pointing. I followed, and there, sitting on the edge of the pool with their legs kicking in the warm pool water and their fingers entwined, was Bobby with Chloe Armstrong.

"But I thought..."

Laura, hearing my confusion, looked across at me. "Not Jackie Harwell, right? Ah, the fickleness of young love."

I'll admit, I didn't love the fact that our son was with Dane's daughter, although it was unfair to her. She was nothing but a sweet girl, bright and mature in a way that most thirteen-year-olds were not. But she was also Dane's girl, so that came with some bias. Also, the messiness of Dane's divorce must have done some collateral damage. That, too, was unfairly judgmental, but it was there.

"Wow, that's...interesting."

Keeping her eyes on me, Laura seemed to glance at Dane quickly without actually glancing at him. *Remember, her father's right next to me*, she seemed to say. Instead, she actually said, "You brought my suit? Great. I'm burning up. Need to get into the water."

Taking the bag of pool towels, she left me with Dane and Riki.

"Don't worry, Chloe's a good kid." Dane grinned. "She gets that from her mother, I guess."

"Oh, no, that's not it," I lied. "Just thought he and Harwell's girl were an item."

Dane shrugged. This was my problem with him. The man was too casual about relationships. He didn't respect them. He was not principled

when it came to them. He thought he was fucking Jessica Early without Jared knowing about it, and didn't seem to have any guilt about it.

I looked at Bobby, who was now in the water. He reached up and pulled Chloe down into the water with him, then turned and swam away. She laughed and followed. I made it a point to talk to him about this. I didn't care who he dated or liked, but the last thing I wanted was for my son to turn out to be Dane.

"It was nice chatting, boys," Riki said, "but it looks like Joel and Marley are ready to go." We looked across the way, where her husband was gathering up their stuff and their sixteen-year-old was looking sullen and typing on her phone.

I couldn't help watching the busty redhead go, her bikini doing nothing to hide her pale athleticism. "See you later, Chase," she said, waving flirtily to the lifeguard on duty.

The poor young man stuttered and waved back.

She looks like she's fun in bed. The thought was delivered in Dane's voice, and when I looked at him, he was just as fixated on Riki as me. Our eyes met. He grinned, feeling none of the shame I did.

How did I get stuck alone with this man? I looked around, trying to figure out an escape route. I'd never really liked him—found him too charming to be trustworthy—but now that I knew things about him that he thought were total secrets, it was like I could suddenly see the Matrix. I wondered if this was how undercover agents felt.

"So..." I began, realizing that I didn't know what to say. I went ahead and put my foot in my mouth. "You seeing anyone these days?"

I half-expected him to look at me and figure out that I knew about him. If he did, though, he didn't show it. "A few people. Nothing serious."

"Just having fun?" God, what was wrong with me.

"Oh yeah." He laughed at himself. "Don't get the wrong impression though. Chloe there takes up most of my time these days."

If I didn't know better, I would have believed him. Even still, I *wanted* to believe him. He was that kind of guy. So it was easy to give in to the lie and say, "I know what that's like." And then, because I was overcompensating for the lie, maybe, I added, "Hey, you guys should come over some time. For dinner. I mean, the kids could watch a movie or something."

I felt like I was digging myself deeper with each sentence, but I couldn't seem to stop. "I'm sure Bobby would be happy to have Chloe over, and Laura too." *Stop, man. Just stop.* I snapped my mouth shut.

"Yeah," Dane said. "Sounds like a plan, man."

"What are you two boys talking about?" Laura's question drew us back to her as she walked up, wearing her swimsuit. It was simple enough—a turquoise tank suit that was neither high cut on her legs nor low scooped across her chest. I liked it because of the criss-crossing straps over her back, and just how much of her sexy back it revealed. Plus, Laura looked good in anything.

"Michael invited me over for dinner."

Laura turned to me, her brows going up. "Oh?"

My face lit up. I scratched the back of my neck before I realized how guilty that made me look. "Yeah, since Bobby and Chloe seem...friendly."

Anyone else but me probably wouldn't see the complete look of incredulity etched across Laura's face. The way her lips were parted just so would look natural. The gentle cock of her hip and the angle at which she rested her hand on it would go unnoticed. But I saw, and felt heat build along my scalp.

Then she let it all go, turning to Dane with an understated flourish. "Sounds fun."

"Great." Dane paused, thinking. "Can't tonight though. Rain check?"

Maybe he sensed the tension after all. Or maybe he just had a date already lined up. I almost asked him if he did. It was Laura at my side that kept me from blurting something stupid again.

"Absolutely," she said. Then, she blurted the stupid thing. "Hot date?"

The blush that spread across her face was deep, and her eyes went wide, like she was reacting to someone else asking it. It was my turn to look subtly incredulous at her.

Dane laughed. "No, actually. Meeting up with a buddy of mine downtown after I drop Chloe off with her mom. We're hitting up the new climbing gym."

Of course Dane rock climbs. "Ah," I said.

"I should actually get going," he continued. "Chloe's got dance this afternoon. See you two around."

Laura waved. "I'm sure I'll see you around. We can plan that dinner then."

My stomach fluttered at the casualness of the remark. She saw him around often? I knew they ran together that one time, but had they done it since then? I'd asked her not to. Or had I? I couldn't remember anymore. Stranger still, more than making me feel ill, the possibility that she had surged thrillingly through me.

"Great. Later."

I even liked the way Laura stared at his rock climber back as he went to fetch his daughter.

Without taking her eyes off of him, Laura said, "Dinner, huh?"

"Guy seemed lonely."

Laura finally looked at me, able to keep her face expressionless for only a second before she burst out laughing. "Uh huh. Come on, Mr. Hospitality. Let's get into the water."

Chapter 12

I wanted to know how much Laura saw Dane during the day—the man worked from home, after all, as did my wife. But I also didn't want to ask. It had nothing to do with a lack of trust. If anything, these last few months had only strengthened my faith in her. It wasn't just that we were in this little adventure in voyeurism together. The change also came from Jessica's behavior. She and Jared were doing this crazy thing, and they were still together. That opened this wide world of possibilities.

I didn't ask her about it, though, mostly because I didn't want to spook her. This was all new—to both of us. I knew Laura was just as intrigued by what the Earlys were doing. We'd certainly talked at length about *that*, but it was much easier to talk about the situation when it wasn't personal. When it wasn't about the two of *us* doing these crazy things.

What I needed to figure out was whether I even wanted that. A part of me did—especially whenever I thought about Jessica and Dane and the things I'd seen them do. Putting Laura in Jessica's place was always thrilling. But then I'd think about sensible, level-headed Laura, and it seemed so crazy. She didn't even like porn. She couldn't read erotica without bursting out into giggles, or pointing out every single inevitable typo. If I brought up actually doing any of these things in a serious way, I worried that she'd just laugh at me.

Beyond spooking her, or getting laughed at—which she wouldn't actually do—I didn't want to know if Laura and Dane bumped into each other throughout the day because I was afraid that she'd just confirm that she didn't, and I liked living with the possibility—as unlikely as it was—that she was.

So that's how life rolled along until the next Friday night, when Laura came downstairs, ready for class. She was in classic, casual Laura mode—skinny jeans, a fitted, plaid shirt, and a pair of Toms. Her hair hung in a long ponytail down her back. She kissed me softly on her way out, then turned and said, "Grabbing drinks after. Don't wait up."

I thought nothing of it. Did my usual Friday thing. Got ready for bed. I did wait up, though, on the off-chance that something crazy happened. The

anticipation was always there, even if nothing had happened since that first Friday.

When Laura crawled into bed a few minutes past midnight, smelling of alcohol and perfume, I got the feeling that something *had* happened.

“You have fun?”

“Yeah.” She unsnapped her jeans and wiggled them off. “Just me, Ellen, and Jess. And you’ll be interested to know that Ellen had more questions.”

“Oh?”

“Mmm hmm. About Jess and Dane. Actually, no. Mostly about Jared and his reaction. *Is he really okay with the arrangement?* He is. *Does he get to play with other women?* He can, but never has, as far as Jessica is aware. *What does he get out of it?*” Laura stared right at me when she gave Jessica’s response. “It turns him on, thinking about his wife being so naughty.”

My mouth went dry.

“Ellen just couldn’t understand it. She said her husband would never be okay with that.”

“And you?” I asked.

Her smile was sunshine. “I wouldn’t say I understand it, either, but I can relate a little more.” Her hand strayed down beneath the covers, where she found that I was stiffening up. “Ellen asked when was the last time that Jess got together with Dane. You know what Jessica said?”

Between Laura’s hand, rubbing along my cock, and the way she dropped her voice, low and husky, I was fully erect before I could shake my head.

“Jess said that she was meeting up with him tonight. After our drinks.” I jumped in her hand. Laura’s breath caught. “They’re probably together *right now*. That really turns you on, doesn’t it?”

“Not just me,” I said.

“You’re right. I think Ellen was also turned on.” Laura laughed before diving down beneath the sheets, tugging my boxers down my thighs. She didn’t do this. She didn’t hand out blowjobs like this. Not unless she was really, really horny.

A moment later, as I felt her wet lips swallow my shaft, her tongue swirling it, she confirmed just how horny the whole conversation made her.

I sank into my pillow, enjoying the slippery blowjob. I cast my mind to Jessica, possibly just a few houses away, riding Dane's cock at this very moment. But it was another image that got me going, that hardened me enough that Laura had to pull off and whisper something about me being so hard—that of my wife over there instead, sneaking away from her girlfriends and into Dane's bed.

"I'm surprised you didn't follow her," I said.

Laura pulled off me, pushing the sheet away from her. "I thought about it, but I had Ellen there with me." I couldn't tell if she was serious, or just teasing me. Not that it mattered. Either way, it was a sexy admission.

I said, "I still think about that, you know. How you followed them. How you watched."

"Turns you on, thinking about your wife being so naughty, huh?" She squeezed me.

"You know it." I reached down, guiding her up. "Come up here. No more teasing."

She slipped out of her thong and straddled me, still in her fitted plaid shirt. Any doubt that this was a turn-on for her was gone as I sank into her wet and primed pussy.

"Oh, you feel so big," she sighed.

"And you're so wet."

Laura reached beneath her shirt, touching herself. Like she needed any confirmation.

"Tell me why," I said.

"You know how I get after a few drinks." I stared up at her, and when she met my gaze, she rolled her eyes, up and away. "Okay, okay. I guess...seeing how excited Jessica got when she confessed that she was meeting up with Dane. She was all...flushed...but not like embarrassed flushed. More like...like she was..."

"About to do something that she shouldn't?"

Laura ground her hips down into me. "Mmm... yes."

"You're sure you don't want to experience that?"

Bowed over me, Laura gathered my head in her hands, resting her forehead on mine. She stared *into* me, even as the heat and lust of the moment roiled between us. "I've seen what he has to offer," she said, her voice hushed. "Of course I've thought about it."

Adrenaline punched against my heart.

She went on. "You want me to experience it, too."

I did. "I do."

"Ellen asked if he was big," Laura said. "Jessica told her that he was the biggest that she'd ever had."

I groaned, feeling close to my limit. My heart thumped, hard and fast, like a kick drum.

"She said that it was beautiful, too. Thick, slightly curved. Like a banana. Like something designed to put in your mouth."

"Laura," I said tightly. This was so unlike her, all this dirty talk. Part of it could be blamed on the drinks, but only a part. She'd been drunk before, but it had never been like this. Jessica was rubbing off on her, whether intentionally or not.

"I think that if Jessica had invited Ellen with her tonight, she would have gone."

"Would you?"

Laura didn't answer. Instead, she ground deeper into my lap, tossing her head back. I kissed her neck, where the collar of her shirt hung open, and could feel the reverberations of her moans crash like waves up her throat. Grabbing her ass, I encouraged her to bounce harder, fuck faster.

"Think of him, baby," I said. "Think of Dane's big cock you're riding."

Her breath caught. She craned back further, reaching behind her to brace herself on my thigh as she clutched the back of my neck with her other hand.

"Think of how different it would feel. How new and exciting."

"Michael." Her turn to sound tight, a wire so taut it began to fray.

"Not Michael. Don't think of Michael."

She groaned.

"Oh, Laura. I've wanted you for so long." The words just poured out like gravel along a metallic shoot. It didn't sound like me. It wasn't supposed to. "You're so fucking hot."

"Yes," Laura gasped. For a second, it felt like we were having separate conversations. Then: "Fuck me, Dane. Show me how much you want it."

Somehow, I didn't come, even as my balls tightened and my cock lurched. I grabbed her hips, digging my fingers into her ass cheeks, and I physically lifted her up and down my cock, thrusting my hips off the mattress. The bed creaked. The springs whined.

“Every time I saw you run by in your tight, little running shorts...”

“Yes.”

Her encouragement was real. Her excitement thick. “Every time you said hello, all I could think about was getting you back here. Into my bed —”

“Oh... oh... *Dane*.” She hissed his name, a fuse burning down to its payload.

“Getting you bouncing on my cock.”

Laura twisted over me.

“Feeling you come...” My breath came labored and loud. “...on my...cock.”

“Ngh!” Head back, hair so long now it tickled my thighs, she exploded on me. “Oh! Oh, yes. Uh, yes!”

She was lost in her own world, shut behind her tightly closed eyes, where hopefully, excitingly, she was thinking about Dane and how he would feel inside of her.

Real or not, that ended me. I thrust up, my abs burning, and joined her wet, molten release.

She melted down into me and smacked her lips like she’d had a very satisfying meal. The image of her with Dane lingered, even as she transformed back into my beautiful and familiar wife.

“It really does turn you on,” she said, more personal confirmation than question.

“Yeah.” No sense in denying it anymore. “Turns you on, too.”

She raised off of me enough to look down and meet my eyes, her hair a curtain around the two of us. I could still smell the sweet scent of her shampoo beneath her natural, earthy musk and the sharper tinge of our lust.

“It does,” she said. There was a “but” there, but she didn’t offer it right away. She smiled instead, enjoying the effect her confession had on me. “As a fantasy, it does.”

She kissed me gently before rolling onto her side and snuggling against me again.

“You know the thing that Jessica kept reiterating? Whenever Ellen asked about Jared, or why he was okay with the whole thing, Jess just kept saying that they talked. A lot. All the time. It only worked, she said, because they had such rock solid communication.”

“Makes sense,” I said.

“If he ever feels threatened, she would end it. Their marriage and their relationship is more important than anything Dane could offer.”

“And yet Dane has no idea he’s being used. That’s some irony.”

Laura shook her head. “Not irony. You need to learn to use that word.”

“Forgot I was talking to a writer nerd.” I slipped my hand up under her shirt. Her skin was still damp. “We have pretty good communication.”

“Mm, we do.” She looked so complete. “And I know that you’d like me to be like Jessica—”

“No—”

“Or at least the idea of it turns you on. It’s okay. But you have to understand, I’m not her. It’s not just that I don’t need anyone else, it’s that I don’t want anyone else, either.”

“But you just said the idea of it turns you on.”

“I get turned on by a lot of things. Doesn’t mean I want to do them all.” We chewed on her words quietly, separately. “I know you have a crush on Jessica. And I’m also pretty sure she finds you attractive.”

“She does? She said that?”

Laura ignored my question. “If I told you I was okay with the two of you getting that crush out of your system, would you do it?”

“No,” I said automatically.

“And why not?”

Because I’m not a slave to my desires. The answer came as clear as crystal, spoken in the smug and sweet voice of my wife. When I looked at her, she’d turned her head enough to smirk at me, almost like she’d said the words aloud. “Okay, I see your point. But...”

She regarded me patiently, a teacher coaxing an answer from a young child.

“...but that’s different. You wouldn’t really be okay with that.”

“Would it change at all if I was?”

I thought that one over. If Laura had my fantasy, if it turned her on thinking about me sleeping with Jessica, could I get past the ethical boundary of doing something so wrong? “Lacking any and all context, no, it wouldn’t change anything.” Laura began to nod when I added, “But if the circumstances were just right...”

I could see her follow my line of thinking, processing it slowly, thoughtfully. We’d been together so long that I knew her expressions. I

could tell when she was thinking of a rebuttal. She wasn't doing that now. She was giving the matter a fair shot.

She caressed my fingers along my chest. "Okay, I'll grant you that. If the circumstances were just right, I suppose anything's possible."

"Really?"

She giggled softly at my expression. "Didn't say it to get your hopes up, dear. I think I've also said the same thing about having a girl-on-girl experience." She had, but I mostly thought she was just indulging me.

"Wait, really?"

She nestled against me, shutting her eyes. "Anything's possible, right?"

Now I knew that she *was* indulging me. I let it go, let sleep take us at last. I didn't remember my dreams other than that they were filled with wild, sexy, and improbable situations.

Chapter 13

[Laura]: Guess who I ran into on the trail this morning?

[Laura]: You have one guess.

I was at work when I received the texts, and they immediately got my heart racing. Not even a week had gone by since our “right circumstances” conversation had come up.

Before I could reply, she shot me another text.

[Laura]: I invited him to dinner Saturday. :P

[Me]: Did you really?

Whatever I’d been doing vacated my brain. If I’d been walking through traffic, I probably would have been run over.

[Laura]: Your idea. Not mine.

That was true, and I would have lied if I said that it wasn’t thrilling. I picked up my phone, my hand shaking as I composed my response.

[Me]: But you offered.

[Laura]: I didn’t know how to end the conversation! It just came out.

[Me]: I usually go with “see you later”

I laughed out loud as I imagined her exasperated reaction.

[Me]: So is this running thing going to be a regular thing?

I didn’t press send immediately. I waited to see if she responded to my tease first, telling myself that if she did, I’d cancel the question. She didn’t, though, and with a deep breath, I delivered the text.

I held that breath until she responded, because I didn’t know how I wanted her to respond. Part of me wished I was there to see her reaction, or to show her that it was all just a joke. But I wasn’t there, and the text had gone out.

[Laura]: We didn’t actually run together. He was going one way, I was going the other.

A moment later, she added.

[Laura]: Thought you didn't want me to run with him? ;)

So there it was. She wasn't running with him. She remembered what I'd said after I came home that one time to find Dane in our kitchen. Made sense. But...

[Me]: Guess things have changed some since then.

[Laura]: Hm... I'm not sure. Wouldn't want to give him any ideas.

It was a tease. If she was with me, she'd wink. Or maybe roll her eyes at my reaction—which was a tightening, hardening one.

[Me]: Of course we wouldn't.

*

“Should I pull out your LBD?” I asked as we got ready for Dane and Chloe's arrival.

Laura threw a balled up sock at me. “You're too much,” she said with a laugh. “Even if I were so inclined—which I'm not—our son and his daughter are here. What kind of example would that set?”

This was Laura, sensible and mature. She was right. I agreed with her wholeheartedly. But it also meant that as much as I fantasized, this particular fantasy would stay just that—a fantasy.

Which I was fine with.

And yet...

And yet despite Laura's reasonable approach to the dinner, I didn't miss the amount of time she took to get ready. She took a long shower, shaving everywhere. She actually blow dried her hair, brushing it into golden brown waves that fell around her shoulders—rather than simply pulling it back into a ponytail. She did her nails in a soft pink—both fingers and toes, and while she didn't wear her little black dress, she did put on a nice summer dress—cotton white and patterned with small, embroidered flowers.

I caught her turning on her tiptoes in front of the mirror in our bedroom, checking out how the white cotton fell across her ass. It wasn't too short, although it did end above her knees, and while it wasn't tight, it was snug enough to require a thong. I considered walking in on her, busting

her self-inspection. Instead, I just smiled to myself and went downstairs to fire up the grill.

Bobby was out there, nervously dribbling a basketball in the driveway as we waited. Since the pool, Chloe and Bobby had hung out a few times, but they ran in different friends groups—being a year apart—and Chloe was frequently at her mom's.

I considered saying something to him, asking him how he was. Giving him some kind of fatherly advice. Before I could, though, I spotted Dane walking up the sidewalk with a blond girl who looked about as apprehensive as Bobby.

Dane was dressed in a pink polo shirt that emphasized the fact that he kept in shape—just in case we missed it—khaki shorts, and sockless loafers. He carried with him a six-pack of Stella Artois, Laura's favorite beer.

"Howdy, man," he said, jovial as ever. We went to shake hands, and he crushed mine in his. I hated guys who did that.

"Hey, Dane. Chloe."

"Hello, Mr. Richards."

Behind me, in a shy voice, Bobby said, "Hey, Chloe."

A blush formed over Chloe. "Hi there, Bobby."

Bobby dribbled the basketball nervously a couple times. "Want to play a few rounds of H.O.R.S.E.?"

"That sounds fun," she said, recovering enough from her bashfulness to add, "but don't you think one-on-one would be more interesting?"

I glanced at Dane, who was beaming with pride at his daughter.

"Uh, sure." Then, uncertainly, "You sure?"

Chloe's smile was more coy now, less sheepish, and held out her hands for the ball. He passed it to her and she took a few practice dribbles. "Don't worry, I'll take it easy on you." With that, she put up a beautiful, arching shot at our driveway hoop, hitting nothing but net.

"Good luck, Bobby," I said with a chuckle. "Come on, Dane, let's get those beers in the fridge." To Dane, once we were out of earshot, I said, "He's in trouble, isn't he?"

"She made All-State last spring," he said.

I laughed. "Well, this'll teach him not to ever underestimate someone just because she's female."

Dane nodded, grinning. “Wish someone had taught me that when I was his age.”

This is why I didn’t like Dane. He was too good at making me want to like him. He was cocky and confident, but could also be unexpectedly self-aware. Only I was pretty sure that was an act, too, just another tool he used to get people to like him.

I looked at the beer. “So you like Stella? Didn’t think you were a European import kind of guy.”

“Actually, yeah, man. I haven’t been able to get into the IPA trend. Too bitter for me. Hope this is okay.”

I stared at him, trying to see if he was telling the truth—that he didn’t bring that beer because he knew Laura liked it. I tested him. “It’s actually Laura’s favorite.”

“Oh yeah?” If he was lying, he was doing a hell of a job at it. Probably was though. “What a happy coincidence.”

No guile. No irony. He seemed to truly believe that it was a coincidence. I let it go, because it wasn’t healthy not to.

Laura was coming downstairs as we came into the house. She’d paired her dress with a pair of flat-soled sandals—modest, casual, yet still flirty enough with all those delicate, white straps and her exposed toes. I wondered how long it took her to settle on them.

“Hey, Dane,” she said. “Oh, Stella. My favorite!”

“Laura. So good to see you again.”

I looked between them. Was there an undercurrent? Did they hold one another’s eyes just a little too long? My heart trembled when I concluded that they did.

“Let me take those,” she said, reaching out and taking the six-pack from Dane before he could stop her. “Want one?”

“Sure.”

She headed for the kitchen. “Michael?”

“Uh, yeah. Love one. Thanks.”

Dane’s eyes lingered on Laura’s ass just long enough for me to see, although he was pretty sly about it. We followed her as he looked around the house, remarking on how interesting it was that while we both had the same model of home, we’d decorated and furnished it so differently.

Laura and Dane bantered about furniture and artwork. I watched, enraptured by the exchange. They didn’t flirt. Not exactly. Laura didn’t bat

her lashes and giggle at everything Dane said. Their conversation wasn't banal, an excuse to make eyes at each other. My wife was still my wife, serious when she talked about the way we'd positioned the sofa in the living room, and the window treatments. But it was still...fascinating.

I excused myself to go outside and start grilling up the steaks. My beer was already empty when I picked up the plate of meat, though, and I was too embarrassed by it to grab another. Probably a good thing, too. Gave me an excuse to pace myself.

Bobby and Chloe were still playing basketball—Chloe really was good. I left them to it, parking myself in front of the grill as my wife chatted away inside with a known adulterer. It was thrilling.

Not that anything was going to happen, I reassured myself. Not with the kids here—but even if they weren't, not even then. Unless the circumstances were *just* right.

I was daydreaming about one of those situations—Bobby and Chloe going off to hang out with friends and me suddenly needing to run to the grocery store—when Laura and Dane finally emerged from the house, carrying plates and new beers. Laura was laughing, and it sent my blood racing.

“Refill,” she said, handing me the long neck bottle.

“Thanks.” I eyed the plates. “We eating out here?”

“On the deck, yeah. It's so nice out.”

Dane clapped me on the back. “That smells amazing, man.”

“How do you like your steak?”

“As rare as you're comfortable grilling it,” he said. “But crispy on the outside.”

“A man with taste,” I said, flipping a filet. Fire leapt up as the grease dripped onto the coals. “Steaks'll be done really soon.”

“Great!”

We ate on the deck, enjoying the setting sun and a day that wasn't overwhelmingly hot. We switched to wine, the kids drinking soda.

“Man, it's really nice out,” Dane said, sitting back and taking it all in. “Thank you so much for inviting us.”

Chloe and Bobby, sitting in the corner, were involved in their own, quiet conversation. It was good to see them get over their awkwardness.

“We're glad to have you,” I said. “We should have done this sooner.”

“Don't fret about the past,” he said.

“*Carpe diem*, right?” I said. It was meant to be casual and offhand, but felt awkward as it rolled off my tongue.

“Hey, mom?” Bobby said. “A few people are going out to watch that special showing of *Star Wars*. Do you mind if Chloe and I go?” He took a visible gulp when he looked at Dane. “If that’s okay with you, Mr. Armstrong.”

“I don’t have a problem with Chloe going,” Dane said. “But it’s not my call for you.”

This was too similar to my daydream. It was uncanny. All that was needed was an excuse for me to leave them alone—

“I’m fine with it,” Laura said. Her cheeks were pink, and she spoke a little loudly as her buzz came on. “Michael?”

All eyes were suddenly on me. I felt exposed. I felt like they all knew my sordid thoughts. “Um, yeah. Forgot you mentioned that showing. Go for it.”

I’ll drive you. It was poised on my tongue, ready to come out with a little more courage. I glanced at Laura, wondering how she’d react if I made that suggestion. Surely she’d see right through me.

Before I could, though, Bobby said, “Awesome. Cole’s dad can pick us up. Let me text him real quick.”

Regret and relief washed over me. I was off the hook, and yet I wished that I was still on it.

The kids left us, but the grown ups weren’t ready to end the night. Laura went inside to get a cardigan, emerging with another bottle of wine.

She’d put on makeup for the dinner—a little mascara, a little eyeliner, lipstick. She must have touched it up inside, because when she rejoined us, I couldn’t take my eyes off her.

Dane even shot me a glance that said, *You’re a lucky man.*

Again, we chatted about this and that. We discussed politics. We talked about the school district. We talked about college for the kids, and how it seemed both so far away, and so soon. We talked about the new developments along High Street.

And all the while, I kept thinking of ways to make an escape, to leave these two alone, to let circumstances follow their natural course. I kept chickening out. I just couldn’t do it.

“Hey, would you guys like to get high?” Dane said, once the second bottle of wine was drained.

Laura giggled. She was at the giggling stage of drunkenness. “Uh, what?” she said, covering her mouth.

“Pot. Or hash oil, I guess is what it technically is.” He pulled a vape pen out of his pocket. “A friend of mine showed this to me. Apparently the era of head shops and glass bongs is gone.”

“Wow,” Laura said, looking from the slender vaporizer.

“So...” He said, leaning forward and holding up the plastic cigarette. “Want to get high?”

This was...weird. I felt paralyzed, flashing back to high school, when this scene played itself out almost exactly—cool guy, girl I had a crush on, the offer of a joint and the pressure to smoke it. I’d accepted it then, just as I knew I’d take it now. It wasn’t the first time I’d smoked pot, and it wasn’t always so awkward. But it was now.

Laura studied me before replying. She looked game, but uncertain how I’d respond. *You sure about this?* she seemed to ask. I nodded. What the hell, right?

“Why not,” she said. “Not every day you get to try something new.”

She said this looking right at Dane, and my stomach twisted. She was more drunk than I’d thought.

“That’s the attitude.” He turned the pen on. I expected it to light up or something out of science fiction, but other than a small, blue LED, it didn’t do anything.

He took a drag, just as he would a cigarette. Unlike a cigarette, though, the smoke that he blew out barely smelled like the marijuana from my college days.

Laura accepted it gingerly, albeit excitedly, like a nature enthusiast being handed a live and exotic snake.

As she lifted it to her lips, Dane said, “One thing to know, the hash oil is going to be a lot stronger than the stuff we smoked back in college. So no one is driving anywhere after this, got it?”

“After two bottles of wine, I think that was always the plan,” Laura said, giggling nervously. “Just...suck on it?”

Dane’s burst of laughter had the slightly maniacal edge of a stoner to it. “You said it, not me.”

Laura rolled her eyes, lifted the vape pen to her lips, laughed one last time, and took a drag.

“Whoa, boy,” she said as the rush hit her. “You weren’t kidding about it being stronger.”

She handed the vape pen to me, and again, I felt the discomfort of teenage peer pressure. Only the cool girl was my wife, and the cool guy was the one crushing on her. Not me.

I took it from her before my head spun off. It went down smooth, yet I still ended up coughing.

“Slow down, Mike,” Dane said. “That stuff is...” Whatever he said next was lost as the hash oil hit my brain and the world suddenly slid sideways.

“Intense, right?” It was Laura speaking, but sounded like I was at the bottom of a pool. I swam up, breaking the surface. My eyes had been closed. When did I do that?

“That’s...wow...”

“Right?!” Laura again, clearer. She was taking the pen again, her fingers brushing along Dane’s thumb? Or was I just seeing that?

“God, I haven’t done something like this since college,” she said, taking another hit, breathing out the nearly odorless vapor.

“Oh, that couldn’t have been *that* long ago,” Dane said, taking the vape back. His fingers definitely touched Laura’s this time.

“We are definitely not talking about my age.” Laura laughed, relaxing back into her chair.

Dane turned to me. “You doing okay there, Mike?”

“I’m great,” I said automatically, even as my head spun. A titter escaped before I could even figure out what I thought was so funny. “I feel like I’m a cloud.”

“Yeah, man.” He passed the vape pen back to me. I shouldn’t have taken it, but I did. The second rush wasn’t quite as intense as the first, but that hole I felt that I was standing in just got deeper.

Laura rose, slapping the arms of her chair as she did. “I’m getting some water. I can already tell this is going to make me thirsty.”

It took me a moment to realize that they’d both left, Dane following Laura inside. I intended to follow, but something anchored me to the spot. Part of that was the intense high and the amount of effort it was going to take just to stand. The other reason slithered through me, exciting and unsettling all at once—what if Dane made a move on Laura?

I sat for what felt like a long time, letting the hypothetical tickle my insides. My stomach churned with jealousy. My pants tightened until I had to adjust myself. I was too scrambled to produce concrete answers to the question, but felt the emotion of them like a crush of pressure and a warm hum.

Other than our empty wine glasses, the table was cleaned up. I looked out over our yard, our square plot of grass and its crisp landscaping. The lights were on in the house behind ours, and through the window, I could see baseball on the neighbor's oversized television.

With a sigh that felt better than it had a right to, I rose. My legs didn't wobble like I expected them to, and I only had to steady myself once on my way into the house. But my heart hammered against my chest, and for one panicked moment, I wondered if I was having a heart attack.

I wanted to walk in on something.

And I didn't.

It was...confusing.

The churning in my gut grew as I entered the house. It was so quiet in here after the chirping of the crickets outside, so still that my eyes went toward the stairs, toward the bedrooms, when I heard laughter erupt from the kitchen.

I tried to breath a sigh of relief, but there was no relief to be had. My heart continued to pound against my ribcage and my lungs were heavy and thick. I froze there in the door, wondering if this was it, and feeling the rush of that realization.

Laura's laughter subsided, but didn't entirely stop. She said, "He's not going to like this, you know."

"He doesn't have to know." Dane's voice hit me in the chest. I'd say it sobered me up, but I was so far from that that it wasn't possible.

"You're so bad," Laura said with a giggle.

"And you don't need to be such a mom all the time, Laura. Live a little sometimes. Remember what it was like before all this."

I stepped forward, drifting toward the kitchen's light—I was the moth, and this conversation was most definitely my flame.

"I'm not a mom *all* the time," Laura laughed. "And tonight is definitely bringing me back."

For whatever reason, I thought of that moment back in college, at the house party, when we were just friends and I saw Laura make out with that

guy. I thought about it without really processing why.

I strained to hear something. The smack of a kiss. A gasp or a sigh or a moan. Instead, I heard a crunch.

“Why do potato chips taste so good when you’re stoned?” she said.

“A question as old as the meaning of life.”

I walked in as they broke down into hysterics. They weren’t in one another’s arms, although they were leaning around a corner of the kitchen’s island counter. A bag of Bobby’s salt and pepper potato chips sat between them, mostly empty. The innocence was more disappointing than relieving.

“Hey, Michael. We’re pillaging Bobby’s junk food. His gummies are next.”

“So bad,” I said, wearing a grin goofier than I felt. “What kind of examples are we setting?”

“He doesn’t have to know,” Dane repeated, and it was then that I realized they’d been talking about Bobby and his chips, not me and the two of them fooling around.

Laura pretended to be shocked, indicating Dane like a lawyer presenting a new piece of evidence. If she had some argument, though, it was lost as she scooped up the bag of chips and her water, and headed into the living room. She brushed by me, looking up with a devilish expression that I swear said, *I know what you were thinking*.

Dane passed me next, putting his arm around me like we were brothers. “You’ve got quite a woman there.”

The mix of buzzes stole my ability to speak. I became a passenger, being guided into the next room, the next phase of the night.

Dane produced the vape again, passing it around. Any hope for sobriety tonight was gone, but I didn’t care. This felt too good.

“Mm, that feels good,” I heard Laura say. Again, I realized that my eyes were closed only after I’d closed them. Worse, this time I was lying down on the couch, a pillow tucked beneath my head. Had I done that?

Vaguely, I was aware of Dane and Laura sitting on the other sofa—the *loveseat*—I thought with a thrill. She had her feet in his lap, her shoes off so that he could give her a foot massage.

“You have cute feet. Dainty.”

“All my parents’ fault for starting me dancing at such an early age,” she said. She looked at me, and finding my eyes open—at least partially—a

naughty smile spread across her face. “You have great hands. You do back massages, too?”

“Of course.” I sensed him glancing at me and quickly shut my eyes, feigning sleep. Not hard when the light was low, the recessed lighting dimmed to a warm yellow. “You want one?”

“I’d love one.”

My cock grew and my chest rose and fell like I was hyperventilating, but I kept my eyes closed. Even as I heard them shift on the loveseat. Even as I so desperately wanted to peek.

“I cannot believe how stoned I am,” Laura laughed. “What kind of parent am I?”

“You keep worrying about that. Just let it go.”

“I keep worrying about it because it matters.” Laura sighed, whether because she knew Dane just didn’t get it, or because his hands were working their magic, I wasn’t sure. “There’s a time and a place for this. For me, that time is long passed.”

“Doesn’t have to be.”

“But it is. And I’m fine with that.”

They weren’t having an argument. If I ignored their actual words and listened to their tones, it would have sounded like a normal conversation, like they were discussing their favorite movies.

“As good as this feels, I don’t miss it.”

Dane didn’t answer immediately, but judging from Laura’s hushed groans, his hands kept working her. “Is she telling the truth, Mike?”

I didn’t answer. I pretended to be passed out. Laura backed up the lie, even though I was pretty sure she knew I was awake. “He’s out. He gets like this with wine. Add on the hash and he’ll probably be on that couch all night.”

“Too bad for him.” I couldn’t help but hear the innuendo.

“Do you do this often?”

“Give pretty women back massages? Yes, actually. As often as I can.”

“You’re unbelievable.” I heard her eye roll. “No, I mean the vape stuff. Getting...you know...”

“High? Are you asking how often I do illegal drugs, Mrs. Richards?”

“Goof.” Laura laughed. “This some kind of midlife crisis?”

Dane laughed. “Well, I may be having one of those, but this isn’t part of it. Actually, you may be surprised to know that Lisa’s the one who

introduced me to the whole vape thing.”

“Lisa? No way.”

“That’s the thing about her. Everyone thinks she’s this angel. That when she left me, she was the victim.”

“So you didn’t cheat on her?” Again, it could have been a sharp accusation, but Laura asked it with real curiosity. We had heard so little about how Dane and Lisa split up, although based on what we knew about him, Laura and I assumed it had something to do with infidelity.

“Well, yes, but it’s not that simple.”

“You don’t have to talk about it if you don’t want to.” I peeked now. Something about the tone. He wasn’t massaging her anymore, and she was facing him, their knees touching. The intimacy set my heart racing again.

“No, it’s fine. Nice, actually.” He shared a smile with her that was surprisingly vulnerable. “Don’t get to tell many my side of things.” He took a deep breath and began. “So the first thing you need to know is that we were swingers.”

“Like...” Laura hesitated, worked through the word, and came up with a “What?”

My thoughts exactly. Were all the couples in Kingston part of a scene we were just now stumbling upon?

Dane didn’t sound embarrassed when he said, “Yeah, like what you’re thinking. We had sex with with couples. You’d actually be surprised at how many others do it.”

“Like who?”

“Not my place to say, but I can tell you that there’s a swinger club north of the city. We didn’t play that often, but we’ve been up there a few times. And we weren’t the only ones from Kingston.”

“Okay,” Laura said, light and incredulous. “Like, you all go there and throw keys into a bowl?”

Dane snorted. “You know, everyone goes to the keys thing. The 70s really left a bad impression, didn’t it? No, there’s no bowl. No randomness. It’s a party, like any other, only a really liberal and open one.”

“Lisa did this?” Laura still wasn’t buying it, and I couldn’t blame her.

My impression of Lisa was similar—a healthy brunette with a hippy-vibe, who used to operate a knitting stand at the Farmer’s Market and taught yoga at night at Breathe Yoga. She always struck me as the more mature

one in the relationship. The one always bailing Dane out, forcing him to grow up.

“Oh, yeah. Lisa loved it.” There was a pause. “I know, right? Mind blown? You have no idea how dirty that woman is.”

He sounded wistful, which I wasn’t expecting.

“Give me an idea,” Laura said, although she must have been embarrassed because she immediately added, “Nevermind. I don’t want to know.”

Dane answered, ignoring the last part. “Well, playing with couples was fun, but the thing Lisa really enjoyed was sharing me with another woman.”

“Like a threesome?”

“Exactly a threesome. Well, actually, she liked to watch. That girl’s such a voyeur.”

“But she didn’t just watch.” I heard the fascination in Laura’s voice.

“No, she didn’t.”

“She...”

“Yes, she played with the other woman. She’s very much bisexual.” I didn’t need to see the scene to imagine the tension coursing between them.

“You’re blushing, Laura. Curious about something?”

“What?” Laura cleared her throat. “No, of course not. Just...surprised is all.”

“You ever think about that?”

“No, of course not,” she said in a rush. “I’m perfectly happy with my life, as I said. I have no regrets.”

“I’m not talking about regret, Laura. Didn’t you say earlier you liked to try new things?” I heard them shift on the sofa. Somehow, I kept my eyes closed. A moment later, Dane said, “He’s out, like you said. Don’t worry about him.”

“You’re not going to take advantage of me in this state, are you?”

“Do you want me to?”

The question hung thick and serious. I held my breath. My pulse pounded between my ears. If I could have stopped my heart from beating, I would have. I heard it, and almost couldn’t believe it when I did—the sticky whisper of a kiss, wet and tender and quiet.

I had to look, and when I did, I nearly had a heart attack. Their heads were together, tilted just enough that there was no doubt what they were

doing. Dane's hand was in Laura's hair, while hers was resting on his biceps. No, not just resting. Squeezing.

My erection sprang painfully against the seat of my pants, so hard that I had to shift. When I did, the two on the love seat broke apart, spooked by my movement. I shut my eyes, fighting to get my breath to even out.

Laura's sharp laugh cut through the room, diffusing some of the tension that we all felt. It gave me an out, an opening. I stirred, pretending to just be coming to. I opened my eyes groggily, blinking at the scene. Laura had scooted away from him, her head tilted away, her hand covering her mouth. Dane grinned, too, like he was in on the joke, not the focus of it.

"What's so funny?" I asked sleepily.

"Oh, nothing, honey," Laura said. "You have a good nap?"

"Not long enough."

"Come on, let's head upstairs."

"Bobby home yet?"

"Not yet, but I don't think the movie is over yet." It's funny, but it seemed like our son had left hours ago. Checking my watch, only two had elapsed.

"I should get home, too," Dane said. I wanted him to look at least a little guilty, but he didn't give me that. "I should be at home just in case your son tries putting the moves on my daughter." He grinned. Oh, the irony. "Just kidding."

"Thanks for coming over," I said. "It was certainly an interesting night."

"Hey, that's what I'm here for, right? Thanks for dinner. It was great."

He actually hugged the two of us, even though he was just a neighbor and we saw him all the time. Seemed like a fitting end to a weird night.

When he was gone, Laura and I just stood there, staring at one another like we'd just survived a tornado, and had a good time doing it. "You were awake for that, right?"

"Mostly," I said as she reached out and touched my chest. "Did you really—"

"Are you mad?"

"Are you kidding me? I'm sorry I interrupted you."

Laura just rolled her eyes. "I shouldn't have let him do that."

"Why not? Wasn't it you who said something about the right circumstances? Things seemed pretty right to me."

“Oh, Michael. You don’t really think that being under the influence is the right circumstance, do you? I may feel like I’m back in my early twenties, but I’m not going to be making those same mistakes.”

She was right, of course, and said like that, I couldn’t argue. I gathered her into my arms and looked down at her, putting on the most serious expression I could muster, given the circumstances. “So…”

She batted her lashes.

“What kind of mistakes, specifically, did you make back in your early twenties?”

Laura giggled, trying to pull away. I held her close. “You’re too much, Michael.” She shook her head. “You’re lucky I’m so in love with you.”

“I’m definitely lucky.” I kissed her, the way I’d hoped that Dane would have kissed her—long and deep and passionate.

Bobby walked in at that moment, and since we were still at the front door, he made a face. “Gross, you two. I don’t need to see that.”

“Nice to see you, too, Bobby. Have fun tonight?”

“It was good.” And like the sulky teenage boy he was becoming, he wandered down to the basement to play video games.

*

“Oh, Michael,” Laura sighed over me. With Bobby back in the house, even two stories down, she made it a point to remain quiet when we had sex. Usually, she didn’t say anything beyond a sigh or an escaped moan. That she said my name spoke to how turned on she was.

“You’re so wet,” I whispered.

“Uh, huh,” she agreed, but didn’t elaborate. She kept riding me, her palms on my chest, her eyes shut. Her hair was loose, framing her face. Her cute, little ears poked through her sweat dampened strands, making her look impish.

“Thinking about him, aren’t you? Thinking about that kiss?”

She responded with her hips rather than her voice, riding me harder, digging her fingernails into my chest. Still, she didn’t open her eyes.

“So am I,” I said. “In fact, I bet so is Dane.” She responded to that, too, the walls of her pussy rippling around my cock. “He’s thinking about how close he almost got. Probably thinking about how he can finish what he started.”

“Oh, yes,” Laura cried. She tightened her already closed eyes, really living that fantasy of hers—the fantasy I was painting for her.

“You liked the massage, didn’t you? You liked feeling his hands all over your body. You imagining those hands now?”

Laura bit her lower lip.

I reached up, filling my hands with her soft, warm breasts. Her nipples were hard, sensitive and puckered saucers of pale brown. This was the body that Dane wanted—and this was the way he wanted to see her. I got to see it every day.

Laura moaned, pushing her chest into my hands, urging me to play my part—to play *Dane’s* part. I released one of her tits, running my hand down her body, along her side and down between her legs. Her abs quivered in my wake, echoed a moment later by her soft cries.

“That’s it, Laura, think of him.” I swiped down her landing strip, following it to her clit, which ached for my touch. “Think of how it felt to kiss him.”

She crashed over me, tossing her hair to the side as her orgasm rippled through me. As she thought of Dane. I knew it was wrong, that the situation was bad, that if they’d gone through with it, in the morning she would have felt used and guilty and awful for letting herself be taken advantage of, but a dark place in me wished that it had gone another way—wished that it really was Dane in this bed with her. That it was Dane she was coming on.

With that, I joined her, consciousness and fantasy colliding in a wild burst of emotion and desire. *Oh, Dane!* I heard her cry, real or imagined, it didn’t matter. It hit me just as hard. Just as profoundly.

She collapsed onto me, and once again we were here, post-sex, talking about what-ifs and hypotheticals.

“You know, for a second there, I wasn’t sure what I was walking in on,” I began.

“In the kitchen?”

“Yeah.”

She spread out on her pillow, looking impish. “I was hoping your dirty mind would go there. I heard you come in.”

“You did that on purpose?”

She ignored the question, cutting to the real discussion we needed to have. “So I kissed him.” *Thud*. “You’re not upset?”

“Not at all.”

“How does it make you feel?”

It wasn't an easy question to answer. There were no clear answers to give. I tried, “Excited.” But that wasn't entirely true, so I added, “Also, confused.”

“Not jealous?”

“That, too. And turned on. Mostly those two things have me so confused. But you know what? I'm not angry, or upset. I don't feel betrayed.”

“Why not?”

“Because we talked about this. Because he's not a threat, and even if he was, I trust you. Hell, your judgment was about as impaired as it's ever been, and you still shut it down.”

“Well, I almost didn't.” Laura actually looked away, embarrassed, her face red. “And I mean, I still shouldn't have kissed him.”

“But you wanted to.”

She forced herself to meet my eyes. “Yes.”

“I'm glad that you did.”

She laughed. “Of course you are.” She buried her face in my shoulder, embarrassed. Whispered, “So am I.”

I could talk about this forever. It was so hot. But I also didn't want to push it. Laura was on the cusp of something, but I knew how fragile this moment was. She had to get here on her own. Just like she had with the kiss. With Dane. So I changed the subject for her. “So Dane and Lisa were swingers.”

“I know! So crazy.”

“Given that, I wonder why they split up. I always thought that he cheated on her, but if they had an understanding...”

“Whatever their arrangement was, he could still have broken her trust,” Laura said. “You're allowed to drive my car, but you better ask before you do.”

“So he didn't ask, you think?”

“Or did it with someone he wasn't allowed to.”

I thought about Lisa, bisexual, swinging Lisa, now so much hotter in my mind, and it seemed insane to jeopardize that. Looking at my wife, I reminded myself to never do that with her.

“Just so you know—and I'm in no way pressuring you to do anything—but if you ever did want to try...whatever out, you have my permission.

On one condition.”

She grinned. “You get to watch?”

“Well, that would be ideal, but I was going to say that you be honest. Not just with whatever naughty things you get up to, but about how you feel about the after.”

“Hypothetically speaking, of course I’d be honest. But you should know that honestly, honestly, I don’t need it.”

I started to tell her that thing about not being need, but want, when she beat me to the punch.

“And as shocking as this may be, most of the time, I really don’t even want it.”

“Most of the time?”

There was that sparkle. She winked. “That’s what I said.”

Chapter 14

Laura texted me, the Tuesday after the hash incident. Dane happened to run into her at the coffee shop. He asked her if she was free to run later that day.

[Laura]: I told him I had to check my schedule.

[Me]: I'm your schedule?

[Laura]: Uh huh.

I didn't dwell on my answer, because I knew if I did, I'd realize that this was not a good idea. On the other hand, the idea of her spending time with this guy that so clearly wanted her, and who she was attracted to, was too hard to resist. Plus, I trusted her. This was probably the closest we'd get to anything actually happening.

[Me]: Go for it.

We had wild, passionate sex that night. And every night that week. All I had to do was think about the two of them getting all sweaty, running together, talking about whatever, and I was hard again.

Friday was Laura's final writing workshop with her current class. It had gone so well that they already had her lined up to teach another session in the fall. On her way out, she told me that she'd be out a little later for their final post-workshop drinks. I didn't think much of it, hanging out with Bobby, then surfing the internet.

Then Laura came home, wide-eyed and smiley in her slightly tipsy way. "Dane and Jessica are at it. Right now." She was whisper-shouting, but immediately clapped her hand over her mouth, as if she'd spoken too loudly.

"Again? What are you talking about?" I hissed.

Laura shut the front door behind her and sidled up to me. I could see excitement dance across her pretty face. She was practically shaking in my arms.

"We went out, of course—"

"You, Jessica, and Ellen?"

She nodded. "The regulars. A few others since it was our last class. It was all pretty normal. Everyone had grown pretty tight. And then Dane

showed up.”

“Did he?”

“Pretended that he was just our guy friend,” Laura confirmed. “It did kind of end things. People calling it a night, closing out their tabs.”

“So how do you know that he’s with Jessica now?”

Her eyes brightened. “As I was leaving, Jess caught up to me and said that she’d left a scarf in the class and asked if she could borrow the Art Center keys.”

“And Dane was still with her?”

“Not right next to her, but he was still lurking by the bar.”

The audacity of Jessica Early was amazing. “She must have known that you’d know what she was up to,” I said.

“Well, she didn’t come out and say it, but she was definitely very smiley.”

“You gave her the keys?”

Laura bounced on her toes. “I did.”

“Now you’re an accomplice.”

“Jared knows about it. Dane is single. No crime there to be an accomplice to.”

“Other than trespassing. And possibly indecent exposure.”

“High possibility there,” she laughed.

“So...” I looked at my mature, responsible wife, wondering if I could get away with this next suggestion. “You think that maybe...you left something back in your classroom, too?”

I expected her to roll her eyes or shake her head in judgment. To say something like, *You’re unbelievable*. Instead, she looked up and away in coy thought.

“You know, now that you mention it, I think I did.”

*

When they issued her the keys, they gave her two sets, one for the front, one for the back. She’d given her front door keys to Jessica, so we snuck in through the loading bay.

“We probably shouldn’t be doing this,” Laura said as she quietly unlocked the rear door to the Kingston Community Center. It opened into a

rear hallway, empty and lined with closed doors, the narrow windows dark. Emergency lights filled the space with pale, dim light.

“We’ve come this far. Come on, let’s go.”

She took a shaky breath, nodded, and took my hand. Together, we crept into the empty building.

The community center was a modest two-story building that smelled like acrylic paint and wet clay. The tiles on the walls and the floor made me think of an elementary school, which wasn’t entirely off the mark considering who usually filled these halls during the day.

We’d entered from the first floor, but the front doors opened onto the second floor, which was also where Laura’s workshop was held.

As we went into the stairwell, it occurred to me that maybe we should be concerned about alarms, or a guard. When I mentioned as much to Laura, though, she gave me a funny look before saying, “Honey, where do you think we are? This is the Kingston Community Center. Now...” She held a finger up to her lips, indicating silence.

We had to be extra careful with each step in the echo-amplifying stairwell. It helped that I wore tennis shoes and Laura had her Toms on. We moved through the space like shadows, our hushed breath—on the brink of hysteria—louder than our footsteps. Laura looked back at me, giddy and excited all at once, and slowly pressed on the bar that opened the top floor door.

We heard them immediately, and probably didn’t need to be as sneaky as we were. Jessica’s loud moans rushed through us as soon as the seal of the door had been broken. “Oh! Oh! Eat my pussy, baby!” she cried. “Eat my naughty, married pussy, you asshole!”

“I’m the asshole?” Dane’s voice challenged. “I’m not the one having the affair.”

Jessica’s throaty laugh dripped with raw sexuality. I felt it as surely as if the brunette knelt down and wrapped her mouth around my cock. I shut that out as Laura peeked around the corner, then pulled me deftly into the upstairs hallway.

Jessica said, “But you like fucking other men’s wives. And *that* makes you the asshole.”

They were toward the front of the art center, near the main lobby—and definitely not near the class where Laura had hosted her workshop these last several months.

She tugged at my hand, moving us along the wall in their direction. The clink and scrape of a belt bounced down the hall. I hesitated. Laura didn't let me.

"Guilty as charged," Dane said. "And *yours*—" Jessica gasped. "—is ready to be fucked hard."

"Oh my—uh!" Something crashed on the floor, papers and pencils and what could have been paperclips, all lost among Jessica's moans. "Oh, you're so *biiiiig*!"

Laura and I arrived where the hallway opened out into the lobby, and where Jessica and Dane were definitely fucking.

The lobby was expansive—an airy atrium with a glass ceiling that looked out to the stars. Emergency lights illuminated the vast space from above, casting the couple on the reception desk in soft yellow twilight. Dane had Jessica bent over the desk, her cobalt blue dress hiked up around her waist as he held her by the hands and fucked her. She had an elbow braced on the counter and her head in her hands, fingers raking through her loose, dark hair.

"It's been too long, Jess. Too fucking long. You need to get away from your old man more often." Dane grunted.

"Hey, I was ready last weekend." She looked back at him, side-eyed and sexy with all that mascara. "It was you who was busy."

Dane ran his hands along the black garter belt that held up her stockings. "An interesting opportunity cropped up."

"Must have been to give up seeing me. Do I know her?"

Laura. He was talking about Laura. Coming to the same conclusion, my wife backed up against me, her body going stiff, her breath catching.

"Don't you know everyone in this town?"

"Is she married?"

"All the hottest ones are." I dipped down, pushing Laura's ponytail aside and burying my face in her neck.

"See? You're an asshole—"

SLAP! He spanked her.

"And you're my whore."

"Fuck you."

"How about I fuck *you* instead?"

Laura trembled in my arms, her breathing shallow. I wanted them to keep talking about my wife, but it seemed like the sex had consumed them

once again. They were so close, no more than twenty feet away. I could see the detail of the lace on her garter belt and at the tops of her stockings, and make out the red handprint on her ass. I could see the way her tits bounced in the low scoop of her dress.

Jessica sank into a deeper bend on the desk, thrusting her ass back and her head low. She reached between her legs with her free hand, moaning louder as she found her clit. Inspired, I slipped my hand up under Laura's skirt. Her skin was hot, her flimsy panties giving way to my probing fingers. I traced her cropped stripe of pubic hair down to her wet slit, easily pushing two digits inside of her.

Laura bit back her gasp, managing to stay quiet as she reached behind her, ruffling my hair before kissing me sloppily over her shoulder.

We were distracted with each other for only a moment before Jessica's loud moans drew us back to them. While Laura had to stay quiet, Jessica had no cause for restraint. As far as she knew, they were alone in an empty building after midnight.

"That's it, baby. Fuck me. Oh, fuck me!"

Dane slapped her meaty ass again, then grabbed it, squeezing. Drawing a squeal from the brunette. It was more aggressive than anything I'd feel comfortable doing—with Laura, with anyone, for that matter—but it drove Jessica wild. Laura seemed to react, too, pressing harder against me, her pussy shivering around my fingers.

"Come for me, baby," Dane urged. "Come on my cock."

"I'm close," she hissed.

"I don't want close. I want screams." He spanked her again. "I want to feel your cunt come all over my cock."

"Oh!" she cried. "OH!"

I fingered Laura in time with Dane's thrusts, and my wife matched with her grinding hips, stroking my cock with her ass.

Jessica reached across the desk, grabbing the opposite edge with her left hand to anchor herself, even as her right worked between her legs. Dane reached down, grabbed her loose, dark mane of hair, and yanked on it. Jessica screamed through her clenched teeth, through her flaring nostrils.

Dane fucked her through her thrashing orgasm, pounding her again and again, pulling her hair, spanking her. Using her in a way that she should have hated—that Laura should have hated—yet turned both women on.

“Fuck, baby, that was good,” Dane said, pulling free. Jessica lay flat on the counter, breathing heavily, limp and fucked out.

Laura gasped at the size. We’d seen his cock, and even at a distance, it had looked huge. This close, the reality of his girth seemed to thrill my wife. He stroked himself, keeping his erection alive as he leaned back against the counter, away from us, and rubbed Jessica’s bare ass.

“Love the stockings, baby. You wear stockings for your husband?” He fingered the garter belt at her thigh.

“You know I don’t.”

I wondered if that was really true. It was interesting that Dane didn’t know about Jessica and Jared’s game.

“Keep it that way. I like having something that he does not.”

Jessica rolled onto her side, away from us, and reached out to encircle his cock. “Oh, you’ve already got nine inches that he does not.”

Nine inches? That couldn’t be right.

“Nine inches that need to be sucked. Right now.”

Jessica looked all too willing to follow that order. She slipped down to her knees, her dress falling back into place, and took Dane into her mouth.

“That’s it, Jess-baby. You know how much it turns me on when you suck your juices off my cock.”

“Did your interesting opportunity last Saturday do this for you?”

I wondered if Jessica was actually jealous. She had to know that Dane wasn’t a one woman kind of guy, given his past.

“No. Not yet. She’s more of a project.” Dane reached down, running his fingers through Jessica’s hair. “But don’t worry, babe. You’ll always be my favorite project. God, you played hard to get.”

Jessica slurped off him long enough to say, “Didn’t want you to think I was some slutty bimbo.”

“You’re definitely not a bimbo,” Dane agreed.

“Is this...project?”

“Definitely not. It’s so much hotter that way. To offer temptation like a lure, then slowly, slowly reel her in.”

Jessica tried to pull away again, to continue the conversation, but Dane held her in place.

“But she’s up for it. In part, I have you to thank, actually. Pretty sure she knows about us, and I think you told her.”

Jessica’s response was muffled by the slab of cock in her mouth.

“I can tell in the way she looks at me. Checks me out when she thinks I’m not looking. The way she flirts when her husband isn’t around. She’s definitely tempted.”

I felt the rush of jealousy and pride and excitement. He was into her. If anyone was seduced, it was Dane Armstrong.

Then he did something that nearly knocked me on my ass. Without releasing Jessica, he turned his head ever so slightly, just enough to direct his in another direction. In our direction.

“Aren’t you tempted...” He paused, milking the drama. “...Laura?”

Chapter 15

I felt like the floor had dropped out from under me. My stomach sank. I went into a panic spiral. We were caught. We were busted.

Laura had sense enough to push us back down the hall, out of sight before Dane actually turned around. But still, when she looked back at me, her eyes were just as wide as mine, just as wild with panic.

I didn't breathe. If I could have stopped my heart, I would have. As it was, it beat like a nervous bird's. For one irrational moment, I thought that if I just didn't move, didn't emerge, Dane would think that he was mistaken. That we could just sneak away.

Dane said, "You might as well come out here. You can watch from the lobby seating."

Laura searched my face for something—something I didn't get. Not right away. Then, like the first tip of a domino, I did get it. She was looking for...

But that couldn't be right...

But maybe it was?

And like that, she knew that I knew. Without saying a word, she got what she needed.

Final permission.

I thought about what she'd said a few weeks back—the hypothetical that I couldn't *stop* thinking about. *If the circumstances were just right, I suppose anything's possible.* These were the right circumstances. Now what, exactly, did "anything" mean?

From the lobby, Dane called out: "I know you're there, Laura."

Go, I mouthed. *I love you.*

She relaxed, lifted onto her toes, and kissed me quietly. She looked hesitant to be so excited, but also excited. And nervous to be so excited. *Love you, too.*

She didn't jump right out there, boldly stalking into the light to announce herself. Instead, she crept to the corner, just at the edge of visibility, and leaned against the wall. Like everything was casual. As if *anything* about this situation was casual.

"So it *was* you watching," I heard Dane say. "Naughty, *naughty*."

I gulped, pressing myself against the wall, so close I could hear the thrum of the air conditioners through the painted cinderblock. I needed to feel something solid and concrete as the world seemed to crumble beneath my feet.

“You like to watch, do you? Come on. Come closer.”

“I can see from right here,” Laura said, crossing her arms in front of her.

I reached out, running my fingers down her spine. Letting her know that I was there for her, right behind her. She shivered.

“Laura?” It was Jessica, and in her voice was shock and concern—not because she’d been caught, not concern for her own well-being, but for my wife’s.

“Hey, Jess,” Laura said sheepishly. “You find your scarf?”

Jessica laughed in that high-pitched, sexy voice of hers. “You followed us?”

“I was...curious.” Her shoulders tightened, almost a shrug. “I’m sorry. I couldn’t help it.”

Dane said, “I knew there was something... You knew about Jess and me last week, didn’t you? When we were talking. It’s why you were so curious.”

“Maybe,” Laura said.

“Oh, Jessica,” Dane said. “Jessica, Jessica, Jessica. I’m going to have to punish you for this, you know.”

“I’m sorry. I had to tell someone—”

“Enough excuses. Why don’t you give our audience a show. Get back to sucking my cock.”

While I couldn’t see anything, I felt Laura react to it, her body tightening, her breath catching beneath my fingertips.

“Does that turn you on, Laura? Watching your friend take so much cock into her mouth?” I could hear Jessica working him, her soft, wet moans squishy and intoxicating. “She can take all of me, you know. All the way into her throat.”

I heard a gag. Dane grunted, followed by a high, feminine gasp.

“Were you touching yourself when you were watching us? I bet you were. Show me how.”

At first, Laura didn’t move. She just stood there, leaning against the wall, not fully committed to joining. I traced my fingers down her back,

carving along the crevice of her ass. Laura gasped.

“Take off your dress, Laura,” Dane ordered softly. “Don’t hold back. Your friend Jessica here isn’t.”

As quietly as I dared, I whispered, “*Do it. I’m right here.*”

Even saying it, I didn’t think she would. But we’d come a long way, following this man and the temptation of Jessica’s lifestyle until anything became possible. Despite all odds, Laura reached between her breasts and began to unfasten the buttons.

“Very nice,” Dane said. “What a sexy, little bra you have.”

I remembered the bra and panties she’d put on because it was one of my favorite sets—black satin fringed in white lace, like a naughty French maid. When she’d put them on this morning, I’d fantasized about how hot it would be for another man to discover the lacy things. Now, one had.

“You have a nice body, Laura. You have no idea how long I’ve dreamed of this view.”

Laura spoke with steadiness, her voice clear and unwavering and playful. “I could say the same.”

Straightening off the wall, she pushed the dress from her shoulders. I slinked back into the shadows, feeling exposed for my wife. Her thong matched her bra, the lacy frill plunging between her heart shaped ass.

“Your turn,” Laura said. “I’m not going to be the only one undressed.”

I heard a rustling. A laugh. “I don’t think you just want to watch, do you, Laura?”

“Not just watch...” She leaned against the wall again, her right hand disappearing in front of her, into her panties.

“Are you wet?”

Laura nodded. She hunched her shoulders as she was playing with herself, her knees bowing as I watched the ties of her thong stretch and contort. A moan escaped her.

I dared to reach out. To glide my fingertips once again along her back, along her bare and hot flesh. She reacted, gasping, shuddering.

“Mm, that’s it, Laura. Match Jessica’s rhythm. Think of my cock, instead of your fingers.”

“Uh, yes,” Laura moaned, the words spilling free before she could catch them. She was still trying to contain herself, and she was losing.

I reached up, fingering the catch of her bra.

“No,” she gasped. I didn’t listen. I twisted, freeing her breasts. She reached behind her with her free hand, to pretend like she’d done it, to avoid Dane’s suspicion—like there was any chance he’d figure it out. I squeezed her hand as the bra fell away. I wished I could have kissed the space between her shoulder blades, but it would have been too risky.

“Very nice, Laura. Beautiful. Your nipples are so hard.” Her chest rose and fell rapidly as she kept playing with herself, as Jessica’s gags and slurps filled the atrium. “Why don’t you come here. Come closer. I’d love to lend a hand.”

I squeezed her hand one last time, traced her spine, and gave her ass a soft pat. *Go. Have fun.*

Without looking back, she stepped out of her pooled dress, away from me, out of sight around the corner. Out of reach. I could still feel the warmth of her skin on my fingers. Things were in motion now. We’d passed the point of no return.

“That’s it, Laura. Come right on over here. Right beside me,” Dane said, followed by the hollow patting of the counter beside him.

I waited until I was sure that no eyes were cast in my direction. I imagined her weaving through the benches in the waiting area, her hips rolling from side to side as she rounded the bend of the welcome desk. I listened until I could no longer hear the whisper of her footsteps.

“This is what you really wanted last week,” he said. “To be a bad, bad girl. Only hubby was there.”

At last, I crept to the corner, where the hall opened up, keeping as close to the wall as possible. Heart in my throat and breath held, I looked.

My heart slammed against my chest. Laura was standing beside Dane. Standing *close*. He had one hand laced through Jessica’s shimmering locks as she continued to blow him, the other cupped behind Laura’s head. Pulling her close. Pulling her into a kiss.

“Hubby’s not here now,” he said.

“Oh, Michael’s here,” Laura said, finding some semblance of herself. She looked wicked, tipping her head forward so she could look up at him through her lashes. “He’s always with me.”

My lungs filled. My heart skipped a beat. I half-expected Dane to look in my direction. To call me out of the shadows. But he was too focused on Laura. He was too set on his prize.

“Then I hope he won’t mind me doing this.” He pulled her against him, leaned down, and kissed her. She didn’t hesitate. Not even for a second. Before his lips were even upon hers, she opened her mouth and accepted him, melted into him, took him as greedily as he wanted her.

It was a different kind of kiss than the one from last week. It was harder, deeper. Nothing was innocent or sweet or soft about it. He took, and she willingly gave. My body tightened and my vision narrowed, shades of green and red and the starry edges of asphyxiation. My gut sank as I watched Dane’s hand descend along my Laura’s back, out along her hip, pulling her closer, closer, deepening their kiss. I caught her moan as he felt her ass, his large hands palming her beautiful, round buttocks.

Dane pulled out of her kiss, but kept his hand on her ass, his thumb tracing the edge of her thong. “You aren’t just going to watch.”

I heard the command there. It wasn’t a question or a request or a idle musing. It was an order, and Laura was ready to comply.

“No, I’m not just going to watch.”

Dane looked down at Jessica, on her knees. The brunette was staring up at the two of them, her mouth full of his cock. “She’s a great cock-sucker, Laura. But she also knows how to share.”

Laura stared at Dane, at this other man, as if thinking, *Am I really going to do this?* Or maybe it was more like, *He’s such a fine looking man, this is what I’ve wanted.* Both thoughts rattled through me, both equally plausible.

Leaning forward, she kissed him one last time, deep, hard, pushing her tongue into his mouth this time. The aggressor. Her fingers played along his upper body, tracing his pecs, his abs, down his taut belly.

Breaking the kiss, she sank with her hand into the space that Jessica made for her. The brunette sucked one last time along the thick cock before shifting it in Laura’s direction.

Tentatively, Laura reached out, touching another man’s erection for the first time in a long, long time. He’d shaved it bare, making it look all the more obscene in Laura’s delicate hands.

“Show me what you really wanted to do last week,” Dane said.

Laura flicked her eyes back up to Dane, biting her lower lip in a show of coyness that no one here believed. Then, with a glance at Jessica, she leaned in and wrapped her lips around Dane’s cockhead.

“Oh, fuck yeah,” Dane groaned. He gripped the edge of the counter, his knuckles turning white, as my wife slowly—*slowly*—swallowed his shaft. She only managed about half of him before pulling back with enough suction that I could hear the *pop* as she pulled away.

“You could take all of that?” she asked Jessica, amazed.

Jessica, amazingly, blushed. “Took some practice.”

“I’m impressed,” she said, returning to the cock. Trying for more. She managed about an inch more before he hit the back of her throat and she pulled off, gagging.

Jessica took over, demonstrating her deep-throating technique as Laura watched, transfixed by the pornographic sight just inches away. When Jessica pulled back, she offered it back to my wife like it was a toy.

I didn’t know how Dane managed not to come, being passed like that by these two beautiful women. I nearly came, just standing there, watching without any stimulation beyond what I was seeing. I didn’t dare touch myself.

Jessica sat back as Laura got the hang of it, able to hold more of his girth in her throat before it became too much and she started to choke. The brunette slipped out of her dress, revealing a view right out of a Victoria’s Secret catalogue—black bra, garter belt, lace-topped stockings. Her panties were missing, so there was nothing to shield her glistening, cleanly waxed mound.

When she rejoined Laura, rather than waiting to take the cock from my wife, she dipped low and latched her mouth around Dane’s clean-shaved balls.

“Oh, fuck yeah, that’s good, ladies,” he said. “Share the love. There’s more than enough for both of you.”

I needed to remember to breathe. It felt like someone was sitting on my chest, pushing the air out. I saw stars. I felt dizzy.

When Laura sucked off and Jessica took her place, Dane guided her down to his balls. She didn’t hesitate, lapping and teasing him. Sucking each orb into her mouth in a way I’d never seen her do to me.

When they switched back, and Jessica kissed her neck, she only hesitated a moment before going to work, sucking his dick. The Sapphic exchange burned itself into my brain, and while it didn’t go anywhere, I held out hope that maybe it would.

Before that could develop further, though, Dane pulled Laura back to her feet.

“You two are good at that. *Too* good.” He pulled Laura into a kiss, like she was his. And she went with it. Like she *wanted* to be his. My insides squirmed.

Jessica rose along the opposite side of Dane, kissing up his arm, detouring long enough to tease his nipple with her tongue. When she was at full height—taller than Laura by inches thanks to her heels—Dane naturally broke the kiss with Laura, turned to Jessica, and kissed the brunette just as deeply.

His hands weren’t idle, stroking and caressing a woman on each arm. He dipped his right hand beneath Laura’s thong, following the curve of her ass. She gasped as he touched her pussy from behind, biting her lip and shutting her eyes. I couldn’t see details, but I had a pretty good guess what he was doing.

Breaking his kiss with Jessica, he said, “She’s so wet, Jess. Think she’s ready?”

“Only if she says she is,” Jessica said.

Dane turned back to my wife. “Are you ready, Laura? Ready to fuck me?”

Everyone in the room seemed to hold their breath as we waited for her answer, and Laura milked it well. She put her index finger to her lips in quiet thoughtfulness, even as they curled up in a runaway smile. To Jessica, she said, “Is he really that good?”

“Better, actually.” She shivered. “So much better.”

Laura turned to Dane. “Let’s see what you can do.”

“Now we’re talking.” Without warning, he scooped Laura up in his arms. She let out a whoop of surprise as he shifted her over, setting her onto the edge of the welcome counter, facing him. Grabbing her thong, he pulled it down her thighs. She lifted her butt off the counter, helping him out before she seemed to realize what was happening.

“Pretty,” he said, touching her landing strip. “Nice and tight.”

Laura grunted, reclining back onto her elbows as he pressed two fingers into her wetness. He withdrew them, lifted them to his mouth, and sucked them clean. “And sweet, too.”

“Did you expect anything else?” Laura asked.

“From you? Never.” Dane stepped forward, cock in hand like a scimitar ready for pussy. “It’s why I’ve wanted you for so long. I love *sweet* things.”

The angle wasn’t great, but it was enough. I saw him place his cockhead against Laura’s engorged pussy. Saw him press forward, sinking the tip into her. Saw Laura shut her eyes as the new sensation of another man rolled through her.

“You *are* tight,” he said. She wrapped her legs around his torso as he sank deeper into her, her thighs blocking my view of the actual penetration, but not the effects.

“Oh, my—” Laura began before she ran out of breath. My lungs went shallow with her. A moment later, in a rush: “Ohmy...yes! Yes!”

Dane steadied her, a hand on one hip, the other reaching out to fondle her nipples. “You feel so good,” he groaned.

I wasn’t sure that Laura heard. She was lost in her own world, besieged by Dane and the unfamiliar stretch of his super cock. Her breathing stuttered along, punctuated by gasps, by cries of *oh yes* and *oh my god!*

I didn’t dare touch myself. I didn’t dare move. I didn’t even want to blink. Missing even a split second of this was unfathomable. Prior to this moment, I didn’t know how I’d react. Would I be overcome with jealousy? Would I feel sick to my stomach? Would I feel humiliated and insecure, running away to hide and feel sorry for myself?

“Oh, my god!” Laura’s clear, familiar-yet-not voice echoed through the atrium. “F...fuck me.”

I felt all of those things, but rising above like a mushroom cloud was the powerful force of my excitement. This was happening. This was real. And as I watched Laura succumb to another man—not for me, and not just for herself, but for this wild journey we’d taken *together*—my love for her was as profound as that atom bomb.

Jessica was standing just behind Dane, one hand resting on his back, the other rubbing her pussy in time with my wife and her new lover.

Dane turned, craning his head so he could kiss the brunette as he continued to fuck Laura. When he broke the kiss, he whispered something to Jessica that I couldn’t hear, but nevertheless made my heart jump against my chest. Especially when Jessica glanced at Laura, seemed to blush, and gave a short nod. *Yes.*

“Oh, yes. Oh, god.” Laura was oblivious, lost in her own world of Dane and his cock and his hand on her breast. She sank onto her back, unable to hold herself up any longer.

“Touch yourself.” Dane commanded, and Laura obeyed. Free from having to brace her arms behind her, she reached down between her legs, dancing her fingers across her clit. “This isn’t the first time you’ve touched yourself, imagining this.”

Laura just groaned, lost in pleasure.

“Is it, Laura?”

“N...no.”

“Naughty. So fucking *naughty*.” He rammed her hard, grabbing her by the calves so he could pull her legs over his shoulders. She was still wearing her Toms, which would have been funny, but for some reason made all of this even more real. This wasn’t a show or a dream or a woman who looked like my wife but wasn’t. This was Laura Richards on that desk being folded in half by a man’s man as he pounded his hips into her.

Laura’s cries grew louder, gasps bleeding into sighs and moans. She clenched her teeth, only to rock her back and shout aloud, “Oh... oh, fuck me.”

“That’s it, baby. Come for Dane,” he encouraged. “Come all over my cock.”

“Yes...yes!”

Dane’s voice was tight as he said, “I’m close, babe. I’m almost there. You want to feel it? Feel my come, deep inside you?”

“Yes,” Laura cried. “Yes!”

My head felt like it had been dipped in molten lava. I felt fire on the tips of each strand of hair. A bead of sweat trickled down my back, beneath my shirt. I barely noticed any of this.

Dane turned, kissing her ankle, squeezing her leg. The atrium echoed with their wet slapping. With the sounds of their high and desperate cries.

“Fuck, baby, here it...comes!” He slammed one last time inside of her, throwing his head back. The veins in his neck stood out as he roared, a beast claiming his prize. Emptying his balls into my wife’s unprotected pussy.

Vaguely, I considered this. No condom. Bareback. His skin on hers, no barrier to their intimacy. It slapped like a betrayal...in all of the best ways.

Laura's orgasm burst as she felt Dane fill her. She writhed across the deck, raking her hair with her free hand, teasing and slapping her clit with her other. She linked her ankles behind his neck, drawing him into her, folding her in half as she came.

I almost joined them without even brushing the front of my pants. The pressure of my jeans against my erection was nearly enough. I had to look away, to force myself to breathe, to slow down, to think of anything else but what I'd just witnessed.

The sound of kissing drew me back. Dane kissing Laura, haloed in the glow of their mutual climax. Laura was lost in bliss, her eyes still closed even as Dane drew away. He pulled away with a collective groan, leaving Laura limp and splayed across the desk.

She didn't see the nod Dane gave Jessica. She didn't see Jessica suck in a breath and shift her attention to her. To my wife. To my wife's pussy. But I did, and I felt the world once again tilt on its side.

Dane stepped away, and Jessica filled his space, sinking down to her knees between Laura's thighs.

No way, I mouthed to myself. My eyes stung from not blinking.

Jessica glanced one last time at Dane, who nodded and grinned and looked on with eager anticipation. Turning back to my wife with fire in her eyes, she brushed her soft hands along Laura's thighs and lowered her lips to Laura's pussy.

I watched Laura as her mouth parted in a gasp—followed almost immediately by confusion. Her eyes popped open as she pushed back up on her elbows, glancing down her body, down to Jessica's pretty and very feminine face. Her eyes went wide. Her mouth opened, a protest ready. Her head had already begun to shake when Jessica darted her tongue across Laura's clit.

Her protest faltered with a shiver and a shudder. Jessica kissed her mound loudly before running her tongue down Laura's slit and sliding it deep. Despite herself, despite how wrong I knew she felt this was, Laura moaned.

"Just go with it," Dane said, moving around to the other side of the counter, where he could stroke my wife's hair and pull her hands back over her head, forcing her flat onto her back. "This is your first time with another woman?"

"Yes," she hissed, breath short.

“But not the first time you’ve thought of it.” He caressed her face, her neck. He slid his fingers into her mouth and she willfully sucked on it—as if needing to prove her sexuality. “I noticed the way you reacted when I told you that Lisa liked girls. You’re curious. It’s okay.”

“Noo...” Laura’s denial transformed into a moan, betraying its authenticity.

“You don’t want me to tell her to stop, do you?”

This time, her no was clearer. She didn’t want that. She wanted Jessica to continue. To keep eating Dane’s come from her pussy.

“Then just relax, Laura. Tonight’s all about trying new things. That’s why you followed us, isn’t it?”

“Uh, yes!” Laura thrust her chest up and her head back into the counter.

“You wanted to get caught, didn’t you, you naughty girl?”

I knew that she hadn’t, but the idea that she had was too delicious not to make my head spin.

“You came in here in your thong and your pretty dress, with your pussy shaved so neatly, hoping that maybe, just maybe, things would get wild.”

Laura said nothing, lost in her moans, in yet another building orgasm. She draped her legs over Jessica’s back, moaning around Dane’s fingers as he began to play with her nipples. Jessica pushed two fingers of her own into my wife’s pussy, shifting her focus up to her clit.

“You’re going to be a good friend and return the favor, aren’t you?” Dane asked.

Laura cried out, cresting.

“Because I plan on fucking you again as I watch you lick your first pussy.”

I came. It caught me by surprise—as fast and violent as a car crash. I gritted my teeth and stifled all sound as I exploded in my pants, seeing stars and fire and the image of my wife coming on the mouth of another woman. Sound receded. Perception dulled for an aching, exploding moment.

Then, it was back, loud and raucous. Laura screaming. Dane shouting encouragement. Jessica crawling onto the counter, her body nude now but for her garterbelt and stockings. Crawling up Laura’s panting body, her tits dangling, caressing. Laura opened her eyes enough to see her friend over

her, dipping her head in for a hungry kiss that Laura returned without hesitation.

“Beautiful, you two. So hot.” Dane settled into the swivel chair behind the welcome desk, his cock already back to its full and impressive length.

Jessica broke the kiss, but kept her face close to Laura’s as she looked over at Dane. When she laughed, it was more for Laura. More as if to say, *Can you believe this guy?*

Laura, still lying on her back, looked, too, tipping her back to admire him upside down. From my vantage, I saw almost what Dane saw—two beautiful women, lying on top of one another, looking at him with lust in their eyes. Slowly, he stroked himself, up and down, drawing Laura’s attention back to it.

“I’m ready,” he said. “Climb on over.”

Jessica whispered something I couldn’t hear, laughing softly. She kissed Laura’s neck one last time, then climbed off of her. Free, Laura swiveled around to Dane’s side of the counter, straddling him in the chair. She moved with purpose, free from any hesitation or guilt. It was Laura who guided Dane’s cock to her pussy. It was Laura, ultimately, who sank atop him, taking his cock back inside of her with a shared gasp.

Watching my wife ride another man was like seeing her the way I used to, back when we were just dating and everything was new. It wasn’t that she *looked* younger—I actually preferred the curves she had now to back then. It was more the exuberance in the way she bounced in Dane’s lap. The way she wrapped her arms around his neck so she could fuck him harder. The way she gave all of herself to indulge in this moment. So carefree. So sexual.

I’d caught a glimpse of it when I’d watched her blow vape smoke and giggle last week. I could imagine that scene transforming into this one, if we were younger and we hadn’t been together.

I couldn’t stop looking at the way he held her by the ass, urging her up and down the length of him. It was sex as sport, a give and take and take some more between two people who couldn’t get enough.

“Baby, you feel so fucking good,” Dane said with bated breath. “You feel...so...good.”

Laura sighed into his compliments, bouncing faster. She dug her nails into the muscular meat of his shoulders and neck, tossing her head back to come again, to lose herself with Dane’s thickness spreading her open.

Jessica moved again, her clicking heels drawing my attention back to her voluptuous beauty. She strutted around the counter, the garters and stockings still in place, but nothing more. She traced her red-painted nails along Dane's chest, hopping the short distance to my wife. Laura gasped as the other woman stroked her fingertips down her back as she passed.

"Time to return the favor," Dane told my wife. Jessica perched herself at the edge of the counter, just in front of Dane and Laura, and placed a stiletto heel on the small of Laura's back.

Dane continued. "I can tell that it turns you on, Laura. I can feel you tighten when you think about it. You like the idea of being so naughty, don't you?"

Laura groaned.

"I bet you really like being told to be naughty. Yes?"

Laura folded into Dane, burying her face in his shoulder, even as he began to pull her hips away. Before he positioned her facing forward, though, she lifted her eyes and found me in the dark.

It was like that moment when a dream suddenly becomes lucid, when you remember yourself as actor, as participant, not just observer. I wasn't just watching them. I was a part of this, connected by Laura and our love and all the little moments that led us here. And despite my earlier orgasm, despite the cooling come in my boxers, I was hard again, achingly so.

Laura lifted off Dane, kissed him one last, gut-wrenching time, and turned in his lap. She sank back onto his cock, facing away from him, from me. Facing Jessica as the brunette lifted a leg onto the swivel chair and parted her thighs.

Dane wheeled them closer, pushing Laura down between Jessica's legs.

I had just enough of an angle to see my wife sink her face down between another woman's thighs and run her tongue along another woman's pussy for the first time in her life.

Jessica tossed her hair, licking her lips as Laura explored her.

"You like that, Jess?" Dane said.

"Yes, it's good—" She gasped, like she'd touched a hot pan. "So good. Yes. There...oh, right there."

"There what?" Dane went in. "She's new to this. Need to be more specific."

“Keep doing that to my clit—yes! And...mmm...and use your fingers...haaa...yes, there. Right...there...”

I realized that Laura wasn't just teasing Jessica with her mouth, but had added her right hand to the mix, flashing in and out of the other woman.

Dane watched the girl-on-girl action, slowly stroking Laura's back as he let her settle in. That patience, however, didn't last long. Grabbing her by the hips, he began to lift and lower her along his shaft, fucking her with sheer force of will. Just watching it exhausted me, but Dane didn't seem to tire at all. When he spoke, he wasn't out of breath, his words weren't clipped. “That's it, Laura, lick that pussy. Finger that cunt of hers.”

Laura moaned—the cock and the dirty language and the order seeming to get to her—and the moans reverberated across Jessica's pussy.

“You know Jessica's always had the hots for you, right, Laura?”

Jessica moaned, neither a denial or confirmation.

“She told me how she's played with herself, imagining fooling around with you.” He fucked her harder, manhandling her like she weighed nothing. To Jessica, he said, “Told you she'd be up for it. Told you this one's got a slutty side.”

Jessica tossed her head back, thrusting her chest upwards, her nipples hard and swollen, and cried out her climax. Her moans echoed through the open space. If I hadn't just come, this would have triggered it. It triggered Laura's, who joined her friend, unable to keep her face between the other woman's thighs.

She arched back, reaching behind her for Dane, her mouth seeking his in a sloppy, messy kiss. He stood, lifting her off the chair without actually pulling free, and bent her over the counter—the same position we'd walked in on when it was just Jessica and we were just going to watch. Oh, how long ago did that feel.

This time, though, Jessica was right there, recovering from her orgasm even as Laura draped herself all over her. She pulled Laura close, kissing her wetly, whispering things that I wished I could hear, that drove Laura deeper into her bliss.

Dane slapped Laura's ass, his thrusts growing wild, uncontained. He was closing in on an orgasm of his own, riding out the last leg. Laura couldn't keep kissing Jessica. She buried her face in the other woman's rich mane of hair as her cries hit a sustained staccato.

“That’s it, baby. Scream. Scream for me,” Dane barked, slamming his cock into Laura again and again.

The raw sounds of sex sucked the air from my lungs. I was touching myself through my jeans, rubbing myself, my fear of coming gone—my fear of getting caught virtually nil. When had I stepped forward? When had I moved so close to the light?

It was at that moment that Jessica glanced in my direction, seeing me. Her eyes went wide. Her mouth hung open.

I put my finger to my lips. *Shh, shh*. Somehow I knew she wouldn’t tell. Maybe it was the naughty smile. Maybe it was the way her dark eyes danced. Or maybe it was how she pushed her fingers up Laura’s neck, grabbed her by the ponytail, and pulled her back in for a deep, torrid kiss.

Dane slapped Laura’s ass one last time, dug his hands into her meaty ass, and exploded inside her. Once again. One last time.

I wondered if this would really be the last time. The thought frightened me as much as it excited.

“Oh, fuck, Laura. Take it. Take my come.”

Laura moaned with him, breaking her kiss as her orgasm swelled once again, cutting through her. Her cries rose, so familiar, yet so strange given this context. Out-of-body, certainly out of my mind. I almost joined her, but didn’t. I wanted to save myself for later. Needed something to reclaim her.

I sank back into the darkness of the hall before the threesome recovered, although I didn’t leave. Instead, I pressed myself against the painted cinderblock hallway, my chest rising and falling as I fought to get my breathing under control.

I heard the giggles and the sighs as the trio disentangled themselves—the intimate sounds of post-sex.

“God, you two are sexy,” I heard Dane say. “Next time, I want to watch the two of you sixty-nine. I love watching two chicks just go at it like that.”

Laura spoke, and I could hear the amusement in her voice. “Sorry to break it to you, but there probably won’t be a next time.”

“Don’t tell me you didn’t enjoy it. I *know* you enjoyed it.”

I heard the smack of a kiss, and when Laura spoke again, her voice was practically a purr. “Oh, I enjoyed it. But I’m also a happily married woman.”

I felt relief before I even realized that I'd been seeking it. There'd always be a certain amount of anxiety with this fantasy, but I let go the last of my fear with Laura's reassurance. She had fun, but she didn't *need* it.

"That's what they all say," Dane said.

"Feel free to believe what you want to believe, honey," Laura said.

"Playing hard to get just ups the price of admission. Next time, you're going to spread wide for me and take my pole right up your tight little ass."

He was an arrogant prick, but the idea of it gave me a guilty thrill. I wondered if Laura felt the same.

My wife snorted.

Jessica laughed. "Looks like you're losing your touch, Dane."

"Well, I should get going," Laura said. I heard a kiss and wondered who it was between. "Before Michael wonders where I am."

"Wouldn't want him to worry," Jessica said. I could almost hear the wink. "Call me tomorrow. Let's get some coffee."

"Okay," Laura said.

Dane said, his voice laden with suggestion. "See you around, Laura."

The women just laughed, and as Laura rounded the corner, the smile on her face was contagious. *Ready to go?* Laura mouthed.

I nodded as she slipped her arm around me and leaned her head against my shoulder. She smelled like sex and walked with a ginger step, but she was with me. She was back.

Behind us, Dane said to Jessica, "So how well do you know Riki Ruskin?"

Jessica laughed in mock incredulity. "You're lucky I don't get jealous."

"You know I share my toys."

We pushed into the stairwell silently, cutting off the last of them. Leaving the two of us alone.

"You're a toy now," I whispered.

Laura turned to me, stopping at the top of the stairs. She put her hands on my shoulders and stared up at me. "Definitely felt like one."

There was a question in her statement, and I knew her well enough to hear it as surely as if she'd spoken it aloud. "We're good, Laura. You're amazing."

She blushed. She *actually* blushed, despite everything. I loved her so much. "I can't believe I did that."

"What? Fuck another man? Or go down on another woman?"

She tittered. "Yes. All of that."

"I never knew you liked other women."

"I didn't, either." She glanced away. "Still not sure I really do, although that was pretty fun."

"Well, you don't have to decide right here and now," I said. "Come on. Let's get home."

Chapter 16

When we got back to the house, it seemed wrong that it was so normal. Like it wouldn't have been surprising to find the place on fire or something.

But Bobby was still there, parked as usual in front of the Xbox. Our dog came around, wondering where we'd gone. Even the dishes from dinner were still there in the sink, waiting to be washed—because of course our teenage son wouldn't take it upon himself.

Standing at the sink, doing those dishes as Laura swept the floor and put away the placemats, I could almost pretend like what I'd just watched was a dream. But then our eyes would meet, pink would spring into Laura's cheeks, and I knew that it was very real.

"I'm going to take a shower. See you up there," said Laura. I shivered as she ran her hand across my shoulder blades.

My hands actually shook as I finished up the last of our dishes. Goosebumps formed across my arms when I slotted the last plate into the dishwasher and shut the door, and I had to take a deep breath to calm myself before going to wish Bobby goodnight.

One of the benefits of our son taking the basement bedroom was privacy—on both of our parts. We wanted to give him his space, and while I hadn't considered it until now, it was nice to have our own.

"Hey, kiddo, I'm headed up to bed," I said.

Bobby was focused on his Xbox, where he ducked and weaved through a Call of Duty map with his friends. He looked up at me, smiled, and nodded without saying a word. A moment later, his on screen avatar caught a bullet and the respawn timer came up.

"Sorry about that," I said.

"Don't worry about it, Dad. We're getting crushed anyway."

"Night. Don't stay up too late."

"Night, Dad. I won't."

I shut the door behind me and ascended the stairs, my heart beating like a bird's. Part of me half-expected to walk in to find Laura in her regular pajamas, her Kindle in her hand, her eyes droopy with sleep.

When I opened the door, though, Laura was just stepping out of the bathroom, steam and the clean smell of the shower billowing behind her.

She had just a white, terry cloth towel wrapped around her, and it took all of my willpower not to pull it off.

“Feel better?” I asked.

“More human, yes.”

“My turn. I could use some more human.”

“Don’t be long,” she said suggestively.

I almost skipped it, but I really, really needed to get clean. Stepping beneath the spray, my thoughts went to what I’d witnessed, which were already feeling too surreal to be real. Laura had done it. She’d actually let another man gather her in his arms, pull her close, strip her and use her and make her scream.

This was always where we were headed—from the moment I followed Dane to Jessica’s house and watched them through their bedroom window. It could have gone so many directions, but I knew, deep down, that it would end up here.

Well, maybe not exactly *here*. Not with Jessica involved. Not with me watching from the shadows. I’d prepared myself to come home one day to a confession from Laura—*I went running this morning with Dane and we kind of...*

That confession was like a lash—the pain, the pleasure, the denial of being involved. This was sweeter. This was more inclusive, and by the time I stepped out of the shower, I knew that it was also the *only* way Laura would have consented.

Toweled off and clean, I stepped into the bedroom, spa-like and peaceful. Soft music played on her iPhone. Scented candles filled the room with soft, flickering light. In the center of the bed, beneath a thin, flat sheet of Egyptian cotton was the shape of my wife, waiting for me.

I dropped my towel, my cock already more than halfway hard. Laura pulled the sheet aside as I pounced into bed. Like I was twenty again. Like we were new to the whole sex thing.

“Careful. Go slowly, please,” she sighed as I pressed my cock against her pussy. “I’m still a little sore.”

“We can do this later—”

“No. I need it. I need to feel you inside me. To know that you still want me.”

I chuckled as I sank into her. I was the hardest I’d been in years. “I still want you.”

“I can feel that. You feel so big.”

“You can tell, after fucking Dane and his monster dick?”

Laura shuddered as I pressed to the hilt. “Oh yeah. Everything’s so much more sensitive right now.”

She may have been more sensitive, but our neighbor had stretched her out—something that should have made me squirm with insecurity. Instead, it delivered another rush of excitement, ratcheting up my need to be close to her, to be inside of her.

“Go slower,” she laughed, pushing on my hips as I tried to nail her to the mattress.

“Sorry,” I groaned, reining myself in as best I could. I brought my lips to hers, putting my passion into the kiss. It worked. Kind of. When I broke it, she was still laughing.

“It’s okay. I like it. Just...a little much right now.”

Because you were fucked twice by another man, she didn’t need to say.

She said, “I still can’t believe we just did that.”

‘We.’ I liked the ring of it. “It was great.”

“Mm.” I fucked her slowly, her strange-feeling pussy rippling around me, wet and warm. “I’m glad you were there with me.”

“Me too. I’m not sure I would have believed it otherwise.”

We made out some more, frolics in the warm reclaim of our love, of our bodies. No more talk of what went on, although it was present on both of our minds as surely as the scent of candles.

Laura came quietly—not the screaming, moaning climax of earlier, but a gentler one, no less powerful. It was intimate, and I watched her work through it, coming out lazy and droopy-eyed on the other end.

“You’re watching me.”

“Haven’t you learned, it’s what I do?”

Laura giggled, nuzzling my nose. She kissed me, flopping onto the pillow as her face grew serious.

“What?”

She sighed, searching the ceiling behind me, where our fan spun sluggishly, as if the air was too thick to stir, clogged by her thoughts. Finding something—courage, maybe—she dragged her eyes back to mine. Even in the flickering candlelight, I could see how blue they were as they fixated on me with nervous intensity. “For a second, I was worried that you’d...”

She trailed off again, biting her lip.

“Leave? Oh, Laura, are you crazy?”

“Well, I’m feeling pretty crazed right now.” She sighed. “And it wouldn’t be the first time someone’s had a fantasy that should have stayed a fantasy.”

“Honestly, I wasn’t sure. Now I know.”

“I’m glad you were there. That was the best part—looking up and seeing you watching me.” She shivered.

“Like I said, it’s what I do.” My gut fluttered as I formulated my next question, unsure of how to ask. Knowing I needed to. I went with humor and messy metaphor. “So now that you’ve had a taste of the forbidden fruit, you think you’ll be able to resist it again?”

I smiled. I played it off as a joke. Laura saw right through it. Saw it for the deep and equally silly question that it was. “Will I completely lose my inhibitions every time I’m around Dane? As much as Dane thinks he’s God’s gift, you know that I won’t.”

It’s like everything snapped into focus. Laura was still Laura, and as earth shattering as her orgasms had been, she was still my wife, and I was still her husband. A team.

“You can, if you want to.”

“Ah, now the real reason for your question.” I couldn’t deny it if I wanted to—not with my cock still buried deep inside her, or the way it surged as I gave her permission to keep playing.

“I mean, now that we know I’m not going to freak out and all,” I said.

Laura blinked up at me. “You heard what I told Dane, didn’t you?”

“Uh huh. And I think it’s probably a good idea to keep him in his place. Man is too blessed in this life for him to start stealing some of mine.”

“He certainly is blessed in some departments,” Laura said, mostly to get a rise out of me. It worked. “So you want me to find some other stud out there...”

“Yes. Your ideal man.”

“My ideal, huh?”

I actually wasn’t sure who her ideal was, now that it was out in the open. It just meant more things to discover. More secrets to learn.

“Or ideal woman,” I said.

Laura grew bashful. “I told you, still not sure how I feel about that.”

“Looked like you were feeling pretty good, but sure. We don’t have to go there yet.” I made love to her slowly, drawing out the moment. “My point is, if another situation should come up...”

“So if that hot barista at Starbucks asked me if I wanted a double shot of espresso, I could tell him I thought he’d never ask?” The only “hot barista” that I could think of at our local Starbucks was about twenty-five, very fit, and definitely black. Was that her ideal man? Did my wife have a thing for black guys?!

“Mm, you like that idea,” Laura sighed. She ran her hands down my back, feeling my ass. “I do, too.”

“I’ve seen the way he looks at you,” I said. That was actually true, and he wasn’t alone. “Maybe I should send you out tomorrow morning. Going to need some coffee after tonight.”

“Mm. I could be up for that, although...I may be sidetracked until well into the afternoon.”

“Oh, yes, Laura.” The love-making lull over, I started thrusting. If she was sore, she didn’t tell me to stop, her own soft cries joining our slapping bodies. “You could take all the time you need. As long as you come home and tell me all about it.”

“And what would you like to hear?”

“How he kissed you.” I squirmed, but pushed on. “How he put his hands all over you.”

Laura moaned, her excitement awoken.

“How he pinned you against the wall and fucked you.” That *was* a fantasy I knew she had—one I hadn’t been able to fulfill even at my strongest.

“Michael,” she cried, her voice cracking.

“Laura...ah...”

“Come, baby. I want to feel your come.”

I was back in that room, back in memory, not fantasy. Watching Laura join Dane Armstrong. Watching him kiss her. Watching him fuck her. I saw her in his lap, facing him as he sat in the chair, their bodies covered in sweat like a pair of thoroughbreds at the end of a wild race. Panting. Shivering. Moaning.

I came as that image burned itself on my brain. This may never happen again, but I’d always have that.

“Ah, Laura, I love you. I love you so much.”

“Yes. Yes! Fuck me so...uh...so good!”

*

“So the barista, huh? I didn’t know you like your, um, coffee hot—”

“Don’t—”

“—and black.”

“—say it.” Laura groaned. “I can’t believe you said that.”

“You’re the one with the attraction.”

“I should never have said a thing. Now you’re going to obsess every time you find a Starbucks coffee cup in the trash.”

I laughed. “Probably.”

Laura joined me in laughter, even as she rolled her eyes. When the moment passed, though, she looked more thoughtful. “Michael, I just want to manage expectations.”

I cut her off. I knew where this was going. I even agreed with it. But there was no sense putting a finality on this moment. At least not tonight. “I know, tonight was special. A once in a lifetime experience. I don’t expect you to be any different tomorrow than you were today.” I kissed her. “So don’t expect me to be any different, either.”

She grinned, getting me immediately. “So watching me have a threesome with our neighbors didn’t get that fantasy out of your system?”

“No more than it did yours.”

“Well, what are we going to do about that?”

“How about we take one moment at a time.”

Epilogue

Laura didn't end up having a fling with the barista—not that I actually thought she would. She didn't meet up with Dane, either. Even to run—although I'll admit that there were a few times when I'd be at work and let my mind wander. Dane would bump into Laura, she'd invite him in for coffee, and the next thing they knew, they were naked, fucking each other silly in the master bed.

It never happened, yet I still came home on those days, inspecting the sheets. Had she changed them? Was there any evidence of indiscretion? Never.

I suppose if there was a negative outcome, it was that new suspicion that seemed to lace everything. It wasn't due to trust issues. It wasn't even jealous paranoia. Not really. I liked to think of it in more optimistic terms—if I could actually get away with calling a hidden affair optimistic. Now that we'd crossed the line, now that things weren't just fantasy, I carried the hope, dim as it was, that maybe, just maybe, it could happen again.

Probably not with Dane though.

Especially after he got caught fucking Ellen Potter by her husband, Trevor, who drove his SUV through Dane's front door. Talk of the town, that was, and Dane made himself scarce as his "house was being repaired." Laura couldn't resist the poetry in that action—"Not sure it's a house that can ever be repaired."

About a month after the encounter at the Kingston Community Center for the Arts, the Earlys invited us over to dinner—Laura, me, Bobby. With the boys there, I knew it wouldn't get that weird, but it was still the first time I'd seen either of them since that night.

"Maybe we should tell them that we're busy," I suggested when Laura first broached it as we were emptying the dishwasher.

"And just delay this? Honey, they live in our neighborhood. They're not going away, and neither are we. We need to face this problem at some point."

"Or not? Just, you know...pretend that it was all a dream." Then something occurred to me. "You and Jessica talked about it?"

"Of course."

I sighed. Of course they had. Laura wasn't one to let a thing like that linger unaddressed—especially a thing like having a threesome with your good friend.

“Did the two of you...?” My heart began to race, even at the thought of it.

Laura began drying the pots in the dish rack, eying me over her shoulder. “Did we get all hot and bothered, rehashing it?”

“Did you?”

“Well, we *were* hanging out by her poolside, wearing bikinis. And you know how good she looks in that little black one.”

“You were?”

Laura chuckled the towel at me. “Get your mind out of the gutter,” she said with a laugh. “No, we were having coffee. Both of us remained clothed. And no one had an orgasm.”

“Sounds boring.”

Laura rolled her eyes, smiling, and went back to putting the dishes away. “But we did talk. Otherwise, things would be weird. And we decided that we all should get together. It would be good.”

“Did you tell her how it all started? Like, with us following her back to her house—”

“You mean how *you* spied on her first?” She needled me. “No, that’s a thing I’m going to take to my grave. But we did talk through a lot of other stuff. Like how she saw you watching us.”

“Oh, right.” I’d actually completely forgotten about that detail, and immediately told her as much.

“Uh, huh. Would have been good, knowing that first you know. But it’s all good. We worked it out.” She wrapped her arms around me. “Although she did make some joke about how we owed Jared now.”

“So she told him about it?”

“Oh yeah. Definitely.”

I groaned. Even though we shared the same fantasy, it was still deeply personal to me. Discussing it with another guy felt like a betrayal to it, weirdly. But Laura was right, we needed to get past this hump, this first meeting, or it would be forever awkward.

*

“So you like watching your wife fuck, too, huh?” Now that Jared knew that we were of like minds, he seemed to have no problem coming right out and tackling the subject directly. This was a lot more inline with the former Marine, refreshing on the one hand, extremely awkward on the other. “Pretty amazing, yeah?”

We were going to hang out around the pool, but the weather hadn’t cooperated, sending us a warm, summer shower, so we were on the screened-in porch.

“Yeah. Amazing is one way to describe it.”

Jared tipped his head back and grinned. “I remember my first time. Fuck, man, we must have fucked three times a day after that. For like the next six months.” He sipped his beer. “I had no idea you two were like that, though.”

“We’re not. I mean, not really.” I rubbed the back of my neck.

“You’re still together,” he said. “And you two seem happy, so I say fuck it. Be who you want to be.”

“So when we were at Regionals, why didn’t you just talk to me then?”

“Well, it’s not exactly the kind of thing you come out and say, right? ‘I get off watching my wife fuck other guys.’”

“I see what you mean. Not exactly a common fantasy.”

“And yet here stand two guys who have it.”

I wondered if it was sheer coincidence, or if this man was partially at fault. Before this summer, I hadn’t even known what a hotwife was, and I’d certainly never thought about Laura straying. Now, I thought about it all the time.

“Do you ever get worried,” I asked. “That things will get out of hand? Or that Jessica will...I don’t know. Fall for someone else?”

Jared chuckled. “Not really. It’s not going to end well for any guy who tries to get between us. Jessica can be a real slut, but she’s my slut.”

I restrained myself from reacting to him calling his wife a slut, although every ounce of me wanted to cringe. It just underlined how different we were. Still, Jared did have some helpful things to say.

“Word of advice. Talk to Laura. Communicate. Jess and I talk all the fucking time. If things get too intense with someone, we talk about that, too.”

“Has it happened?”

“Oh, sure. We’ve been doing this for a while now. It ebbs and flows.”

“With Dane?”

Jared laughed. “That dude is too into himself for me to be worried. It’s the quieter ones you need to watch out for. Remember that.”

“Thanks, but... I don’t think... I mean, it was more of a once-in-a-lifetime thing. You know? Stars lining up and all that.”

Jared grinned. “They’ll line up again. Trust me. And when they do, talk about it.”

Jessica and Laura came out onto the patio, armed with glasses of wine and mischievous smiles. “What are you two talking about?” Jessica asked.

“Astronomy,” Jared said, putting his arm around his wife.

“Dorks,” she teased. “*We* were talking about guys.”

Jared chuckled. “Of course you were.”

Laura looked at me, her face red. I wondered how much wine she’d had already. “Anyone in particular?” I asked her.

Jessica answered for her. “Apparently Laura’s got a fan in her new writing workshop. Like a genuine, Laura Richards fanboy.”

Laura’s blush deepened. So maybe it wasn’t the wine. Her second workshop had just started, just the night before, but she hadn’t mentioned anything about this. “Oh?” I asked her.

“And apparently, he’s good looking,” Jessica interjected.

“I never should have said a thing.” Laura looked like she wanted to hide her face. Instead, she looked at me timidly. “It’s nothing, really. He, just, has read my books is all.”

“And he’s good looking.”

Laura’s smile was shy. “I wouldn’t throw him out of bed.”

I glanced at Jared and Jessica, who were suspiciously silent as they watched our exchange. Jared had a Cheshire Cat grin plastered to his face. He whispered something to Jessica, who smiled and nodded.

“So...” Laura’s smile turned mischievous. “When do you start traveling to soccer tournaments again?”

About the Author

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Find me online at www.kennywriter.com, or follow me on Twitter at [@kennywriter](https://twitter.com/kennywriter). I also operate hotwifebooks.com, which may or may not look like crap right now.

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